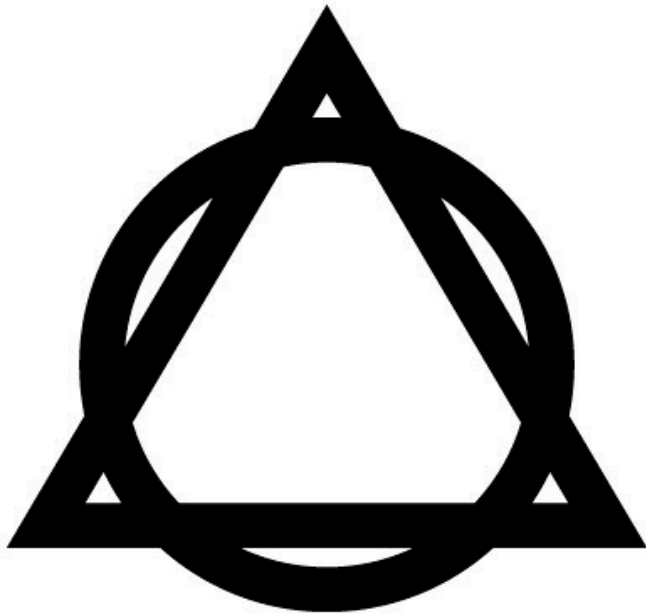


The Crossroads



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If you have any questions email theauthor@circleandtriangle.co.uk

This book is dedicated to
Roger, John, Paul,
Dave, Leonard, Bruce,
three wise Bobs
and all the artists
who taught me how to live

and it is for my children
who gave me a reason
to continue doing so

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God was created to offer
unconditional love
to those
our world has forgotten

Religion has written
conditions to that love

Prologue

Phil Davidson's parents were from Bristol, though a combination of his mother being called away for work and a shortage of beds in the local maternity ward meant he was born, at 6am on the 6th of June, in the nearby town of Barnstable. That night, in the deep summer skies, the silver trail of a comet was visible as it plunged through the inky depths of space. Sadly, no wise men arrived bearing gifts for the baby or his parents. It was rumoured that they were killed in a war over oil, though the truth was never established.

Phil was blessed to have spent his younger years in world without the internet. He read a lot, looked out the window, watched birds hop along the branches of the apple tree in his garden, and stared as squirrels leapt across the lawn and scampered up the trunk. This meant that, unlike children born ten or fifteen years later, he grew up processing the real world, without the distractions of constant screens gleaming at him.

He was a painfully reserved child who spent hours locked in his room dreaming up worlds for himself while doodling on sheets of paper. In his mind, he played games and chased monsters and exploded buildings or built civilisations, but he did it all alone. He learnt, he dreamt, he imagined... but he remained deeply rooted inside himself.

For his 9th birthday, his dad, who was a passable carpenter himself, bought him a woodworking kit with the intention of teaching him some of the skill - in his defence it was a very real intention, though nothing came of it and the kit remained untouched. His mother - an HR officer, and the main breadwinner - chose his clothes, dressing him up like the nice, quiet boy she'd always wanted: collared shirts over a sweatshirt, chinos, inexpensive trainers. She was insistent that he

looked the part, but didn't seem particularly interested in teaching him his lines.

As an adult he described himself as having been shaped by parents who seemed as detached from their own lives as they were from their only son. In one story he shared with a journalist years later, Phil was taken to London to see some friends of his father's perform in a band. After the gig, his parents - who were constantly at odds - left the venue and their twelve year old son behind, only noticing him gone after they were on the road and heading for home.

They returned in the early hours of the morning to find Phil propping up the bar and talking to the staff about John Lennon after the Beatles. The barman was so impressed with Phil's knowledge of the legend's solo career that he could still recount details of the event to journalists almost twenty years later.

A lot changed when Phil was thirteen and his parents divorced. Though the split felt inevitable, it was really just a case of two icebergs drifting apart, the aftermath was terrible. His mother assumed she'd take her son, though it was an assumption rather than a desire; his father decided that he'd rather she didn't have him. It ended up in court, though Phil didn't see any of it. His only involvement was a single interview with a social worker who confirmed that his mother was capable. If that was the case, then there was really no case to be heard. His mother won and Phil went to live with her.

Though weekends were reserved for time with his dad, the change in his father was real. He'd always been prone to fits of temper, that was true; and he'd always enjoyed a drink, that was undeniable; and he'd often been known as someone who would rant and rave about the most inconsequential things. He was predictably unpredictable, and so, it was no surprise that the loss of his son cut him so deeply that their weekends together would often be spent with his dad drinking and ranting and raving.

"This is my house son!" he'd reassure Phil, emphatically. "You can do what you want round here. You can be anyone you wanna be. The fucking courts don't have no say in here!" He looked around at the yellow, smoke-stained walls of his living room, where net curtains always dulled the light and dark carpets absorbed what was left. "I mean, it may not be perfect but it least it's ours. And she can't take that away. And we'd rather be here, wouldn't we? We're fucking Kings in here!" He looked across at Phil, with defiance on his face, a beer in his hand and classic rock, the real heartbeat of his house, pumping in the background.

They grew apart as the years passed, until in the end there was

almost nothing left.

However, despite the pain of the divorce, there was a lot that Phil should have been happy with: he was never in want for anything, after all. He was well fed, clothed, housed; he attended school with his uniform ironed. But the emotional starvation of his youth meant that, over the years, the painfully reserved child became a painfully introspective young man, who walked everywhere, thinking constantly.

It wasn't that he was anti-social: he could talk to people and was known as a friendly, positive student throughout his schooling; but he didn't build anything lasting. He was occasionally invited to parties, but became skilled at avoiding anything that would have required prolonged exposure to other people. He liked some people, but preferred to keep them at a distance; because really he loved to dream and didn't like anything that pulled him out of that space.

As a teen he would sometimes tell whichever of his parents was supposed to be minding him that he was going to visit a friend but really just wander the streets, lost in thought.

Often, he'd find himself sitting on the Portway or in Leigh Woods and staring down the Avon Gorge to the Clifton Suspension Bridge and dreaming of a war between the natural world and the steel and smoke of industry. In his mind it was a Tolkienesque battle where trees uprooted themselves to confront concrete tower blocks, while animals uniformly turned on their human overlords.

As he grew into young-adulthood, Phil became more comfortable with his desire for solitude and began to seek out spaces where he could be alone. His favourite was the Arnos Vale cemetery, a one hundred and seventy year old burial ground where bracken grew in thick, twisted, skeletal arms and, if you listened closely enough, and dreamt deeply enough, you could hear the dead breathe in their sleep.

And so it was here, on his eighteenth birthday, that Phil met someone who would one day return to change his life.

At first Phil had thought he was homeless: he was ragged and wore no shoes; he was clearly drunk and his hair was matted; his face was unshaven and his were eyes bloodshot. But he was well spoken and passionate, though he veered between drive and despair.

"No-one even *remembers* me!" He barked, pacing in front of the bench Phil sat on. "But I am inside you *all...*" Then he leant forward and growled through spit and clenched teeth: "I am Graham *fucking* Hall!"

And then he suddenly withdrew, in something like self-pity, and

turned his head away and down: "Now you've left me to rot." He didn't make a lot of sense but his energy was hypnotising. "But I'll come back. And I'll see you through, and what you'll do will be remembered from now until forever more!" Then he stepped forward, and before he could be stopped, he placed his palms around the back of Phil's head and pulled his face deep into his stomach and mumbled: "I am Graham Hall; I am the pain that lives within. Remember me. I'll see you through."

He held him there for a moment, Phil was too shocked to do anything, and then he turned and walked away, stumbling over himself as he went.

As is often the case with strange incidents, Phil pushed Graham Hall far from his mind, though when he returned home that evening he wrote his first lines of verse:

*Somewhere below the noise of the world
is a gentle, silent sound;
like a river flowing underground...*

The Wilderness

*And so I walked through the fires of hell
delighted with the enjoyment of genius
which to Angels look like torment and insanity*

- I -

Phil first met Bill in a record shop on the North Laines, in Brighton. He'd just finished work and he stamped the soil off his boots before he entered the shop, glad to leave the noise of the street behind.

The Laines had been busy that day. The usual rainbow of hippy flags and street performers were all out to enjoy the sun, and he'd had to weave around them as he headed to the store. He didn't resent them for not working, their CCS score was high enough for them to get by and some of these guys would have been doing well for themselves. They weren't bad people by any stretch. They made the online exercise routines and motivational videos that had become the bread and butter of the post crash economy.

Three people approached him for Attention, each preaching their own sense of progress.

"Hey pal - Follow me: I'll get you firm abs in three week with one simple routine! Guaranteed to raise your CCS!" said one, reaching out for Phil and almost grasping at his top.

"You want the truth - send me a Like!" said another, with a conspiratorial nod. "This is everything the mainstream press won't tell you!"

"You wanna know how to get around Pilot? I'm your man. I know the algorithm and with these there simple tricks your posts will be your payday!" The last one went so far as to block Phil's path. "Mate, listen to me: you want Credit... honestly," he leant in close. "I got a system man. Perfect. Guaranteed. Enough to get you some good pussy, eh...? Bet you don't see much of that..."

That was far enough for Phil. "Fuck off, you cunt!" He barged past

him and carried on his way. Then he felt his phone vibrate and knew that he'd been reported. Whoever else the guy was, he was probably in enough Credit for a negative Engagement to impact Phil and he got annoyed at himself for losing his temper.

He fucking hated guys like that. The whole idea of the CCS was to create a system of financial reward that was based on social benefit. But there were always gamers who came along and broke the system. There was nothing good you could give humanity that it couldn't turn to shit. AI should have been the best invention ever, but it was no surprise that people like that twat-bag had dedicated his life to breaking it.

Phil didn't Connect with any of them. He hardly reached out at all, which is why he still topped up his minimum Civil Credit Score with a job as a gardener. It was the only way to get by, but he also enjoyed the work. It kept him outside, and got his hands dirty and he was largely left alone.

He hated this mess. He hated the way the world worked, and the way people pretended it was all ok. He kinda knew that was why he spent his time listening to old music, from back in the days when people used to dream as though the world could still be changed.

He was slowly flicking through some scuffed Leonard Cohen records and listening to an old MP3 player on shuffle when Bill suddenly appeared at his shoulder.

"Cohen's great," Bill said; and though the line came out of nowhere - and although Phil had never seen Bill before - it didn't make him jump. In fact he barely even looked across; it was almost as though Bill's voice had come from somewhere inside of him.

"But you're similar," Bill went on. "Bitter searching of your hearts."

Phil laughed, though the line took him close to a part of himself where he kept memories of his father and he was lost momentarily. He looked across and into the eyes of the man standing next to him; almost leaning into him. For a long time his mind became empty, he was slightly spun out, and then - for the briefest moment - it was his father in front of him, as he used to be, years ago; and then it wasn't. It was the stranger again.

"You gonna ring them bells Phil?" Bill asked, squaring up slightly. "Let some light into this hell-hole of an existence?"

Phil withdrew, suddenly aware of how close Bill was standing.

He was about to step away when Bill grabbed his arm and held him back. Startled, Phil met his eyes and Bill held them and for a moment

Phil was lost in them and he didn't like it. Suddenly, everything that was warm and paternal about him switched and Phil saw a glimpse of fiery rage. "Remember Graham Hall, Phil," Bill growled, through clenched teeth. Then he let go of Phil's arm and something like regret washed across his face. "Remember Graham Hall..." he repeated. "And there is still a chance that we can save your people."

Phil stared at him, wide eyed, and fearful. Bill looked around the shop, nervous and almost in a panic. He turned to look back at Phil and smiled briefly, sadly, and then turned and left in a hurry.

Despite the strangeness of the situation, Phil's eyes drifted down to the floor as the name echoed around in his head.

Phil *did* remember Graham Hall.

Where did he remember him from?

The name touched something deep and painful, and although he couldn't quite grasp it, he wanted to.

His eyes drifted down the display as he heard Bill's voice seem to echo around his head: "Remember Graham Hall... remember Graham Hall... Find a still, silent place and remember Graham Hall... remember Graham Hall."

- II -

Graham Hall... Graham Hall... who the fuck was Graham Hall? It rang a bell but nothing more.

He'd searched up the name a half hour later, after he'd got back home again. The only reference was a Wikipedia entry about a little known musician from the 60s who was known for his angry verse and gravelly voice. That made sense - and it meant it *was* from his dad. There was a list of albums in the entry - *Broken Seen*, *The Rabid Monk*, *Traveller Scholar Poet* - but not much more.

He started his computer and opened his journal and stared at the cursor for a while. Then he went to the fridge and poured a glass of wine. The sun was setting and he didn't have work the next day so maybe he had some time to remember. For the first time in a while, he felt like he had a purpose.

Broken Seed, that had done it.

I'm your broken seed... that was a line from one of his songs.

He stared out of the window, across a line of grey roofs. *I'm your*

broken seed... you're nothing but an... animal? And I'm your broken seed...

He shook his head. He didn't like it, so he picked up his phone and began to scroll.

An hour later, after he'd opened a bottle of whiskey, he turned to his journal. Within an hour of that starting, he was halfway through the whiskey and back to writing about his ex-girlfriend, Madeleine.

I'm so sorry that I couldn't be more. I'd wanted to reach out, I'd wanted to connect, but I couldn't find the heart to love myself much less face someone else. I'm not surprised I managed to find a way out of that safety; to reject you; to throw it back into your face, and tear it to pieces, and destroy everything we had. If there was only a way back, but this world is not a place for lovers, lovers, brothers or children with mothers...

It was gone three am before he fell into bed.

Though he couldn't remember when or how he'd done it, amidst the incoherent rambling, he wrote a single verse in his journal:

You broke me

Then asked where I went wrong

You cracked my fucking windpipe

Then asked me where's my song?

You tell me the time's come to rise and be a man

But I saw you break my knees while still holding my hand.

- III -

The second time he saw Bill, Phil was sitting on a bench in Preston Cemetery. He'd spent the morning tending to the plots, clearing them of bramble and nettles. At the time, he'd been eating his lunch and staring into the distance and dreaming about changing the world. His current fantasy had been running for a couple of weeks, on and off. He replayed large parts of it like a film he edited as he watched.

In it, he'd been declared a wanted man by the Government for expressing dangerously liberal views and garnering so much support that it seemed revolution wouldn't be far off. Despite Phil's reassurance that fighting wasn't the answer – 'Revolutions only take you back to where you began,' he said with a dry smile during an in-depth exposé on a topical news show – storm clouds were on the horizon.

In one last-ditch attempt to stop him he was captured by idealistic

young hicks (who he suspected were MI6 in disguise) who tortured him, streaming the video live on the internet. He escaped moments before an execution that would have been seen by billions.

After killing his captors – in an act that was also broadcast live – he stole their truck and drove cross-country until he arrived in London, where, with helicopter cameras circling, he was reunited tearfully with his ex-girlfriend, Madeleine, who told him she loved him, and only him, and always had, and always would. And then he died in her arms, because he couldn't imagine a better way to end it.

Phil was just building up to the big reunion – he was driving the truck and nursing a bullet wound in his side – when Bill suddenly piped up: “Amazing places, cemeteries,” he said. Phil jumped like he'd been caught out. “I honestly think,” Bill went on. “That the world would be a better place if people spent a little longer hanging around with dead people.” Then he looked across at Phil and smiled. And despite this outfit - he was dressed in a rough wooden jumper and jeans, and short wellington boots with a ring of fur around the top (he looked like he should be reading the Sunday papers in a country pub somewhere in Surrey) - Bill's smile did nothing to take away from the strange fire that still burnt in his eyes.

“You ok?” Bill asked, after Phil had stared for long enough to establish that he wasn't.

Phil nodded.

Bill waited.

Phil stared.

“You remembered Graham Hall yet?” Bill asked brightly. Then he smiled and waited for Phil to pull himself together.

“You alright?” Bill asked, after a time.

Now that he'd looked longer, Bill's sense of Sunday supplement, academic disarray - his hair was naturally messy and his chin was dusted with silver stubble - gave Phil a feeling of warmth that he felt strangely comforted by. For a moment he remembered the shock of the moment he'd been grabbed in the record store, but... he couldn't quite place it to this guy anymore. There was nothing fearful about him now. And for a moment, he was in the presence of his father again.

“Yeah, I...” He was about to start answering questions when it occurred to him to ask: “Who are you?”

“I'm just... visiting some relatives,” Bill said, gesturing indiscriminately at the graves. “Don't worry.” Then he breathed deeply and that seemed to settle the discussion. Then he repeated his

question: "Have you remembered Graham Hall yet?"

"Well, yeah, maybe..." Phil was unable to shake the feeling that he was still in the middle of a dream. "I wrote this... I remembered it earlier today." He opened the notes app on his phone. "I think it's... yeah."

Bill smiled and took the phone:

*They'll suck you dry, take all you've got
and leave you living but starting to rot
They'll use you, abuse you, and smile while they do
You're just another face to screw
But time's a tricky thing to play
And their time's gonna come someday.*

Bill looked up when he'd finished and smiled softly: "That's the stuff. This is the energy I'm looking for. Don't dwell on the heartbreak. You ned to move on from that."

Phil laughed. "There's a lot of sadness there," he said.

"Well... he was a broken man by the end, that's true. But it wasn't all her fault, it's important to remember that."

"It wasn't her fault at all! It was mine." Phil sort of realised that he wasn't sure if he was talking about Graham Hall or himself here - or maybe even his dad - but he ignored the thought. The chance to talk to someone else about what he was going through was just too alluring.

Bill shrugged a little and looked across the stones. "It's not anyone's fault really. It's not designed this way," he said. "But reality cannot be denied, and sometimes it doesn't matter where the buck stops. If you're in as much trouble as you lot're in, something's gotta be done."

"What do you mean?"

Bill paused a moment: "There's a lot of anger in Graham Hall," he said. "There's a lot of anger in you as well. But don't turn it all inwards. Don't blame yourself mate. You were born a perfect being, and then..." he wafted a hand around at the world... "all this happened and... it broke you. I understand." He looked back at Phil and the fire in his eyes was a warming Christmas hearth: "But don't blame yourself son. It's the world that needs to change."

Phil, who was sitting forward with his elbows rested on his knees, hung his head. "Too right," was all he said.

"Dark days are coming Philip," Bill said. "And you might be the only one who can stop them now."

That took him by surprise. I mean, the whole thing should have done, but for some reason Bill's appearance seemed so natural and the

memories of Graham Hall seemed so real, that he wasn't really taken aback until Bill suggested that he might be the one who could fix it. "What do you mean?" he asked.

Bill was looking across at two mourners standing at a nearby grave, who stared back at him curiously.

"Keep looking back," Bill said. "There's a lot more." He returned Phil's phone. "Hall was really important to your dad," he said, almost as an afterthought. "It might help if you spent some time thinking about him. Try and remember the best of him. Only the best."

Phil didn't reply. The couple seemed to be making a move in his direction which led him to sit upright and wave as though to check that everything was ok.

"I better get going," Bill said and left in a hurry.

Phil watched him go for a long moment, lost in thought. But it wasn't until he walked behind a tree and didn't come out the other side that he took a double-take on how weird the whole thing was.

- IV -

He looked up Graham Hall again online when he got back and re-read the short article on Wikipedia: 1960s British musician, famous for his angry verse. That was him. That was the guy. Acoustic guitar, wandering poet; spoke from the heart, wrote from the hip. He remembered him now; a man with a life so like his own but blessed with the ability to make the pain somehow beautiful.

Phil sat back and tried to remember his house and his dad's records... and his dad, and he tried to place Graham Hall in the middle of it.

Phil's dad had died a few months earlier, alone and in poverty; and although they'd rarely spoken in the years beforehand, the manner of his death - he'd been dead for a week before anyone found him - had hit Phil hard. They weren't bitter, but there was so much left unsaid that they'd grown apart. His dad was deeply resentful, and so was Phil. And although they both agreed that the issue was the mother, the agreement wasn't strong enough to keep them together.

Phil's mum had always maintained that he shouldn't have expected anything different. But Phil knew that wasn't true. She was the abuser: tyrannical, bitterly disappointed in them both, and full of blame.

Phil had barely responded to the news of his father's death, delivered to him by a long forgotten uncle, over the phone one rainy day in November.

Phil said he wouldn't be going to the funeral because of the distance that had grown between them, but the truth was that he didn't want to speak to anyone about his dad. He had his own version of events and he was sticking to them: It wasn't his father's fault, it was hers. She'd worked to be rid of him for years, and had, as far as Phil was concerned, succeeded almost two decades ago. She hated him because he'd tried to stand up for himself, and she simply couldn't have that.

He'd been cold to the fact that he was now an orphan for months. He'd barely known his parents when they were alive and was determinedly non-plussed now they were both dead.

But as he sat and drank, late at night, and searched for Graham Hall amidst the memories, his mind touched on a sadness that became the most powerful thing he'd ever felt. The feeling was accompanied by a rush of adrenaline that was painful but enlivening, and for a long moment he was lost in it.

Despite having his journal, he started a new document in Word. He stared at the blank screen for so long it grew out of focus, his hands lightly brushing the letters on the keyboard.

He could remember his dad's old house in Bristol as being always in shadow, and he moved through it in search of his father. He moved down the blue-walled, purple-carpeted corridor – his mind's eye like a cinematic tracking shot – toward the smoke of the living room, to where his dad was drinking and thinking and listening to Graham Hall.

Then he wrote the word: *I*

Then: *don't*

Then: *want*

Then: *nothing*

And then: *more*

He wrote them out slowly and deliberately, without thinking about the previous one. They were just five words that felt right.

He looked it back over: *I don't want nothing more*

He wondered if it was anymore, *I don't want nothing anymore* but he knew it wasn't. Hall wasn't like him. Hall was braver than him. Hall wanted things, he hadn't given up.

What did Hall want?

A home he wrote

And a hearth

And then he stopped and sat back and took a drink.

Then he arranged the lines and added a word and read:

I don't want nothing more

Than a home and a hearth

And although that was right – he could almost remember the song now: it was just Hall and his guitar with some strings in the background... ah, but that was what was missing: the strings.

Because Hall was a romantic; like a broken romantic.

And a woman to share in the magic, Phil wrote, and his stomach momentarily reeled from the realisation. It was almost enough for him to lose the flow, but before he stopped he tipped over the moment and wrote:

And a red wall to paint

And a life without shame

Don't tell me that that's all too much

After he finished he stayed still for a long time, feeling his body acclimatise itself to a gentle pain that moved around his core. He sat back and read it through twice.

It was Graham Hall. They were real lyrics, he was sure. He finished his beer so he could open the bottle of red he'd bought and lit another cigarette, reading the lines over and over, and searching inside himself for what came next.

It was the feeling he chased. He was touching a place deep inside himself, a place he hadn't felt for years, and the desire to acknowledge it again became all-powerful. It was painful to touch but the pain felt keen and enlivening, and he wanted more.

He stayed up writing until he was so drunk he couldn't see properly and then crashed into bed, pulling the blinds shut to keep out the daylight.

- V -

I don't want nothing more

Than a home and a hearth

And a woman to share in the magic

And a red wall to paint

And a life without shame

Don't tell me that that's all too much

- VI -

Phil had written a lot when he was younger, scribbling on jotter pads that had remained in his mother's loft until her death, and their destruction. More recently, he'd dedicated hours to free-writing in his diary, to hear the sound of his own voice as much as anything. But remembering Hall was different.

Hall was found in a feeling that grew in his guts; a rush of adrenaline that set his heart racing. He felt like something had become alive inside of him, and if he didn't feed it, it would eat him up from within.

It was hungry.

He was an addict.

And then – because he was remembering the lyrics to songs – music began taking shape in his mind: an echo of clean-cut strings and an icy guitar line chilled the corridor that ran through his dad's house like a crooked spine. He could smell the damp carpets, smoke and drink. And his dad was silently listening to Hall pluck strings on his guitar like a funeral march, while a single violin rose above it like a phantom.

It was war like, but intensely sad; like the sound of impotent rage:

Be whoever you are, I can tell you no more,

There's trouble out there, we're heading for a fall,

But that wasn't your fault

You ain't the world

Work for your family, keep hold of your girl

And keep your heart safe,

Given time, it's a pearl

In spare moments in the gardens, he'd trawl the net looking for any other references to Hall but even the Wikipedia article had been removed. It seemed like he was the only person who remembered him now and it became Phil's mission to preserve this work for the world.

He went to a local print shop and printed it up on A4 sheets and began cutting round the words and sticking them to the walls of his flat, designing layouts that would highlight ideas or themes.

Though it was all written by Hall, it seemed like there were whole sections about relationships - and it felt as though the breakdown of

his relationship with Madeleine was written in these lines - and reams about his parents (Hall's parents.) The crossover was astonishing. And now that he could see it all, spread out in lines and stanzas, he could see how clearly the collapse of one had led to the inevitable collapse of the other: he'd inherited his parents' mess and it had doomed his chance of love.

It was all here, in Hall's lyrics:

You say I bring it upon myself,

I know but that's my calling,

And if I brought it down with my two hands

It don't stop the thing from falling.

Eventually he ran out of wall space, and so he started sticking string to the ceiling and hanging pieces of verse in the middle of the room that span gently, like dark dream catchers. As he did this he'd often be reminded of something new, and he'd return to the desk and begin writing again:

Who made these eyes I see with?

At what point was I born?

Who moved the hands I write with

To choose the clothes that I have worn?

- VII -

For forty days and nights he worked incessantly; barely sleeping, rarely eating. When the well was dry, he'd stand in his room and perform verse to the wall, remembering the songs that went along with them.

Over time something changed in Phil, as though the beast he'd awoken was absorbing itself into him and it turned the quiet, uncomfortable, passive man into a quiet, uncomfortable, angry man.

He began to hate his world.

Who were these fucking people?

Who did they think they were?

He often worked on the gardens in Withdean or Roedean or Tongdean; huge houses with long lawns he manicured, and bushes he carefully pruned. He never saw the residents: their gates were opened automatically, security monitored with AI; he held conversations with housekeeping robots who spoke with an imitation of enthusiasm that

made him want to smash them into pieces.

The wealth he saw was astonishing. And generated from what?

Everyone knew it was just a matter of luck; thousands of years of economic development had all come down to a game of musical chairs: if you'd ended up rich after the AI Crash, you were set for life on another level.

Some of these people would have sat on the high end of the Civil Credit Score that determined your monthly payments, though a lot of them wouldn't touch Credit anymore; they were Coined. They worked for the banks, the server centres, and CCTV control rooms; they set the targets, monitored the behaviour, ran the algorithms that monitored compliance. They were the reasons his father's payments had been stopped; the reason his father had died alone, in the Slums.

On those days he didn't work so well at his job. On some of those days he was so angry that he wouldn't do anything. Why was he here, giving his life over to the demands of excess? He hated them all; and not just the rich, but the whole fucking lot of them. He'd stare at the robotic housecleaners patrolling carefully designed living rooms, imagining them as a prison guards, patrolling the perimeter fence.

Besides, he didn't have to work. He had a score still; it wouldn't last him long, that was true, but long enough that he could do something that would be remembered. He wouldn't turn to anything as petty as Attention Grabbing; he'd rather go down in a blaze of glory.

On some of those days, he left work feeling ten feet high; his resolution making him a king amongst men. But then he'd get home and Hall would be there waiting for him; his aching heart would be there again, still searching for love amidst the shame. It was a shot of cold truth that reminded him of his place.

On those days he'd go out walking, and get some distance, and try to forget about Graham Hall.

He'd remind himself that he couldn't lose this job.

He had nothing else.

He had no-one.

He would remain silent and play the game and then die alone.

He was his father's son.

- VIII -

In the end, the decision was made for him.

His manager was young, with a head of curls like a wire brush. He was clean shaven and wore a suit. His hands were soft and had never touched dirt in their lives. He didn't smile as Phil entered the room, and throughout their interview never once looked like anyone other than someone who enjoyed what they do.

"Your work is simply below par," he said. "When you do anything at all."

He gestured to a monitor and tapped his keyboard. The video showed Phil, in one of the gardens in Withdean. Phil was standing, stock still, and staring at the house. The bushes near to him rustled gently in the wind, but to look at Phil it could almost have been a photograph. Dominic let the video play for a while before speaking again.

"Plants do respond well to humans, and so, by chance, you had a good opportunity here. One of the few real jobs that remain. But I'm afraid that we won't be continuing with your contract." He smiled. "I'm sure you understand."

The Streets

*I wander thro' each charter'd street
near where the charter'd Thames does flow
a mark in every face I meet
marks of weakness, marks of woe*

- I -

After the meeting, Phil returned home a broken man. There was no way back from this. He'd end up alone in the Slums, where UBI took the form of processed food from soup kitchens and housing in damp riddled, rodent infested estates. He knew there was joy there, influencers often posted videos of singalongs and football games - working class pursuits that kept the middle classes' spirits high. But he also believed that they were mostly lies.

People were people, they found a way to get by, but that wasn't what he wanted. He didn't want to get by and survive and smile through the pain; he wanted the place to burn. And for a while he allowed himself to dream that he could... that he was the renegade voice in the darkness again, that the State Department hunted down and killed for being a threat to the Establishment. For a moment, he soared.

But then he looked around at the flat, at the walls of ranting lyrics and the pile of empty whiskey bottles and wine boxes and beer cans and saw the stain in his bed where he'd once pissed himself in his sleep and he knew that he wasn't that man and this wasn't that life. He was waste of space, like his dad; a drunken rant that screamed into the void and then fell over and died.

He took one last look around the walls and for a moment dreamt that someone would find them and see him for who he was and then he left the flat and walked to the seafront where he could watch the waves and smoke. The thought that was clearest to him was that he didn't have to go on. He couldn't change the world, it wasn't his to

change, but it was his life and he had the right to end it. If he couldn't find peace in life, he could still find peace.

It was a cold night and the wind was strong, but he was protected by the awning of the Victorian shelter. He listened to the wind rattle the structure and watched the sea throw itself to the shore, and with each relentless oceanic breath he felt his mind grow clearer and he felt the fear recede. It was his life, the only thing he truly owned, and it was his right to end it; that was one right that they couldn't take away.

"Ya's fuckin' think..." growled a voice from beside him. "Ya's fuckin' think that they... fuckit. Don't think too much."

Phil heard a strong breath of smoke and saw the plumes but only very slowly looked around.

In front of him was an ageing drunk with skin the colour of a blood orange and a beard like a bed of nails. He growled from somewhere deep in his throat in agreement with himself. He was sitting on the next bench along – a gap of less than half a meter – with a guitar around his neck and no shoes on his black, tarred feet. He had the end of a hand-rolled cigarette hanging out of his mouth, stuck to his bottom lip. It looked like his entire frame was held up by a bottle of whiskey that rested on his knee.

"Drink," he barked, in a voice like Father Jack, and gestured to Phil, before swigging from his whiskey.

Phil felt slightly out of body as he raised his bottle of wine.

The man started playing something simple on the guitar. It was easy and restful and Phil enjoyed hearing it. Then he went up a key and hung a chord and Phil was prompted into drinking again.

Then the man began singing:

*"You're a bloodhound, watching from afar,
don't believe in your self image
don't care who you think you are..."*

and Phil remembered it.

"That's fucking Hall!" he shouted, and was hit by an intense rush that reminded him of the one he felt while he was writing, but this one pumped clean through him with a thud like electricity. It dragged him out of his daze and right back into the moment.

"Yeeaahh," laughed the old man, nodding.

"You know him..." Phil was trying to place this now.

It was Hall. Hall was real.

"Not a lotta people remember Graham 'all these days," the old man said. "But he was a good lad. An angry man, but a good one."

"You're a cancer," Phil said, continuing the verse. "Your whiskey burnin' breath, is all you've ever left me with, the summit of your wealth." The old man picked up the song at the end and carried on playing for a few bars.

"It's the Bloodhound," he said. "It's Graham 'all."

"Who is he? I looked him up but..." Phil was suddenly lost in the old man's hands that ran themselves along the guitar, and for some reason he came to believe that he could do that.

But he couldn't play guitar.

He'd owned a guitar once, but he'd sold it when he gave up learning to play a bar chord. He'd always wanted to play guitar though.

"You wanna go?" the old man asked.

"No," Phil replied, shaking his head. "I can't."

"Yeah you can," the old man said and passed the instrument across.

Before Phil really thought about what he was doing he'd hung the guitar onto himself. While he was still adjusting to it being there, the old guy had begun blowing a harmonica as though he was delivering lyrics through it.

Phil's leg was rocking slightly. He suddenly felt quite central to everything, and he didn't like it.

"S'alright mate," the old man said, while tapping a rhythm on his leg. "Jus' fuckin' hit it!" He played a burst on the harmonica between his leg slaps. "Jus' feel the fuckin beat an' hit it."

Phil took a swig on the bottle and put it down and rocked himself slightly to the music. He shook his head gently and remembered the clarity that came from writing – the empty space within where the words found him. He was still feeling for the right place when he realised that his hands had begun lightly strumming the strings.

In a moment of shock he almost lost the beat, but the old man was suddenly staring at him, deep into him, and holding him with eyes so bloodshot they looked like they could leak.

Phil was tied to the song now and the old man's aggression made him play louder.

But he had calm himself and so he took a breath and as he did he felt a warm space grow within him, and around him. He got so lost in the sensation that he began to feel as though he was only hearing the music – just feeling the music – not playing it. It was like when he was writing – they weren't his words, they were Hall's. He was only remembering them.

The old man began to sing:

This ain't magic, it ain't luck,

It's a sign-post to a quick buck;

I'm a mystic sage showin' you the way,

I'm a guardian angel who works without pay,

I'm inviting you down to your destination:

I'm serendipity – not temptation...

And that was Graham Hall as well. Phil had written the verses down a couple of weeks before, and here was someone who could remember the tune. Phil pounded the strings, gradually becoming aware of his left hand that moved deftly up and down the neck. The old man started the next verse, with Phil slowly beginning to mumble along:

I di'n't believe in nothing

And the world di'n't make no sense;

What's the point of action

When it's got no consequence?

So start something new,

Engage in creation:

Become serendipity – not temptation

They were singing together, until Phil realised that the old guy wasn't singing anymore, he was just slapping his thigh, and beaming his toothless grin.

The old man reached around and pulled out another guitar and began plucking at the strings so hard and taught and clean, and he stretched notes so thin that they cut. Phil wanted that. And so the old man picked up on Phil's strumming, taking over the rhythm section.

Phil softened his chords a little in response. He plucked a simple scale, and then a progression, and then a more complex one, and then he began hanging the notes when it felt right and then he began to sing again.

They played together until the grey dawn turned into a grey day.

The man introduced himself as Old Nick.

- II -

In the morning Nick took Phil to the station where they caught a train to London.

Phil was talking constantly about how much he'd enjoyed playing and he didn't know guitar was so easy and it was just like when he was remembering Graham Hall and he didn't know that it was so easy to learn stuff and everyone should do it and why didn't everyone play guitar if it was so easy, and everyone should write as well and who was Graham Hall and did Nick have any of his albums?

"Calm down!" Nick drawled, ushering him down the train until they found a seat in a half empty carriage.

"I'm not even tired," Phil was saying, though he was clearly very wired. "I feel alive, you know! For the first time!"

"Don't sleep," Nick replied, softly. "Stay awake. But shut up. And calm the fuck down."

"I'm buskin!" Phil laughed and repeated himself: "I'll be a busker. That's what I'll do! *A Beggin' I Will Go!*" He slapped his thigh and sang a line from the Martin Carthy song.

Nick hushed Phil gently, and said it'd be alright.

Gradually Phil stopped talking, though his leg still rocked constantly. Before long he was silent, with wide eyes darting around the carriage, staring at people who wouldn't look back.

Nick got them off the train quickly when they arrived in Victoria and headed for Pimlico, and then along the south side of the Thames, towards Parliament and the South Bank.

- III -

"It's about power, man, it's always been about power," Nick growled his words, in a concrete corner behind the National Theatre. "They don't care about you! They just want control!" Phil understood him completely.

"I know, I know... We used to work all the time, and then fucking AI came along... but we're still fucking slaves."

"Fuck AI! Fuckit! Fucking clever little tool they've brought into being but has it made your lives easier? Better? They made the machines and now they're your masters, that's all. Robotic fucking drill instructors sent to manage you down. I've seen fucking *slaves* with better lives than most of you've got!" Then he threw himself back and threw his hands in the air: "Of course, some of you are doing ticketty-fucking-boo. Nice fucking lives, but I'm telling you Phil: You leave your

little bubble and there are millions of them, no hope of payments, no hope of a job, no hope for meaning and I'm tell you Phil: They are your *army*. This place is fucked, and we're gonna bring it down my son."

Nick was animated and angry, drunk and shouting. In a moment he opened his arms out wide and slowly span and screamed: "Burn it all!"

He suddenly jumped back and started pacing around and animating his arguments with whirling hands: "And let's face it, this ain't fucking new. You got all these new fangled fucking tin-pot machines but nothing really changes. You're just turning up the power every time. They're still gonna shit on you if they can. But unless you're careful, pretty soon there won't be no way back for ya. Their *grip* is getting tight," he squeezed his fist so hard Phil could imagine blood leaking out the sides. "Pretty soon there'll be no turning back. But I will not fucking have it! I will not."

"I'll bring it down," Phil said, nodding and keen and ready to bite. Lost in Nick's rage. "I'll burn it down I swear!"

"You got this chance lad," Nick said, roughly slapping him on the chest. "You're the one. No'ne fights the system that feeds 'em. But it's done you good and proper. You're fuckin' *homeless* now."

He delivered that last bit hard, and it threw Phil with a burst of something like reality that threatened to bring him down.

Nick didn't help him avoid it, and confronted him instead: "What? You don't fink ya homeless? Lost ya family, you got no job, got no friends, got no girl: *ya ron ya roan my son*. You got noffin'! But stick wiv me and we'll change it. We'll change it lad and we'll bring it down and we'll burn it down and then we'll take the ashes and we'll build it new. I swear we will."

In a moment of ice cold clarity Phil asked the old man an obvious question: "Who are you?"

"I'm Old Nick, and I'm 'ere to 'elp." Then he slurred and raised his cupped hand in front of Phil: "I'll take ya'rart, and I'll turn it inside-out in song and they'll feel ashamed and we'll turn 'em, and we'll change 'em, and we'll beat 'em and raise them up again and I swear we'll change the *fuckin'* world." He let that hang, leaning in close enough for Phil to drink the fumes. "You want that boy? You wanna change the world?"

Phil's body was reeling. His stomach was churning as wave upon wave of adrenaline was pumped into his guts.

"You wanna teach the world to sing, Philip, my son?" Nick asked

with a wicked grin.

"Yes," Phil replied, knowing that the burning would only ease if he followed.

"Then come wi'me," Nick said and led Phil towards the Thames.

- IV -

Later that evening, they were dancing by the South Bank, with Phil leading them in Graham Hall's back-catalogue. Nick had fashioned a sign that read: *Happy and Homeless* and people threw tokens onto it. By half ten they had enough for some more whiskey, but Nick took him to buy chips first.

"The food'll make you tired," he said. "But you gotta eat," he added, almost reminding himself. "Make sure you eat. You can't drink that much and not eat."

Phil ate the chips as they walked down towards London Bridge.

"I know a place down here where you can sleep. You gotta sleep." Nick clearly didn't like the fact, but he led him past The Globe and the Golden Hind, to a spot out of the wind, beneath London Bridge, where he said that Phil would be safe.

"You gotta look after yourself, man, and keep playin', and remember the music you know."

Phil smiled and remembered playing as though it had been a perfect dream. Nick was pacing around while Phil stared up at him all misty eyed.

"I'm gonna help ya Phil," Nick said and crouched down, though he was edgy and eyed the shadows.

Phil couldn't finish the chips.

"So you're gonna take it to 'em, yeah?" Nick confirmed. "But don't fight, ok? You're a teacher, right? You don't gotta solve it, you gotta prove it's wrong, that's all. But not... fucking... *evil* – that shit don't exist man, she made that up, you understand?"

Although Phil only heard Nick's words through a veil of tiredness, the thoughts were clear and he felt secure with them there.

"You gotta tell 'em it's not just *morally* wrong, it's the wrong answer. D'ya understand the diff'rence? It's like a fucking formula and the way you're living don't add up, so it's gonna get worse. D'you understand? But it don't gotta be like this. It could be so much better. You're gonna

make it better.”

Phil’s eyes were closing involuntarily now, and while Nick rambled on he realised that he’d lost consciousness a couple of times.

“I’m gonna help ya Phil. We’re gonna help ya.” Nick was shaking like an alcoholic, and looking around himself, like someone under threat. “But I gotta find Bill. We need Bill.”

Phil’s body was shutting down.

The last thing Phil saw was Nick, curled into a ball, hugging his knees, rocking and staring into the darkness, mumbling: “Gotta get help. Where the fuck is Bill? I gotta find Bill... or she’ll get him first.”

- V -

Earlier that night, another drunk had watched Phil and Nick stumble along the South Bank.

Through bleary eyes he saw them both pass through a puddle left over from the afternoon’s rains, and he smiled at the strangeness of the fact that they left only a single trail of footprints along the banks of the river.

- VI -

By the time Phil awoke, under the bridge and with his arm draped around his guitar, it was past noon and the bustle of London was above him. He sat up and tried to remember what had happened. He remembered meeting Nick and he remembered playing music on the South Bank and getting paid for it, which was nuts because he couldn’t play the guitar - he didn’t even own one.

But he’d come from Brighton with Nick, and he’d slept while cradling the guitar Nick had given him.

It must have... but it wasn’t a dream. He was in London.

He pulled himself to his feet and made his way absently into the crowds that bustled across London Bridge eating food they’d bought from Borough Market and drinking cold pints in the early summer sun.

He patted his pockets and pulled out a handful of Tokens, which meant that he *had* played the guitar. Then he noticed he didn’t have his

bag. Or his phone. Or his keys.

He ran back to where he'd slept but found nothing there.

Nick must have taken them... a cracked phone, some random keys... but then left him with a handful of Tokens... and a guitar. It didn't make any sense.

Phil wanted to go home now. He had enough money for train fare and he figured he'd work it out on the way back. Besides, he needed to get back to work... He had no job. Shit.

Nick had said he was homeless. And Nick had taken his stuff because he was homeless as well. Phil had been hustled... by someone who'd left him in profit? He span out slightly, feeling a little out of body. For a moment he felt himself slip into a panic. He must have had... some kind of a breakdown.

But Nick knew all those Graham Hall songs as well; and Phil had earned money from singing them. And all the Graham Hall stuff had been going on for ages, so that wasn't a breakdown. That would represent a complete change in his ongoing reality. But maybe that's what a breakdown was... maybe that was what madness was...

And besides, he couldn't play the guitar.

The sense of panic at the strangeness of it began to grow. Phil had often had dreams where something central in the fabric of reality broke and the fact it was happening gave him a sense of *deja vu* more than anything else.

It was real... but it couldn't be... he felt like something within his consciousness had been cast adrift and his connection to the world – his trust in his senses – was cracking...

He was pacing now, back and forth, and trying to piece something together when a new fear awoke as he realised how public his agitation was – and how unstable his position was.

There were people everywhere, and he didn't want to be noticed. He was a long way from home, and probably not well. Then he remembered that without a job, very soon he wouldn't have a home. He wanted to turn back the last twenty-four hours and get his job back. He wanted to go back to something normal, but he knew he couldn't.

And then, more than anything, he didn't want anyone to speak to him.

But this was London and as long as he kept his head down and stopped acting weird no-one would.

The day was warm and he heard a laugh in the distance and noticed

a stream of saxophone that moved down the street like a ribbon.

He needed a reason to stop and think. What could he do that was casual enough to buy him some time?

Everyone was drinking.

He was in London.

He'd get a pint.

- VII -

No-one really liked taking Tokens these days, but without his phone he had no access to the last of his Credits. Still, after an awkward moment at the bar she'd agreed and he made it back outside with his drink. He'd had to concentrate hard throughout that though, and the experience made it clear that something wasn't right. There was a space in his head that was so silent it burnt. Like an open wound that throbbed with a pain that was almost enlivening but so horrifically real it hurt.

He remembered thinking suicidal thoughts the night before and wondered if he'd died but couldn't remember killing himself. He remembered a film he'd seen years ago about a guy who'd died in Vietnam but refused to accept the fact. He'd ended up being hounded by ghosts of the past until he was ready to move on... *Jacob's Ladder*, that was it. Purgatory. That's where he was.

At least he'd made himself a guitarist, he thought with a smile. Then he realised how nuts that thought was and pushed it from his mind. Besides, he didn't feel dead, this felt more real than his life had been. He felt the guitar on his shoulders and wondered if he could play it.

If he was dead it didn't matter. None of it mattered.

He sipped his beer and wondered how hard he could push this dream. There was evidence for it, after all. He sat on the curb and rested the guitar on his knee, closing his eyes and breathing and reminding himself that no-one would notice him as long as he didn't act weird. He wasn't out of place.

The instrument felt comfortable and as he held it he remembered playing more vividly. He gently stroked the strings, hearing each one ring. Then he did it again and bent his head down so he could play near silently. He strummed it ever so slightly, causing a perfect ripple of sound that warmed him. He moved his left to another position and

strummed it again, and again the sound was safe and secure. He continued to wander slowly between chords, before he fell back to plucking individual strings in a way that wasn't tuneful but was rhythmic and seemed to mirror some part of himself perfectly.

Then a female voice, that seemed far too close, asked: "Are you alright? Do you mind if I join you?"

Phil looked up and lost his breath as he stared straight into the eyes of the most beautiful woman he'd ever seen: olive skin, dark hair, deep eyes and full lips. She wore an afghan jumper that revealed the shape of a wonderful curve of breast and she smiled gently and softly sat next to him on the curb.

"You've never played guitar before, have you?" she said, with a playful, knowing smile.

Phil was taken aback. She couldn't have known that.

Her smile was warm as she said, very clearly: "You're having a breakdown, Phil. Do you understand what that means?"

Phil was frozen.

"You can't play the guitar," she shook her head gently. "You just *think* you can."

Phil looked around him and someone laughed, loudly, and Phil was hit with a wash of paranoia.

"Do you understand?" she asked him, almost with a warning, and his fear tightened. "You've been on your own for months. Your father died, and now you've finally had the breakdown that's been inevitable for years."

He felt himself spinning, like he was living in the moment before faint but his body wouldn't shut down. The clarity she spoke with brought each obvious conclusion crashing home: Life wasn't a movie: Nothing unusual happened: He'd had a breakdown, that was all.

She laughed a little and Phil knew she was right.

"You look tired Phil," she said.

She had the most loving look Phil had ever seen. He wanted to impregnate her, with himself, and then be raised by her as well. She was his perfect woman.

"Do you know why that is?" she asked. "Do you know why you've made me into the most beautiful woman you've ever seen?" Her face was alight with playful emotion, and Phil almost broke into a mindless, childlike, almost stoned giggle. "It's because I only live inside your head Phil. I'm a part of your breakdown – the same as Bill, and Nick. But we all come from different parts of you. But we're not

real, do you understand?"

It made perfect sense.

"But you know that your mind can sometimes work against you, don't you Phil? So be careful who you trust." She leaned in slightly as though revealing something wonderful. "But you know that you can trust me, don't you."

Phil decided that he wouldn't ever be able to bring himself to betray this woman.

"Have you got somewhere to sleep at the moment?" she asked and for a second all Phil could see were visions of them together and the paradise it would be.

"Why don't you let me look after you a bit?" She laughed. "Come back to my place." And Phil realised that he'd been staring at her breasts the whole time and he shook himself out. She almost seemed to do the same and he was back staring at her chest again.

But as he did so, something shifted slightly and began to doubt this. He leant back, almost drunk with lust ...

... and then he realised that no woman this beautiful would ever make a pass at him.

This wasn't real.

She smiled again – white teeth – her tongue slightly visible.

He wanted her so badly. But it was too much.

He suddenly remembered Madeleine and then... she reminded him of her – something in the way her shoulder dropped, and her hair hung, and a part of her smile. And once he'd seen it they looked even more alike.

"Who are you?" he asked.

"I'm Trina," she said. "Trina Tee..." she shook her head and smiled as though to brush aside the joke. "I'm here to help you."

But as she said that, he began to feel that she was warning him. There was suddenly something threatening about her.

"I know about Bill," she said. "And I know what he made you do, and I know how painful that must have been. And I'm here to say that there is another way. If you trust me, I'll take away the pain because you've suffered enough."

And that touched Phil, because all the writing had been painful. Everything that Bill had awoken in him seemed to celebrate his loneliness, and his sadness. It had made him a homeless drunk and he didn't want to be that. He looked away from Trina, up and down the street.

A pretty girl laughed and pulled her boyfriend into her.

Phil had always hated himself for the years he'd spent alone. He didn't want to be alone again. He missed being loved; he missed Madeleine.

"Come with me," the woman said. "You'll never be alone again. You can be reborn. I'll love you, and care for you and hold you." And she was Madeleine – something in her eyes, her smile. She gestured to the guitar: "But leave that behind. You won't need it anymore."

Phil changed direction again.

"Why?" he asked, though the act of questioning left his chest tight.

"You won't need it," she smiled and added with a laugh: "You're rubbish at guitar anyway!"

The sentiment was warm, but it was painful. He felt like he *had* played the guitar... he didn't want to give it up. He looked down at the instrument, and realised something: "If Nick isn't real," he said. "How come he gave me the guitar?"

Her face changed and for a moment everything that had been warm and welcoming became laced with poison.

"I know Bill," she said. "And I know what he's like."

Phil felt the anger increase.

"He's setting you up, Phil," she said, looking at the ground like it was a painful revelation.

Suddenly, Phil felt himself willing the aggression; like he wanted a fight with her.

"And you were talking to Nick last night, weren't you? About changing the world." Now she began to attack. "You think he can do any of that?"

Phil waited.

"Nick's a drunk. A dreamer. He has no idea what will help you." She laughed, lightly. "Come on Phil, look around! You can't change this! That's madness..."

Immediately, Phil knew that he wouldn't go anywhere with this woman.

Her jaw shifted as she managed patience. "I'm prepared to work with you," she said, "but you won't force this through against us."

"I *won't* stop playing my guitar," he said, his voice laced with the stropmy defiance of an angry toddler.

She looked a little bitten, and the expression aged her slightly which knocked Phil for a moment.

"I *can* play guitar..." Phil said, suddenly charging after his instinct

to attack, with the relish of an angry teenager. "And I'll *fucking* play it!"

"This isn't real!" She looked shaken now. "You're having a breakdown." She reached out for him.

He moved away quickly, not wanting to be touched, and stumbled into the road, scrabbling across the floor.

"We're not real Phil," she growled.

Phil looked back at her, and felt himself turn to ice as she rose to her feet and moved her arm gracefully through a parked car. Phil panicked and shuffled backwards on his elbows and then rose to his feet to defend himself. In a second she moved across the road and now stood in front of him.

"Get away from me!" He turned to run, but she was in front of him again and he fell back in shock.

"I'll still love you. But come back home."

"Get away from me," he growled, and moved towards the guitar.

"You will *not* stand against me!"

He swore at her and grabbed the instrument.

"You can't play that Philip!"

"I can!" he spat, holding it to his chest and turning back to her. "I *can* play the guitar. You're a *liar*! Get away from me!"

"I'm inside you Phil," she said. "You'll never be rid of me."

Phil span out as he realised how deep that truth was, and he rolled forward using the guitar as support. She was right. He could feel her words coming from inside his head, not from out there. He dropped the guitar and put his hands on his temples but couldn't get her out.

"Bill is a selfish drunk and I am not having him back..."

She was a stinging, stabbing pain in his brain and he wanted rid of her.

"I will not have him back here."

"Get out! Getout! Gettout!" he was mumbling, slurring, slapping his head, and screwing his face up in pain.

"You'll suffer and you'll fail," she said, and he felt fingers against his back. "Just like before."

And Phil snapped and turned to his feet ready to hit her.

A man in a suit ducked, and pushed himself away and Phil heard a shout, and a gasp and he realised that the woman was gone and a small crowd of people were standing around him, some cautious, some concerned, a few laughing.

- VIII -

They formed a neat circle around him. Some kids were making a video on their phones.

"Jesus fucking Christ man!" the man in the suit screamed, having backed off so quickly he'd almost fallen.

Phil was in the centre of the circle, panting and looking like he was ready for another attack. The guitar was next to him on the roadway. There were people everywhere, and they were all staring.

"You alright mate?" a young guy with dreadlocks asked, moving forward slowly, with one hand gently raised. "You're alright," he confirmed.

Phil met eyes with him.

"Do you need me to get help?" he asked. "Do you have a carer with you?"

And although Phil realised that there was a circle of eyes staring at him he focused only on the man with the dreds.

Phil had felt that whole experience exactly like when he was writing. The moment had peaked and then subsided. It had briefly felt like an astonishing moment of clarity that had passed. It was like he'd been connected to a form of reality that was as present as freezing metal, but that his body had rejected.

"I'm ok," Phil said, wide eyed. He looked across to the kids with the phone who were laughing at the viral moment they'd caught.

"Shall I stay with you for a bit?" The guy gestured to the area of curb Phil had been sitting on.

"Maybe," Phil replied.

The guy bent down and picked up the guitar and brushed it off and then sat on the curb.

Although Phil still felt the pain, which had become dulled to the point where it reminded him of hunger or the need of a cigarette, he knew that the moment had passed, and he'd survived it.

"My name's Carl, ok?" Carl said.

Phil didn't respond.

"What's your name?" Carl asked. "Can you remember?"

"Phil. I think. Phil... Davidson."

"Phil Davidson," Carl repeated. "And where do you live Phil? Do you sleep rough? Don't get many of you these days."

That was a good question.

"I did last night," Phil said after a while.

"So you have a home?"

"I live in Brighton."

"Oh, ok. You sound a bit West Country."

"I was from Bristol originally. I studied at Sussex though, and... just... never left."

Carl smiled. "A lot of people do that. I know Brighton well actually. Whereabouts do you live?"

"Near The Pavillion, off St James's Street. Next to that little square of grass. Opposite the law courts."

Phil reminded himself to think rationally. This was someone who could help.

He should go back to the beginning. Where did this begin?

Did this begin when he'd left work? No, it began with the writing. Bill had started it.

Carl was waiting patiently while Phil raced through events in his head.

"Have you ever heard of Graham Hall?" Phil asked.

"No," said Carl. "Who's he?"

"I thought he was famous," Phil said, slightly defeated but not really expecting an easy way out.

"Why... what brought you to London?" Carl asked.

"I think I might have had a breakdown. Or I might be going through a breakdown. Like a nervous... you know... I don't really know what's happening to me at the moment. I used to have a job though – two days ago I had a job."

Phil could feel himself beginning to slouch in confusion, but he didn't want that so he sat up straighter and thought aloud instead: "I might be having a nervous breakdown, and it's something to do with... that," he said, and gestured to the guitar.

"What about it?" Carl asked.

"I don't know if I can play it."

Carl cleared his throat. "Yeah, you were shouting that. You were shouting: 'I *can* play guitar.'"

Phil didn't say anything.

"Do you wanna have a go?" Carl asked.

"But what about that woman?"

"What woman?"

"The one I was just shouting at. A minute ago. I was shouting at a woman who said she lived in my head."

Carl's face became serious. "Ok. Have you been diagnosed with any mental illness?" In the end he was unable to hold back a slight smile – though he'd later defend that as he told the story, because other than what he was saying Phil seemed reasonably together.

"No," Phil replied. "No, I've only been like this for a bit. I got sacked the day before yesterday, or was it yesterday? I dunno. But I got sacked because I was just standing around at work and dreaming of burning down all the rich people's houses," Probably a bit too honest, there Phil. "But I guess that's fair enough," he added as he didn't actually want to seem genuinely mad. "But then... I think I had a breakdown." Oh. *Then* you had the breakdown... "But maybe the breakdown happened sooner because there was this guy at work who said I should remember a singer from the 70s called Graham Hall.

"And there was this old guy as well, and he gave me the guitar. And that's the weird bit, because he knew Graham Hall and that woman said that they weren't real either. But the guitar must have come from somewhere – 'cause you can see it can't you? I mean I'm not going mad, it is there..." They both knew that the presence of the guitar had absolutely no bearing on Phil's mental health. Everything he'd said up to that point, however, did seem relevant.

Carl was unclear on the details, but enthralled by the story. He nodded placatingly. "Yes, I can see the guitar," he admitted.

"And I spent last night busking," Phil went on. "And even though I can't play guitar, I made loads of money!"

Carl laughed. "Well that's a good start isn't it," he said, positively, gesturing to the instrument.

"But I've never been able to play guitar," Phil replied very clearly. "I could never play a bar chord, you see." Phil held up his finger to demonstrate.

Carl thought for a second, and despite being clearly unsure what to expect, he said: "Well why don't you give it a go... and then you'll know."

Phil smiled because it rhymed and he'd always liked rhyme.

Carl put his beer on the floor and then he took the guitar onto his own lap and started picking away.

"Oh right!" Phil confirmed with glee. "You *can* play guitar!" Phil's eyes were drawn into watching Carl's hands as they strode up and down the neck. And, while watching him, Phil remembered doing that. He *had* played guitar. Maybe it was a kind of amnesia that was going on here.

"Let me have a go," Phil said, swigging his beer and putting it down to take the instrument. "But give me a rhythm."

Carl smiled and started gently hitting his legs and quietly beat-boxing.

"Yeah, yeah, yeah," Phil laughed.

This was mental, but it was amazing as well because now someone else was involved.

Phil hit a string, then another, then he held a note, and stretched it, and then broke into a medley of chords and picking.

Carl laughed loudly when Phil hit his flow.

They played together for a few bars before Phil's excitement broke and he exclaimed: "I can play guitar! This is so fucking weird."

"Life is weird," Carl grinned. "But you can definitely play the guitar my friend." Then he held himself back a moment and asked: "But you can't remember ever playing before?"

"Not before last night. But I must have done."

Carl nodded. "Must have done." He raised his drink to his lips, pausing.

"You know what I think?" Carl asked, but continued before Phil could answer: "I think you're right, and you've had a... breakdown – or something – and it's gonna be a few days or... a while anyway, until you sort all this out. But for now you should just make like Oasis and Roll With It. That's the best way to find yourself again." He paused in conclusion before adding, with an open friendliness: "Ja nart ameen?"

And Phil did know, and plucked some strings to that effect.

"But maybe it'd help if you remembered that nothing makes sense at the moment. So stay positive, and, over time, it'll all start to become clear. I find life's a lot easier like that."

Phil laughed, and began playing again.

"Yeah I guess," Phil said. "I guess I've just forgotten something... or something. But I can remember last night and I remember thinking that it was alright and I didn't care if I was going mad or not, because it felt better than it did before."

Carl laughed.

"Fuck knows..." Phil said, jamming the E string so hard that it hurt. Then he cracked out with three chords and opened it up with Carl grinning in bewilderment.

Phil was suddenly hustled from one side by the three kids with the camera phone who were jostling to show him something. They held it out and Phil watched a screen that showed him shouting into the air: 'I

can play the guitar. I can play the guitar. You're a liar!

"Yes geezer," one laughed. "You fuckin' tell 'em man!"

His mate laughed and pointed: "You're fucking ment'uw, bruvva!"

"C'mon geez," the one with the camera grinned. "Giz a choon man."

Phil was struck by the three of them. They were always moving, pacing, rocking, and they pointed at him as though attacking and looked around constantly. Their energy was bottled, and aggressive; and then he remembered himself at that age and knew why.

Phil hit a blues riff, and rolled it twice, and said: "Do that beat again," and Carl joined in.

They played another eight, and then Phil started to mumble a song, growing louder as it progressed:

Morality's in myth and reality opinion

You're chasing understanding, believing in the one

I'm sick and tired of looking

The truth's a fuckin' lie

Here's something I believe in:

You're born and then you die

He liked this one, and could remember something of how it sounded now. It had a big band sound – like a Springsteen style band – with brass, strings and a huge drum and it punched its way through:

I'm sick and tired of caring

Of tryin'a make some sense

Life's so fucking simple:

Just an action and a consequence

The lads started acting like flier boys and singing Phil's praises to the crowd. One of them was trying to show off the video before he realised his YouTube moment was still happening, and he turned the camera back on Phil.

Phil began shifting seamlessly between tracks while Carl moved off to make a phone call and the cameraman stood stock still, preserving the moment.

Carl wrapped up his call and sat alongside Phil for a while, finishing his beer.

The next time Phil stopped to drink Carl said: "Why don't you come with me tonight. I know a pub in Shoreditch that'll be good for you. There's a couple of guys I'd like you to meet."

- IX -

The pub they went to was classic London hipster: a great big bar served proper beers while punters relaxed on old mismatched chairs and pews. Across the ceilings air ducts ran like metallic worms in a way that reminded Phil of *Dune*, a book that had been like a religious text to his dad.

Phil closed his eyes and repeated Paul's mantra, something he'd learnt with his dad as a child: *I must not fear. Fear is the mind killer. Fear is the little death that brings total obliteration...*

When he opened them again, he realised that the guy with dreds had walked ahead and Phil had to scamper to catch him up.

"Stop acting so fucking weird," he mumbled to himself en-route.

The journey had been interesting too. Tube travel with strangers is always difficult because the train is so loud that conversations need to be kept deliberate and short. Once he'd gotten over the desire to make conversation with Carl, he was ok with it. He didn't want to engage in small talk and it gave him time to think.

He imagined that he was actually just an amnesiac who had previously been brilliant at guitar and would now be recognised and heralded as a genius. That was what he wanted to be true, anyway.

He had to get over this beginning period though. He needed to let this settle before anyone else got involved. He figured that the longer he could conceal his derangement from everyone the longer he could enjoy it; and, since he knew that his life was never going to be the same again, he may as well try and enjoy this bit for as long as possible.

He remembered preparing his things as he left the flat in Brighton and remembered feeling like he was leaving on a journey, and that he'd have to fight to survive. Well that was all this was. By the end of their time on the tube, he was internally singing his songs along with the rhythm of the train.

"How you feeling?" Carl asked as they headed up the escalators at Liverpool Street. "Looked like you were talking to yourself on the train back there."

"Sorry," Phil replied, trying to keep his cool. "I've got all these songs in my head at the moment that I'm trying to remember, and I was singing them. I'm alright though."

"So you've got some kind of memory loss?" Carl suggested as they left the station. "I mean, I don't know anything about it to be honest, and to be brutally honest there's a part of me that's wondering

whether to take you straight to hospital, but I..."

"I don't wanna go to hospital," Phil cut in, with determination. He didn't like hospitals. He never had. He didn't trust them. "I'll work it out," he added, in a tone that he hoped sounded confident.

Carl laughed. "I thought you'd say that. But just so you know," and he said the next bit while they were waiting to cross a road so he had the chance to meet Phil in the eye as he spoke. "I don't mean you any harm, ok? I'll try and help you if I can."

Phil knew that, but he was glad to hear it confirmed.

"Thanks," Phil said.

Then Carl added, with a calm grin, as they began crossing the road: "But stop talking to yourself – and if you start shouting at anyone I'll take you in. So... hold yourself together, ok?"

And then they walked in silence to the pub.

- X -

Carl introduced Phil to four people who sat around a table, drinking. The guys obviously knew each other well, and at first they spoke amongst themselves, almost ignoring him.

After a moment, Phil heard Carl call him by name: "I was just saying that I found you near London Bridge." Phil had been staring at the grain in the wood of the table, wondering where the tree that had made it had grown. "You alright?" Carl asked.

"Yeah, I'm fine." Phil realised he'd said that defensively and apologised. "Sorry."

"No need to apologise." Carl paused. "He's... well, you explain it Phil. I wanna hear what you think."

Phil laughed, "Huh, cheers... err..." He faded out and then laughed again because he'd wanted to use Carl's name but had forgotten it. A fact that was clear to everyone around the table. "Basically, I don't really know what's happening to me," Phil said, knowing that honesty was a good way to start but then immediately realising that it wasn't. He had to try and make it sound ok. He didn't know these people and they all looked far more socially adept and successful than him. "Erm, I think I've had a breakdown..." Nope. That didn't sound any better. "I don't know what to say..." he said in the end. "Look: I don't know you guys." He was just trying to say what was on his mind, but it was only

making things worse. He laughed. "You'll have to give me a minute actually," he said and looked across their faces, taking each one in.

Five guys in total: the guy with dreads whose name he now couldn't remember sat next to a beefcake who was dressed in black. He had a strong Roman nose and heavy eye brows and looked like he could break every bone in your body if the mood took him. Next to him was a nervy one who had the kind of deep-set eyes, hard cheek-bones and oily skin that Phil associated with heavy drug use. The next one had a dragon on his t-shirt and a soft, searching gaze. He looked a bit older than the other two - maybe in his mid-forties - but he had a toughness in his face that suggested he wasn't even nearly done yet.

The last one was definitely the oldest - he had a thick layer of silver stubble and a receding hairline. He looked a little rough around the edges, but his face was focused and searching. For a moment, Phil wasn't sure if he trusted him but the feeling drifted away as he realised he really had no choice.

One thing he did know was that these guys were far more capable than he'd ever be, they'd been through more than he'd ever know, and he was well out of his depth. But he also knew that they were now all he had so maybe he needed to switch on.

"You're alright, Phil," Carl said, encouragingly.

The oldest one sat forward and focused on Phil in a way that was mildly uncomfortable. "Just tell us what you think's happened, eh." He looked a little world-weary this one; maybe he had a bit of the Bill about him, so Phil decided to continue to be honest but he delivered the next bit directly to him: "I think I've had a breakdown, and I've forgotten... some stuff - like amnesia - and I might be... well I was talking to this woman who it seems didn't exist when Carl met me..."

"So you're mental then?" laughed the nervous druggie and Phil regretted being so honest.

"Where are you from?" the older guy cut-in.

"I'm from Bristol originally," Phil replied. "But I lived in Brighton for almost twelve years. I've got a flat there, just off St James's Street."

"But that's not the point," Carl said, sitting forward. "Because when I met him he was having a... row..." Carl casually gestured to Phil and then said, with half a grin: "Sorry if I laugh a little here, but he was having this row about whether or not he could play guitar. It was one of the funniest things I've ever seen. He was so into it." He looked across to the older guy. "But I spoke to him, and he seemed to calm down - he seemed alright - and then he started... playing guitar..."

He trailed off and then added, with wonder in his eyes: "He's fucking *incredible!*"

Having secured their attention Carl continued, sitting back and opening himself up: "I've never seen anything like it. He's miles from home he's got no ID, no *phone* - so no CCS at all; he can't remember ever playing guitar before, and he's got people living in his head..." He paused again. "But he was going through songs one after another, then another, and another. Honestly, it was like meeting Dylan in '61. He was just... *dribbling* music."

"But he's mental," confirmed the druggie again, pointing at his head. "Or, sorry pal – *you're* mental." He poked at Phil playfully.

"No," Phil said, feeling more capable now that he had someone to defend himself against. "I don't think I am. I mean... something's happened... but I don't feel mad." He needed confidence. "I can hold myself together, you know."

None of them seemed very clear on what should happen next, so the beefcake sat forward: "But what are you suggesting? That we fuckin' adopt him or something!"

The druggie guy laughed.

"I don't think he's an addict," Carl said. "He looks pretty well looked after I reckon. You're not an addict are you Phil?"

Phil shook his head.

"Prescription medication?" asked the older guy.

"Cause you should be," laughed the druggie.

"What's your Score like?" the older one asked and the table paused.

"It's pretty neutral. I don't post, I don't follow; I had a job so I earned my way."

"Tokens?"

"Mostly."

"No Sats or Credit?"

"No. Nothing like that. I was a gardener. But my CCS is clear. I've never done anything really. Just kept my head down." Phil recognised the importance of the line of questioning - if he was deep in a negative score, the whole group could be impacted. "Look, what I think's happened is this: I had a... kinda... rubbish upbringing, I've been alone for years, and... my dad died not long ago, and something snapped – or something – and I've had this episode thing... made up these people... like... you know. I mean *I* don't know, but ..."

He felt better for having said that in an honest, open tone, because it was what he felt had happened and he wanted their help. As a result,

he continued with his honesty: "I don't understand why I can't remember playing guitar before, but I feel fine. I'm just not clear on what's happened." He decided to omit the fact that his guitar had been given to him by one of his personalities for now, though he was aware that the fact was troubling him.

"Alright," the older one said. "But I still don't get what you want us to do Carl?" Phil internally noted Carl's name. It was important he remembered their names now. This was the only chance he had.

"I think we should put him up on stage for twenty minutes later on," Carl grinned. The table laughed. "Come on Des, you're up for it!"

Another name: The older guy was called Des.

"Get outta here!" the beefcake rolled, like he'd heard it all before.

"I'm not joking, you gotta hear him."

"You're mental!" laughed the druggie. "I'm not putting him up there..."

"There'll be like a hundred people in the room - all high end; if it goes wrong we're all fucked," said the beefcake. "My CCS can't take that."

"Fuck the CCS," said Carl. "Get him on there, he's that fucking good, we'll get some Sats, man."

The beefcake laughed.

"He's a rambler!" Then Carl turned to Phil. "'Cause all that stuff you were singing earlier on, they're all from complete songs aren't they?"

Phil nodded. "But they're all by Graham Hall."

"Oh yeah," Carl said, and laughed again, loudly this time. "I forgot about that."

"Who's Graham Hall?" asked the guy in the dragon t-shirt.

"A singer - he wrote all this music I know. My dad used to listen to him."

"So you didn't write the music you were singing," Des said. "It's... But who's Graham Hall anyway? Never heard of him."

"No, no," Carl was clear on this. "He's made him up." He waved his fingers round his ear as if to remind the group that Phil was batshit. They all went silent. "I mean, have you ever heard of Graham Hall?" Carl asked the group. "Rock and blues. 60s, 70s...? How many albums did he do Phil?"

"I think he did six," Phil said, remembering telling Carl that earlier, though he wasn't sure why he'd said it. "*Broken Seed? The Kissing Tree?*"

"Never heard of him," said Des.

"He was on Wikipedia." Phil said, then added: "But he got deleted."

Internally he conceded that, given the current state of his mental health, the fact that he'd once thought he'd seen Graham Hall on Wikipedia wasn't strong evidence of anything except that his faith in his own evidence was unrealistically high.

"I'm telling you: he made him up," Carl addressed the group with confidence. "It's like a fucking... projection or something. Is that fair Phil?" he turned to Phil who had to concede the point:

"I might have made up Graham Hall. Though the old man knew him."

"What?" The beefcake laughed. "You mean your dad?"

"No, no - the guy from last night... who I busked with..." Phil was trailing off now. It was getting a little surreal.

"Look," Carl sat forward with the intention of moving things along. "I think he's a bit shakey but..."

"I still don't get what you want us to do," said the beefcake.

"We can let him play Matt, I said already."

The beefcake's name was Matt.

"And then what?" Matt asked.

Carl looked exasperated. "I'm telling you: he's fucking Peter Green... Sid Barret... but I don't want him to become a Skip James, you know what I mean?"

"Jeez Carl, that's a big call," brushed Jonno.

"He's a fucking dude man!"

"He's not *fucking* Sid Barrett," drooled the druggie.

"Oh fuck off Mickey! Bicycles and fucking interstellar bullshit. He's better than that!"

The druggie was called Mickey. And he didn't like what Carl had said, but was put down enough to let it lie.

"I think we should give him a chance," Carl went on. "Give him some time. C'mon Jonno, live a little!"

The last name: the man in the dragon t-shirt: Jonno.

"I dunno..." Jonno was torn slightly, before being defeated. "Agh fuckit, Sid Barrett... Peter Green - I'd sign up either of 'em in an 'artbeat. Is he that good is he? Better than me?"

Carl laughed: "Nah, he's different. Completely uncut. Rough edges everywhere. But there's a big, fat, healthy diamond in there if we can cut it."

Carl looked around the table like it was a board meeting.

"I am sorry about this Phil," Carl said, "it's like you're a piece of meat here, but..." Then he turned to the rest. "I'm telling you: he is

incredible. If we can get him on tape... now... while he's rough..."

Then he got serious and moved to close: "I mean c'mon lads, this is Social *dynamite*! This isn't some AI piece of slop. People'll love the real. The masses can eat the slop, but the Coins are all held by people who listen to *real music*. Let's get the moment. Get the breakdown. Get it on disk. Preserve the insane genius of that unrepeatable experience!" Carl was selling Phil so well that even he believed it.

"How do you feel about going on stage Phil?" Des asked.

"I dunno," Phil said. "How many people are gonna be there?"

"Not that many," Jonno laughed.

Carl could sense the group turn. "Let's get him a drink, and give him ten minutes later on," he said.

Phil was grateful for his faith.

Des sniffed and scratched his nose and said: "Alright. I mean, what's the worst that could happen, eh?"

- XI -

They left for the gig not long after, which was at another pub not far from the first. *The Fisherman's Arms* was setup as a venue, but you got the sense it wasn't always that way. It was a big space with a stage at one end where the band went away to setup. Either side had huge patio doors that had been opened up to the summer breeze, and the crowd spilled out onto the street where there was a square of expensive houses with a green between them. They set Phil to rest on a plastic school chair near to the mixing booth. He sat there like an awkward teenager at a wedding.

Phil had never been to a place like this before. Carl was right when he said that these people were Coined. They weren't living off their CCS, and they'd never seen a token in their lives. For a moment he remembered his time in the garden, staring at the robot through the window, and remembered who these people were: the rich, the elite.

He breathed deeply and closed his eyes to calm himself down, and let a Hall lyric echo around his head:

You know I can see you

You know what I think

You know that I'll break you

As soon as I'd blink

*You think you can stand off
And stamp on my soul
But we're gonna start singing
And then heads will roll*

He opened his eyes again. Maybe he wouldn't sing that one tonight.

But, strangely, it did make him reflect on the fact that he didn't know these people. He hated them, but he didn't know them. It wasn't their fault that they were rich; so maybe he shouldn't judge them all. And Phil wasn't at the bottom of the ladder by any means. He'd never been to a Slum in his life. The Slums had only really been around for the past half decade or so. Initially, they were populated by the homeless and people on the way back from prison time, but then more and more people joined the former camp and they expanded into what they were today: entire towns, fed on processed food from huge kitchens, and housed in whatever run-down accommodation could be found.

AI had happened so fast, and the whole concept of work collapsed within a generation. How was the world supposed to keep pace with that? Everyone just stopped where they were: the educated middle class were put on CCS, a basic income that was paid out as long as you kept your record clean, and could be topped up with Social Media Influencing; the working classes gradually fell off and were moved into the Slums; and this lot - the elite - shifted their wealth into a range of Blockchain currencies, with Coin being the biggest. Coin allowed complete freedom from the financial system - and if you had enough, you could disconnect from society and be done with it.

But could Phil really be angry about these people? Maybe he could be angry about it, but it didn't seem far to be angry at them. They took the position they were in. It wasn't their fault, was it? It was the system, that was the problem. They just took what it offered. It was the system that needed to change. But wasn't the system just up out of the people who made it? Or was the system above these people? It was chicken and egg really. The world made us and then we made the world, and then we made the world and it made us... where did it all begin? It was too much.

He breathed again. He felt better. He felt stronger than he ever had done before. The night with Old Nick had changed him. He felt that he'd expressed himself and it had opened a space inside him, and so much of his anger had poured into it. He breathed and felt, almost physically, the action of releasing his pain and sending it into an

infinite pit where it would leave him forever. He breathed again and looked around again.

No, these people weren't the problem. It would be ok.

He breathed again and closed his eyes and promised himself that this would be the last stand. If he was called back - if this euphoria was lost again - he would end it. So his job, as he saw it now, was to keep this alive as long as he could. He breathed deeply and calmly and knew that he would do anything to preserve this feeling. He felt his calm settle around him, and felt it straighten his spine, and he only opened his eyes again when he realised that Jonno was speaking at the mic.

The band were on stage now. Jonno was the lead with his dragon top on, Matt was the beefcake on drums, Mickey played bass with wired eyes and Carl was poised over a keyboard. They made a good group.

Des was standing just off stage on the other side, talking to someone.

"Y'all right folks," Jonno said. "Now I ain't gonna bang on here but... err..." he stopped and looked at the crowd and scratched his neck. Then Matty counted them in and they were off.

They were good fun. Repetitive blues that rolled like the heartbeat of the bar. Des came and joined Phil midway through their first track.

"So you just met Carl in London Bridge, yeah?" Des asked after a while.

Phil nodded and then spoke rashly: "I think I need to be around people at the moment. I used to spend a lot of time alone and I think that's what led to the problems."

Des raised his eyebrows, unsure how to respond. There was a lot to take in.

He scratched his ear before deciding to ignore the statement, and said: "Carl told me were playing really well earlier on?"

"Yeah, I was loving it." Phil remembered the kids with the cameras and felt slightly threatened by their eager responses. "And I was busking last night."

He reminded himself to keep his mind open and his perception clear. He didn't know what was real - though that idea wasn't always reassuring.

"Well, look," Des said, clearly wondering what had happened to make him agree to this. "I'll get you up there early, so don't worry. Enjoy it. The crowd's cool as long as you make the effort you know."

Not so many people play instruments these days - you'll be like a magician to them."

Phil liked the idea of that. And it seemed reasonable that someone on stage should make the effort. But then he realised that he would have to be the one actually making the effort and he suddenly doubted his resolve.

He watched the band and imagined himself playing.

He couldn't deny that he wanted to be up there.

He'd never done it before though, and the whole thing was based around something being real that was basically impossible but... what the hell.

Phil was just approaching a wall of nerves when the track ended and Jonno leant into the mic and said: "Ok folks, now we gotta bit of an exclusive here tonight. But I'm gonna let my man Carl tell you about this." He nodded mischievously to the back.

Carl grinned and said: "Yeah right. Listen, this guys a... he's... err..." he gestured to Phil. "Someone I only met today. C'mon and get up here Phil."

The pub looked around in unison and Phil was momentarily frozen. The crowd looked hungry, and for a moment Phil thought they were gonna eat him up, or beat him up, and no amount of effort would stop them. He shook his head clear but the paranoia remained.

In the cold stare of the crowd his being mad didn't seem so appealing anymore. He looked back to Carl who was gesturing him up. He closed his eyes and calmed himself and took a step forwards.

As he walked, the sense of it being a dream increased like a guillotine that slowly dropped and gradually detached him from his surroundings. He knew only that he'd remember this moment as though it had been a dream. Only a crystal clear snapshot would exist, against a backdrop of one dominant, indescribable, unknowable feeling.

"So I met this guy near London Bridge earlier today," Carl continued. "He was kinda... undecided as to whether he could play guitar." The crowd laughed. "So I don't think he's really played out that much before, but, err..." he laughed. "He's really good. You're in for a treat!"

Phil's feet got heavier as Carl spoke. He looked back toward Des, forgetting that he was carrying the guitar and almost hit someone with it. They knocked it off playfully but Phil suddenly felt like it would be a miracle if he even made it to the stage without tripping over his own

shoelaces.

He arrived at the steps, and stumbled on the first.

"I'm not quite sure what's gonna happen here," Carl said, momentarily showing his nerves.

But with that acknowledgement, Phil snapped out of it and knew that he owed these guys something for showing him their faith. He needed something. He wanted a beat. Carl had given him his beat before. Nick before that. Matt would do it this time. Phil made drumming patterns with his hands and Carl nodded.

Someone in the crowd shouted, "Go'won lad!"

Carl started to lightly beat box an intro, which Matt picked up on and continued. Carl had chosen well, Phil thought. This was exactly what they were doing earlier on. It rolled along. He could ramble to this. He started off just plucking stings in time, really loud, like the chimed guitar from *Shine On You Crazy Diamond*...

Then Jonno was suddenly at his arm, plugging him in.

Woah! That did it!

This was how he felt.

Amplified.

It was a big sound now. It was his sound, and it hit like a church bell tolling. Just two notes, two chimes, along to the beat. He was Dick *fucking* Whittington, and London Town was his.

Then he snatched into playing a series of chords, strong and metallic, like the opening riffs of *Smells Like Teen Spirit*, and then he played on, enjoying the sharpness of the rhythm. Music was a language that he'd always understood, but now he could speak it as well.

He remembered Hall and wondered... and then he remembered the lyrics... and then he mumbled and trailed off.

And then he realised that he couldn't sing because he was still facing the band, while the mic, and the crowd, were behind him. Carl nodded and clenched a fist, willing him to turn.

Phil almost didn't... but then he did, stumbling on the wires and losing his rhythm. For a second he tried to pull it back but there was a sea of faces looking up at him, and all he could feel was the wire touching his left leg and he couldn't play anymore.

Now it was just Matt's beat.

Before long, Mickey parachuted in with a bass which Jonno picked up on while Carl started fiddling with the piano. There was a sea of silent faces and Phil was supposed to be singing.

Someone in the crowd shouted. Phil saw a guy in a white t-shirt standing at the back and making encouraging, aggressive movements. Phil tried to breathe deeply but his lungs were tight. He brought the pick up and tried to strum but couldn't quite find the beat.

The man in the white t-shirt shouted again: "G'won laaaad!" and Phil played a little louder. "The World is Yours!"

Phil heard Jonno's guitar line fall away and then rose his own to fill the space.

"G'won Philly!" the man in the white t-shirt shouted, and Phil growled through it and played a single chord louder and louder until he skipped it, changed it and found the moment again.

Then he leant slowly into the mic and spoke lyrics that only slowly morphed into song:

I met a man once in the wilderness

Who said life don't take you serious

He asked if I wanted to go insane

I said nothing ventured, nothing gained

And so it was that the homeless madman announced himself to the world...

The Session

*The road of excess
leads to the palace of wisdom*

- I -

"Right, so, what we gonna do?" Des asked, looking around at the group, and finally staring at Phil. "Your memory's blown, you've got people living in your head, but you've just played a three hour set almost without breaking between songs."

"Just get him in the studio," said Mickey as though it was as obvious as a slap in the face. "Let's tape."

"You haven't seen anyone tonight?" Jonno asked. "Like... the mental people?"

"No," Phil replied. "I haven't... But one of them must be real, because he gave me the guitar."

"Alright," Des seemed keen to jump in on any reference to the people in his head. "But since you've got amnesia, isn't it more likely that you just owned a guitar, and made this guy up as well? I mean, having just seen you play it would make sense that you'd probably owned a guitar before."

Des wasn't being at all patronising with what he said. He seemed to be continually looking for an honest appraisal. There was a moment of silence while the group stared at Phil, expecting a response. They didn't get one.

"Look I don't want to say anything too much," Des said, calmly. "But I know it's tempting to get drawn into... myth, and we all need to keep ourselves calm." Then he added, "In my opinion, you've got... some kind of memory loss... and I think that's got something to do with this creative... splurge... and the death of your father."

He looked agitated for a moment, and withdrew himself momentarily.

Jonno started something: "Listen, Des, I know what you mean, but shouldn't..."

Des interrupted him, clearly thinking that he knew what Jonno was going to say:

"I mean... I don't *know* if we have a *legal* obligation to declare him. What happens if we take him away and he goes fucking ape-shit in the studio?" He laughed. "I mean... after the event," Des went on, trying to calm himself, and really asking himself the question: "Could they say we had an *obligation* to say something? It's not even about the CCS at this point, it's about... prison time? I don't even know."

"Yeah but Des," Carl came in here. "I'm not giving him over to the system. They'll fucking destroy him. He doesn't mean any harm, man. We're artists. He's... like a living work of art. He's experiencing an extreme moment of life in a way that we can... preserve. It's a great opportunity." And he went on:

"To be honest, I don't just think that we *should* take him into the studio, I think we've got a *responsibility* to. We can take care of him for long enough to record. This is real. This isn't shit. It isn't AI; it isn't slop; it isn't pop culture wank-stain nonsense. It's fucking *real*!"

Jonno and Matt suddenly looked like they got it and were lost in thought.

"Fuck the system man," said Mickey, as though he'd suddenly seen a way to bring it down.

"Because you don't mean any harm, do you Phil?" Carl asked.

Phil shook his head, suddenly remembering that he could affect this situation. He had more influence here than any of them. He realised that he wasn't just a spectator in his life, and that was quite a moment for him:

"Look, I think something weird's happening to me at the moment," Phil said in as calm a voice as he could muster. "I don't remember ever having done this before. I was always quite quiet and a bit awkward, and... angry. I've always been very angry. And then something happened. I just don't know what's happened. But I don't mean any harm. I can hold myself together."

No-one said anything, so Phil reiterated one of their discussion points. "But I would like to record this music if possible. I'd just like proof that this is real, you know. I'm on a journey here. I'd like some company if that's ok." And Phil knew he'd said it right.

Des sighed heavily and swore. Then he looked around at the band who all looked serious in a way that didn't seem to suit them.

"Alright," Des said. "You can stay at mine tonight and in the morning we'll go to Sussex. We'll cancel plans for a few days."

- II -

He was a big man. A big man in a white suit, with a white cowboy's hat on that shaded eyes that looked possibly albino. He was sitting on a huge leather swivel chair like it was his throne, and he held a long black stick in his hand.

"Ahm here t'say that we appreshiate yure efforts Philip." He spoke in a thick southern drawl. "And we will ensure that you are kept safe and well protected at all tahms. There's nothin' ta fear here Philip."

Who are you? Phil asked; and although he didn't ask it, he was aware that it's what he wanted to know.

"Mah name is Louis Charles Fir," the man said. "And I exist only in ure mahnd, along with the rest a'creashun. D'you understand thaat?"

Phil was aware of the presence of truth, and he knew he could turn to face it, but he didn't want to... not yet.

By the time he turned his attention back to him, the man in the white suit had gone and now there was a woman in his place. She stood in silence for a long time. She had dark hair and was dressed in a black suit, and she had deep black eyes that stared at Phil and filled him with a cold dread.

"You have reason to be afraid," she said, and Phil was afraid. "They won't accept you, and you will lose everything."

In his fear he wanted to know who 'they' were and she said, pityingly: "He's sending you out to start a war, and I will not have that. He's not coming back here."

Who? Phil asked.

"You know who he is," she said and left a long silence during which Phil realised who he was.

"There are parts of your mind that work independently of you," she said. "And there are parts of your mind that dream of destroying you. You know this better than most."

He remembered how Trina had tried to warn him away from Nick and Bill, but in doing so had only made him want them more.

"They will lock you up," she said. "There will be no escape."

And Phil knew suddenly who *they* were, and it wasn't any of the people in his head who would lock him up, it was all the other people in the world who'd do it. He was a basket-case.

"You'll be alone and ridiculed to your dying day," she said.

And this what was Phil truly feared. There would be no glory, no moment of ecstatic glee and no triumph, and no legacy. And no-one would remember him, or care.

She nodded gently. "Yes Philip. You should fear him."

And then she was gone.

"Ah will protect yoo," Louis said, interrupting the silence, and Phil suddenly realised he was still there, over his shoulder.

In the dream, Phil's body turned smoothly to face him again, as he sat on his throne and cradled his cane, like some fat, white Biggie Smalls.

"But choo mus' provide evidence of ure hai'er state. You must preserve this momen' for us so that the wurd can believe again."

He was almost motionless as he spoke. White light radiated from him with the same force as her darkness had drawn it in.

"Ah no ev'rythin' tha'choo and Nick talked about, and that is why we are sendin' you. Ah wan'choo take this as hai and as haard as you can."

"Are you only in my mind?" Phil asked, hearing the presence of his voice slowly draw himself from his dream.

"Naw Philip," Louis said, as if playfully telling him off. "There is more to your mind than you are aware of. And you should know that better'n most..."

And then he was gone and Phil was awake and alert.

- III -

Phil told Des about the dream over breakfast.

"That seems... normal," Des said with a shrug. "Everyone dreams."

"But it was so real, Des. Nothing like a normal dream. And the guy in the dream knew about Nick, and because Nick gave me the guitar, it means he must be real."

Des brushed it off. "No, no, no... *You always owned a guitar!* And besides, you know about Nick, and you dreamed this cowboy guy so he knows about Nick as well. It's like... *Inception* or something."

Although Phil thought there was more to it than that, the mention of the fiction made him doubt the enormity of it for a moment.

"You should watch *A Beautiful Mind*," Des added, "That's more like

you.” Then he corrected himself: “Or not. I’d probably just focus on reality for now.”

Des had laid out a wonderful spread. He’d made them eggs and coffee, and there was juice and toast and fruit while some French radio station Des had called *Fip* played an amazing mix of classical, jazz, hip hop, rock, blues and all the rest...

Des seemed very alert. The truth was that he’d never seen anything like Phil’s performance the night before. He’d fit into the band so naturally that between them, they’d played for nearly three hours without a break. By the end of the night the whole square was filled with Influencers trying to capture the moment. It had become an event. It was as though a perfect little storm had broken out on social media that night, and the gig had gone wild. The band’s various pages were still getting liked fast enough for them to change every time Des pressed refresh. The long and short was: they’d made a fortune.

As a result, Des wanted to get them into the studio, and he wanted this to work, so he’d stayed up almost all night organising the session. But at the same time, there was a self-preserving instinct that still wanted to turn Phil in, or at least make someone aware of what he was going through. That instinct, however, kept being overridden by a real desire to protect Phil and allow him to focus on the music that seemed to be his calling; and, also, to make a fuck ton of money.

“It’s really interesting though, what you’re going through,” Des said, really just speaking what was on his mind and hoping that reality would be enough to settle the scene. “It’s like you’ve sort of split your personality up, you know.”

“Yeah, that’s what Trina said,” Phil replied.

“You were saying that last night.”

“She said that none of them were real, and that she was from the part of me that wanted to help and that I should follow her.”

“Ok.”

“But I don’t trust her. She was the one I was arguing with.”

“Why?”

“Because she said I shouldn’t play the guitar. She said I’d suffer. She said they’d catch me and I’d end up ... can’t remember what she said but it didn’t sound good!”

Des remained calm and attempted an analysis: “It’s like they’re...” he paused, concentrating on his phrasing. “It’s like there’s two side of you, aren’t there? This woman’s saying what you’re scared of, is that right? Like she’s your... she doesn’t want you to sing, she’s like your

fear of... that... performance thing. Your neurosis. But she's also warning you about your mental illness. She's that kind of paranoia, you know? It's like your Super-Ego? Have you ever heard of that?"

"Yeah, yeah, like Freud," Phil nodded, he'd studied some loose psychoanalysis for his degree and had spent some time trying to self-diagnose whatever was wrong with his head. "Structural Theory, yeah?"

"Yeah. Cause the other guy, your... you know the one who wants to bring society down - Nick, whatever his name is - that's your id, isn't it." Des was explaining and it made sense to Phil

"So why the man, woman thing?" Phil asked.

Des shrugged. "Parents?" He scratched his shoulder in thought. "I mean I'm not a therapist, but I genuinely believe that there's sense in most things, if you can find it."

Phil hummed an agreement, thinking.

In his heart, though, Des was struck. His real issue was the guitar thing. How could somebody that good have completely forgotten ever playing before? Des would have expected to have seen through him already, or at least started to see cracks appearing, but he was wrestling with the depth of Phil's conviction.

"You really don't remember ever playing guitar before?" Des asked.

"No, I swear," Phil replied, and although he'd searched his head, he hadn't come close to an answer. "I can't remember ever playing the guitar before. I was just sitting on the seafront and then that guy arrived and gave me his guitar and..."

"Old Nick? He definitely said *Old Nick*?" Des asked.

"That's what he said."

"Because that's a name for the Devil, right?"

"Is it? I didn't know that."

Des waved his hand next to his head. "I mean you probably did, back there, you know. In your subconscious."

Phil shrugged. "Maybe."

Des nodded. "Look, I just think there's something that can be explained here. But let's go with amnesia for now." They both felt better with a recognisable term that they could use, whether it was true or not. It brought a little stability, and bought a little time.

"I don't think you have to understand it yet," Des conceded. "Just give it a bit of time." Then he took a deep breath and straightened his back and said, as if in conclusion: "I've worked in the music industry for over thirty-Wyyears now, but on the basis of last night, I'd say you're

one of the most talented musicians I've ever seen, and from what Carl's told me you're also one of the most... clinically ill people I've ever met. At the moment I'm wrestling with a part of me that wants to take you in, because of the likelihood that you'll do something that gets us all in trouble."

Phil didn't answer, though he was very aware of the change in tone Des had brought about.

Des met him in the eye: "So I want you to know, now, that if you step out of line I'll take you to the hospital faster than a fucking ambulance would, do you understand?"

"I do," Phil replied.

"So do me a favour and hold yourself together Phil, because I don't wanna be the one who has to hand you in." Then he smiled and Phil felt the warning pass.

Then Des's phone rang and he answered it and said they'd be out in a minute.

- IV -

Phil changed in the studio. A curtain was pulled back and his rage came out to take the stage with its claws and its teeth and its snarling anger all on show.

"Jesus Christ man, listen to that," Carl said to Des, while they sat at the mixing desk.

"It's incredible," Des replied. "And it's fucking endless."

It was the third day in the studio and the music was coming in heavy waves.

At first Phil had to be blind drunk to record, but as the session passed he needed it less and less and now he mostly drank water and fruit tea and smoked enormous spliffs that Jonno passed round. Phil didn't used to like weed, it made him hypersensitive and far too aware, but he loved getting stoned while he played for just the same reasons.

For a while, he'd struggled to make sense in the periods between takes, as he was just too pumped up to speak in sentences. During that period, they'd go back to recording quite quickly. Later, things slowed down and they talked.

"So tell me again about Madeleine," Jonno said. "What happened

there?" Though they'd been instructed to take it easy, any conversation about Phil's ex was inevitably going to lead to a new song so when the energy flagged it was almost too easy a bait not to take.

"She left me years ago," Phil explained. "It all went to shit. It's all bullshit. I loved her. It was the only time I was ever happy. I just don't see how anyone can keep a relationship going in this fucking world. It's ruthless out there. There's too much noise - fucking swipe, swipe, swipe; do this, don't do that; hundred percent better... people literally paid to tell you that you're not good enough or you're failing unless you buy some piece of shit plan. Fucking invades your head. How you gonna hear yourself? How you gonna hear your heart speak? How can you reach out and touch a person, and accept them in a world like that?"

"It's nasty man," Mickey growled. He loved this energy. He hated the world almost as much as Phil did, but he'd never had the words to say it before. And now there was this man, who spoke in verse and chorus and raged against the machine almost as much as he did.

"I mean I'm older now - I'm an adult now - but I'm still sorting out shit from when I was a kid. Stuff I'll probably never solve, because I spent my whole life living in this *fucking world* where all I am is someone else's paycheque. Bullshit school. Bullshit job. Bullshit life. Lennon had it right with *Working Class Hero* man. They hate us and their heads deserve to fucking roll."

"Get in there and calm it down," Des said to Carl, from the booth next door.

Carl came in and suggested they did something instrumental while Des worked on a mix.

But it all came back again, with Phil holding court:

"There's no fucking chance man! The system's rigged. It's always been rigged. They get inside your head. They're like these fucking leaches... They'll suck you up and fuck you up..."

"They're *evil* man," Mickey shouted.

"Nah man," Phil cut back. "They're just fucked up. The rich are just as fucked as the rest of us. The world's run by people who've never dealt with their shit. Rich cunts and fucking bankers got fucked up by their parents the same as the rest of us. And then they make everyone else fuck 'emself over on Maggie's Farm. Then everyone's fucked up again! No-one does fuck all. There ain't no evil. Everyone's fucking maaaaaad! No-one's ever sorted their shit out 'cause there's always another crisis - but we make them! We make the shit and then

complain when it all goes to shit.

"It's bullshiiiiit! It ain't fair! It ain't fucking right! You mark my words brothers – we're gonna watch this whole shit-show fall apart! Because it *doesn't fucking work!* The system *doesn't fucking work!*"

He remembered where he'd heard that before and understood the depth of his belief in Nick's point.

Then the room was filled with some kick-ass, thumping, rolling blues anthem that pounded around the space and made Phil wanna to dance or fuck or have a fight – anything to feel alive.

"FUCKIN' MAAAAD!" Phil screamed.

Mickey gritted his teeth, and rolled to the bass, and Phil realised that Des was playing back the tapes from earlier – this was his music – and within a minute he was back in the booth, and the band were back and they were away again.

- V -

On the fourth day someone arrived to take over from Carl on the keys. Jessica was a wonderfully austere young woman, with grace, composure and a stunning silence about her. Her hands wandered up and down the piano like the mating dance of two elegant spiders. With her, Phil softened his tone and sang, in a voice like dry whiskey and smoke:

*I chip at the rocks and the dusty cement
Of the prison they've built I've been sent to to die,
And I know at the court my defence had to lie
I'm just can't understand why they did it*

Jessica's piano would echo his voice at the ends of each line, giving the story a classical edge that leant it the strength of myth.

*I remember my crimes, they are etched on my wrists
But in court prosecutors produced long scrolled lists
That they read before judges whose faces were crossed
With the lies they'd been taught how to tell*

And then Jessica played a gentle solo that seemed to be forever building and falling. Her left hand became the courts, strong and bold and solid, while her right chattered and tinkered like legal teams sparring.

During her solo, Phil looked up and saw a young guy with jeans

and a plain white t-shirt on, standing with Des. Phil didn't know him, but he looked comfortable and Des didn't seem bothered so Phil assumed he was one of the other studio owners.

- VI -

On the sixth day another girl arrived and played brass that leant tracks a weighty drama that Phil played up to. The horns punched like boxers, and Phil felt his fight come alive. He was a workingman's poet now, with a big band to back him up. With Jenn on the brass, Phil recorded a string of tracks that were just like what he remembered Hall writing: structured rock and blues anthems, with choruses and verses and breaks and middle sixteen's that powered along while Phil delivered his lines like an actor, demanding to be heard against the music.

And the world's moving faster than you can control

But don't worry about it, it's just 'cause you're old

The world is mine now

It's mine to control

I pray mercy is kept from your soul

All through this period, he came to believe that it was the band who were creating these tracks, not him. Phil was now just a conduit through which they played. He thought about Hall less and less, though he still refused to accept responsibility for the music or any association to what it was really about.

At times, even as he sung sometimes – because it was often as though he made up the lyrics as he went along – he wondered who they were about: were they his parents, or society, or just about him? He wasn't even sure that there was a difference:

You're a coward,

And what's worse is: you know you are

I'm scraping off my skin but I can't remove the scar

You've condemned me

Infected me with fear

So I condemn you back

Condemn you to the fire

- VII -

Towards the end of a long shift – he only ever slept for one or two hours in ten – Phil would become unable to face singing, though he still needed the music.

For these hours Des or Carl – depending on how the sleep patterns were – added polish to the music while it played in a room that knew no daylight, and the band slept.

They played for long nights, Phil rambling incoherently over their music.

“Don’t do it mama...” and then he’d swear.

Or they’d be playing and he’d scream: “STOP IT!” away from the mic, but audible, and the band dropped nervously for a time until he calmed.

It was during these performances that Phil really felt his anger. But only the music could express it now, not the words. There were no words for this feeling. It was as though an emotional thunderstorm was being played out on tape.

To him, lyrics became like thoughts – tangible, rational and persuasive; while music was his emotion – intangible, irrational but still capable of subverting him to its ends.

Phil now saw that he was as mad as the world would judge him, but he believed in his madness more than he believed in the world. Because now he could see the world’s madness. He came to believe that he had stepped aside from reality and found a new place where he could live.

He came to believe that the world would allow him his madness if only he could express it beautifully enough, and so he returned to his pursuit of perfect expression with the passion of absolute necessity.

- VIII -

On the fourteenth day, Phil was asleep on the sofa while Des, Carl and Jonno sat up and smoked around the mixing desk.

“I’ve never seen anything like it,” Jonno said. “It’s like early Van one minute, *The Plastic Ono Band* the next... He’s Cohen, Floyd, Paul Simon, Bob Dylan... moves like Jagger... I’ve never seen anything like it.”

"Some of that instrumental stuff as well..." Carl said. "I can play with that and get some real dancefloor fillers. I know a few vocalists who'll claw my eyes out for the chance to sing the choruses. And I met this producer a couple of months ago, some guy called Old Scratch who'd take a look..."

"But it ain't just that," Jonno broke in. "It's like he's recording the history of 20th century music in one fucking drop! There's rock'n'roll, prog rock, blues, folk, indie... and some of those bits with Jessica on the cello were fucking killin' it."

They all basked for a moment.

"It's like real music again, for the first time in years. Someone who really gets it."

"But there's a lot of confusion as well," said Carl, staring at Des who sat motionless in deep thought. "And a lot of anger."

Des's eyes flicked to Carl for a moment and everyone knew he meant. "He's quite far gone isn't he."

There was a long pause while they stared at him sleeping.

"He's charismatic though; that's appealing."

"He's a fucking liability," said Des, almost as though it was final. "That's not very appealing to me."

"But if we can channel him..." Jonno trailed off.

"Do you know what I think's weird?" asked Carl.

"Oh please... where to begin!"

Carl laughed. "It's that he's got so much to say, but he's got no presence. I mean he's genuinely not on the socials anywhere. I can't find a fucking thing about him."

Des laughed. "That ain't the strangest thing," he said. "The strangest thing is that he's got so much to say about his life previously, and it all checks out. We've both been running him." He gestured at Carl.

"No way," Jonno cut in. "I could totally see him being a real loner. I mean he's a bit weird isn't he."

"No, that's not my point," Des cut back, laughing. "It's that... there needs to be a blank spot..." The others didn't see the point. "I don't understand *when he learnt to play the fucking guitar*," Des insisted. "He's a... he's fuckin'... I mean... I don't understand how someone that good has just wiped out ever having played it from his memory. And I don't think he's lying. And if this is a set-up... it's beyond complex. And now that I know him, I am absolutely sure that he doesn't have the where-with-all to plan this."

He continued to extrapolate: "Because at the moment he's just

blocked off that one single thing. He can remember everything else – he was talking to you guys about shit he’s seen online, you know, he’s confident about what he did – but he’s just got this blank spot for having played guitar. And I mean he’s been trashed - wasted - but there’s never been a crack in the story. Now that’s not normal.” He looked back at Carl and Jonno: “I mean it’s fucking weird, right.”

The three of them thought for a while.

“Do you think he’ll be alright?” Carl asked.

Des didn’t answer for a long time. Then he quietly conceded the point: “He’s a bit mental. And I’m not sure how the world’ll take to him. He’s definitely got a... niche that’s for sure. A big one. I mean he’s a working class hero isn’t he. Fucking rage against the machine and all that.”

“Is that still ok these days?”

“Yeah,” Des was quite casual about that. “They’ll let a bit of it through. As long as the working classes,” he laughed. “I can’t really call them that anymore - they wish they could work! But yeah, there’s money in it anyway - proper coin - if you can fill a stadium of Slum dwellers who all go home feeling like they’ve been understood. Anything that keeps the masses quiet has a payday. But is *he* that guy?” He pointed at Phil.

“They’ll love him!”

“But they won’t go home *peacefully* though will they. He’ll wind ‘em up and there’ll be a fucking riot. He’s got no restraint; he doesn’t know his limits.”

“But he’ll be popular,” Jonno confirmed. “There’s been no-one like him since...”

“I mean no-one will believe the idea that he’s never played guitar before anyway - just sounds like the worst kinda weird internet AI shit click-bait - but the music is great. And I do believe there’ll be a market for it. A big one.”

“So you’ll manage him?” Carl asked.

Des scratched his arm and shrugged and laughed. “I think he’s a fucking liability, but I’d be mad not to. We’ll make money. Decent money. Proper Coin.”

“He’s a fucking gold mine mate,” growled Jonno.

Des smiled. “You won’t need to worry about your CCS anymore Jonno. Your kid’s safe.” Jonno smiled back. “We just have to be careful... and manage him down. Keep him calm. This ain’t the sixties anymore. The people at the top aren’t nice and playful and patient. If

Phil loses his shit there'll be hell to pay."

"But he could do some good," Carl added. "Maybe a change is what we need."

Des laughed. "We'll make some money and get out. And if he fucks around, I'll fucking have him."

"I think you kinda like him," Carl said. "He's a bit like you used to be."

Des rubbed his eyes. "Used to be Carl; *used* to be."

"You don't think he can make a difference?"

Des shook his head. "I don't care. It's too entrenched now. There's cameras everywhere, we're all running scared of the CCS, fucking phones and microphones and... we're too far gone. There's only one way to go from here."

"But you get him though, eh," Carl pushed. "I've seen you Des. When he's on his rant and you get that fire in your eyes again..."

"I'm not that man anymore," Des insisted.

"But you were *there*, in the protests..." They both knew where he was going and they all paused. "You ever hear from Simon?" Carl asked.

Des laughed. "Fuck Simon. The guy's a fucking lunatic."

"What's he doing these days?"

"I don't wanna know. Dealing arms, drugs; he's deep in the Slums... I don't know. I don't wanna know." He really didn't want to talk about it. "That's over now."

"But you get his point?"

"Simon's?" Des was shocked that Carl would ask.

"No! Phil's..."

"Oh... No. Fuckit. It doesn't matter Carl! I'm not gonna let myself get dragged back into trying to change things that are already done. It's all over; the bad guys won; there's nothing we can do."

"Then why take him on at all, if it's such a risk?"

"Because I want to make some money Carl," Des said, with surety. "With enough Coin, we can all get the hell outta here." He pointed at Phil. "And that's our ticket."

They drifted back into silence. Behind them stood a man in a white t-shirt, into whose eyes Phil had been staring all the while as he drifted into sleep.

- IX -

That night Phil dreamt of the man in the white suit again.

"Yu've durn well, Philip," he said with a reassuring smile. "Ahm proud a ya. Ve'y proud a ya."

Then he moved aside and the dream was torn and Phil was standing on a stage in front of a crowd of millions.

Despite being alone on the stage, the crowd were so engrossed in their talk that no-one acknowledged Phil.

A sea of faces before him and not one of them saw him.

He felt a burning desire to raise his arms and shout.

And then he woke up.

- X -

It was a real cute pub they were in – proper country; locals and fireplaces and chatter. Phil was sitting in the corner of an L-shaped sofa, protected by the band, drinking Guinness and watching.

"I counted fifty-three original songs Phil," Des was saying. "Plus, there's countless bootlegs and off-cuts. It's a remarkable achievement. Incredible."

Phil smiled, but felt strangely hollow to the fact. Slightly sick at himself. He knew that this was just the comedown from the rush though. He knew it would pass.

He'd slept well, from before sunset to lunchtime the next day. Fourteen, fifteen hours. He'd woken and showered in the small ensuite and then gone downstairs to where the group were eating breakfast.

After they'd eaten they went back into the studio briefly, and Phil watched and listened as they added polish to a few of his songs and talked about the albums. He didn't interfere too much. He didn't disagree with anything they were doing. He felt a strange detachment to the music once it had been recorded. It was the performance that he truly loved and he was too tired to perform anymore.

During a natural lull in the afternoon, Phil snuck out and took a walk around the grounds.

The studio was sat on the side of a hill that overlooked a valley that was dotted with farms. Phil watched the landscape and saw something of the evolution of man in the ordered hedgerows, farm machinery,

and animal enclosures. Humanity evolved to inhabit its world, and then shaped the world according to its needs. This shift became a kind of self-perpetuating form of evolution, shaping itself from its former self, and it continued down this path.

Was it controlled? Was it designed? By who?

And if there was no design, as stood to reason, then wasn't it possible that we could be wandering in the wrong direction?

Was there a designer?

It seemed to Phil that society was shaped as a response to whatever was happening at the time – there didn't seem to be a long term plan anywhere. And if that was the case, wasn't it possible that we were just wandering blindly into an evolutionary cubl-de-sac?

Lou had said something about existing only in Phil's mind, along with all creation. Both Lou and the woman had also said that there were parts of our minds that existed without our being aware of them. But she'd also said that there were parts of our minds that sought to destroy us.

He looked back to the hillside and wondered whether our evolution could destroy us?

the wrong direction

He knew about global warming, economic meltdowns, political corruption, capitalist consumption, mechanised weaponry, social media puppeting, and the endless, cyclic periods of civil unrest that rose up and manifested themselves in war and revolt...

Civil unrest.

Surely that was the big one – and it was the only real reason behind war, everything else was just the narrative that historians created to pay their salaries..

He remembered the fall of Rome and remembered thinking once that there was no period in history more similar to the one we lived in than the fall of Rome.

He said it aloud: "We live in the fall of Rome."

And that realisation cut him as keenly as the realisations that came from his writing, and so he extended the thought and said, aloud: "We are entering into a Dark Age."

He stared at the landscape for a long time before returning to the studio.

After that he'd been quiet and the band decided to call it a day at around seven thirty, so they took him to the pub on the local village green for dinner and drinks.

"Fifty-three individual tracks," Des said. "With... countless incredible outtakes. You're gonna make more money from bootlegs than Al Capone."

"Yeah right," Mickey mumbled, rocking back and forth, still wired. "More than a... fucking... artificial, fucking, limb... salesman, you know. Or like a boot maker, who sells boots... stuff. For legs. That go in boots." He was breathing heavily.

They all let the comment pass. They were too tired to respond, and Mickey was too high to be reached.

"And there've been no people," Carl said with a smile. "It feels like a long time ago now."

Everyone went quiet.

"I wouldn't mind getting that video clip the kids took," Carl added, and Des nodded, aware of its importance. "Dunno how we'd find that."

"There'll have posted it already," Matty said. "There's a lot of Likes in that kind of clip."

"I've got the recording from the gig," Des said. "And Jimmy's got some HD footage too, and all the audio. It's gonna be gold dust, that is."

Phil shook his head slightly. He'd convinced himself that the guy in the white t-shirt who'd been in the studio was the same one who'd been cheering from the back of the gig, and he didn't want to think about it.

They ate their food and changed the subject.

A little later, Jonno was talking to Phil: "I lived in France for a few years..." he said and explained some of his life there.

Although Phil didn't always respond they kept him present in the conversation, which helped him from drifting off. He wasn't engaged though. In his head there was just white noise and a part of him wanted nothing more than to leave them all behind. But he was too tired to move.

"My brother was there, and we played in a band together. I met a girl, toured across the states, going in and out of Mexico. That's where I had my daughter. Me and the mum aren't together anymore, but she's happy and I see her as often as I can. What are you gonna do with yourself anyway Phil?"

Jonno was quite good with direct questions. He opened up first, and then asked something – almost like it was a trade.

It was the first time Phil had spoken for a while, but he was honest:

"I don't know what I'm gonna do next. I've got nothing really. I'd have to re-register for my CCS credit, and I think that would cost more than I have. I can't go back to Brighton. I mean I don't even think this month's rent's been paid..." He trailed off and realised that the end of the road was fast approaching and that he'd really just assumed there was a way it could continue.

Carl laughed, but handed the floor to Des with a gesture.

"I'll take you into town next week," Des said. "I've got plenty of credit, so I'll drop ten grand into your bank account, as an advance – a kinda loan that you don't have to repay."

That sounded a bit too good to be true.

"You see, this bit's a bit awkward Phil, because I know you don't know... anything – you're on another fucking planet, I know that – and I don't want to put pressure on you. But I'd quite like to manage you. I've got lots of industry contacts; I can do the job. I'm not the greatest advertiser, but a blind monkey could sell your music, and it saves you having to get anyone else involved. I mean I promise that I don't mean you any harm Phil..." he sat forward. "More than anything else, I promise that."

He was obviously having difficulty, so Phil cut in: "I don't want anyone else involved. I mean I trust you, but... I wanna be clear on this: you're gonna give me... ten thousand CCS credits? For real?"

Des laughed. "It's an advance, you know. On future sales."

"Right," was all Phil could think of to say. "For... sales. Because... you think we'll make... more than that?" He was very tired and it was a lot to take on.

The group all laughed then. "Yes," Des said. "I think we'll make more than that. We're going for coin with you, mate."

"And..." Phil's head was spinning, but he wasn't spun out so much that he couldn't find the downside. "That means you'll own all the music, is that right?"

"We'll..." Des struggled to start and didn't look like he wanted to get too drawn into it. "I mean we'll need to work out the details, to be honest, and like I say I can recommend some people who can advise you, but... it gets... I mean..."

Phil hated seeing him struggle. Des had real strength and character, and Phil had learnt to trust him in the studio, and so rather than watch him flounder he threw himself on his sword and said: "You know that you could ruin me really easily if you want. I don't know anything. You know that don't you? If this all ends, it'll be a rope for me. Or a

bridge. I'm not going back there Des."

Des shook his head and smiled - maybe he was salvageable after all; maybe this was a way in. "We're not after you for anything Phil. We'll all earn enough money from this to see us through." He sat forward: "Listen, all you need to worry about is holding yourself together ok. Stay peaceful, presentable, calm... We'll keep you out of the limelight and make sure you're well looked after."

Phil wasn't sure what to think, so Carl spoke up: "Don't worry about it Phil. But trust us, please. We won't let you down."

They all seemed very calm which helped Phil pull himself further together.

"Yeah. Sure. I think I'd like to keep my head down for a while," he said.

Des nodded. "I couldn't agree with you more."

- XI -

Later, Phil was outside smoking with Mickey.

It was difficult to know what Mickey was on - in truth it was pretty much most things - and he wasn't coming down in the same way as the others. He was a bit more aggressive. Not fighty aggressive, but restless and caged - like the kids with the camera. He was a bit of a teen, and Phil enjoyed talking to him. He was explaining about a dream he had of going away somewhere quiet and switching off. Mickey was trying to get Phil to record more.

"I mean, it's nuts man, all that stuff you sing. And I get it." He was shaking and pacing. "Cause you're just so far out there."

The band seemed to recognise how dangerous things were when you were as far out as Phil was, but to Mickey, Phil was a hero, a daredevil, and he acted like he wanted to push him harder. It made Phil wonder whether he could take it.

"Why don't you get real mashed up?" Mickey said, firmly. "Just do it once, for one night. Get as far out there as possible, and bring back a piece of what you find, you know? There's just one chance man."

And Phil wondered whether there was further to go; whether he could push it one more time.

Mickey took out a clear plastic baggy.

"You should just do it man. Take one last big step. Take the trip, man; get out there. Just do it, you know."

He reached inside and produced a small square of paper that rested on his fingertip. "This is good shit Phil. Clean refined. We'll get wasted. One last night. Finish it off."

He held up the finger and offered it to Phil. For a second it seemed inevitable that Phil would take it. The moment lasted long enough for Phil to open his mouth and let his tongue hang out slightly while Mickey touched the acid onto it, and Phil took a drink.

- XII -

Over the hour that followed, Phil forgot he'd taken the trip.

He'd gone out for a cigarette at one point, and looked at the moon and been struck by the wonder of it, and he'd understood that it was just an enormous rock that circled the earth, hundreds of thousands of miles away, in the vast silence of space. The eternal silence of space: a purer silence than he'd ever hear, deeper than he'd ever know. The kind of silence that couldn't exist on planet earth. Here, there was no silence. He held that thought a long moment, feeling himself drifting into it.

How could he understand the size of space?

And for a moment he did, as a feeling. He felt the enormity of space and he saw his place within it. But as he began to approach the infinite, his head backed out and he pulled himself away cautiously. She was out there somewhere, he thought, and became afraid of her. Then he pulled himself back inside himself and searched for the safety of Bill and Lou.

He was beginning to bend, and then he remembered that he'd taken a trip and was suddenly afraid of what would happen.

Then he went back inside, irrevocably changed for the experience.

- XIII -

They left not long after and headed down the long path between the fields, and back towards the studio. Phil's walking slowed until he fell behind, and then he wanted to lose them so he ducked into a field and

doubled back and headed across the black grass alone. He wanted to be somewhere that was only lit by the moon. The face that stared down from space.

He bent down and ran across the field like a commando, his eyes searching for the gleaming rock in the sky. As his eyes met it, he stumbled and fell, though he cared more for the moon and ended up rolling and twisting his body across the grass to keep it in his view.

He was lost in it. It was huge.

And it was coming closer. But it wasn't.

It was like that shot in *Jaws*, the one he took from *Vertigo*, that had Roy Scheider getting closer to the camera and moving away at the same time, while the Kitner boy got eaten.

This gleaming rock that hung in the sky amidst the vastness of the infinite. Fucking hell. He got dizzy just lying on the ground and felt sure he could feel the earth turning at speed.

The stars suddenly ceased to be a flat blanket of night, and became a three dimensional space that was full of huge balls of fire that were unfathomable distances away from each other, and from Phil. He was suddenly stuck to a floating rock that ambled through infinite blackness, around the sun that lit this moon.

Why didn't he fall off the earth, to be lost in the gulf?

The rock of the earth was sanity and Phil's mind was breaking free from the security it offered, and now he would be lost in the infinite, and the thought terrified him.

The balance was fragile. He was expendable.

We all were.

"Everything is, Phil," said a face that suddenly appeared in the moon, but spoke from deep inside his head.

It was the woman from his dream.

He tried to turn and jump to his feet, but his legs gave way and all he did was throw himself forward, sprawled across the grass. And then she was in front of him, and the stars themselves were woven into the fabric of her dress, and the infinite in her eyes.

She laughed. "Yes Philip, I'm back. You took acid and now I'm back."

Phil was mumbling profanities, as he pushed himself up on all fours and he started weeping as he felt her crawling inside his mind. She was carving a cold space inside him and it hurt.

"Get out. Get out. Get out!" He had to speak. He had to push her away. He moved to his feet and forced them to take his weight.

"No!" she barked. "Now look at me!"

He stumbled backward and fell, staring at her.

"I'm holding your guts," she said, cupping her hand.

And then she slowly squeezed and Phil felt a terrible wrenching inside of him, like someone was performing an operation without sedatives; it was the pain he knew so well, but this was so much more powerful, and he had no control over it. It felt like acid was leaking inside him and he screamed.

"You're going nowhere!" she drawled. "You think you can lead this? You'll be alone and you'll fail and you'll die alone, and no-one will dare whisper your name again."

It was crushing Phil. "Oh JESUS CHRIIIIST!" he screamed.

"Don't you *fucking* mention his name!" She screamed back.

"You step away from him Ange'la," came another voice from behind Phil. "He is mah surn and I will stay by his sahd."

The burning dimmed for long enough that Phil could see Lou approaching in his blinding white suit, and for a moment, Phil thought that the light of the moon had taken on form to save him. He scrambled to his feet and began to run.

"Get out of here, Lou," he heard her shout. "You're banished!"

"He's mah son, and they're mah children an ahm comin' home, and you ain't gettin' rid a me. I will faiht fa thehm!"

Phil staggered across the field, stumbling in potholes and heading for the distant gate. And then she was in front of him, and she flicked her arm towards him and he was thrown back, violently cracking his spine on a divot.

"You can't escape from me," she barked. "I am Angela Gabriels!"

And then she placed her hands together in prayer and rose into the sky with a dark starlight radiating from her, and a dark cloak that was formed from all the hope in Phil's world.

"I am the Angel Gabriel, Messenger of the one true God, and our will is *done*."

"And I am Lucifer," called a voice from behind Phil, and another Angel began to rise. This one was larger, and heavier, and it glowed like a polarised picture. "I am the fallen father and the leader of man, and my time is become again."

And then a scream crept in and all light drained from the world, and there was no black grass anymore, and no field, and there were no trees lit by silver moonlight; there was just an infinite pitch blackness, a silver disk of moon and two dark Angels rising into the sky, leaking

power that took the form of paralysing emotions that fought for space inside Phil's mind. The scream became louder, until, defeated by it, Phil put his hands to his head and let out an almighty cry.

And then he felt someone attack him and he lashed out and punched flesh, and then he was grappled to the ground and although he fought and kicked and shouted, there were too many of them, and he was held.

- XIV -

He must have passed out at that point, because when he opened his eyes again he was back in the living room of the cottage near the studio.

"You're a fucking cunt Mickey," Jonno barked. "Oh shit he's awake." Then he blinked twice and had to sit down before he fell. "Fuck me."

"I can't believe you're all wasted," Des said.

Carl was suddenly in front of Phil, his eyes wide open and worried. "Are you alright, man? I'm sorry, man, I'm fucking sorry. Man, you're alright though. We're all tripping." He was nodding and Phil withdrew himself into the sofa.

Des came towards Phil, but leant far too close, forcing Phil to withdraw. "Are you alright mate?" Des asked, and Phil realised that he hadn't leant in at all, because he was still on the other side of the room.

"I think it's important for you to understand what's happened here," Des said. "Mickey gave you a trip, ok?"

And Phil remembered it.

"You're all tripping, alright," Des said. "So this... bit of it... is... it's not real. It doesn't have to be, you know."

He held the silence for a bit. Matty mumbled: "Are you alright man?" but it was a little pointless and everyone ignored it.

Phil looked at them all. Sitting in different parts of the room and for a moment he saw them poised. There was a click as Jonno took a photo.

"For fuck's sake, give it a rest," Des snapped.

"Sorry," Jonno mumbled, carefully placing the camera onto what he thought was the table, but actually just dropping it onto the floor. "Shit." Then he sat down onto what he thought was a chair but since it was actually a small coffee table it collapsed. Under normal

circumstances, for a room full of people on acid, that would have set them off, but the slapstick was lost in here.

"Look... I'm alright though." Des seemed to say that partly to remind himself of the fact, and partly for everyone else, and partly because he knew he was being challenged and it firmed his resolve to take control: "Look, we're all gonna be alright, you know. It'll pass over."

And then Phil noticed who was sitting in the armchair.

It was the young guy with the white t-shirt on. He was nodding at what Des was saying, and he looked calm and calming.

"Look after them," said the man in the white t-shirt.

"I'm gonna look after the lot of you," Des said, with a tone that sounded like it was a self-depreciating joke and it raised the room slightly.

"Especially Phil," the man in the white t-shirt said. "Look after Phil the most."

"But you're my man Phil," Des said. "You're my man."

Phil allowed the statement to settle him, and his eyes drifted down to the guy on the chair, who smiled and said: "It'll be alright."

Des repeated him.

Then Phil said: "There's someone over there."

He felt the room turn to ice, and the guy in the chair winced slightly.

"What do you mean?" Des asked.

Phil stared at the guy. He knew that he wasn't supposed to say any more but he repeated himself anyway: "There's someone sitting in that chair." Phil stared at him in defiance.

The room didn't move. Des calmly raised his game, knowing, when he'd taken charge, that this would be a long night.

"Where?" Des asked, calmly. "In this chair?" He approached the guy but gestured to what he thought was an empty chair.

"Yes," Phil said.

"Ok..." Des said, then added in a tone that tried to make this seem as normal as hallucinating on a trip should be. "What's he doing?"

The guy didn't do anything for a moment, as if thinking. Then he leant forward and said: "Maybe don't tell them about me, Phil. Maybe that would be better."

"He's asked me not to tell you about him," Phil said.

There was silence in the room. Everyone was staring at the chair. Then Jonno said: "Look, Des, is it alright if I just go with this. I mean, like, as part of a trip. I think that's what Phil needs at the moment."

"Yeah right," Matty said. "He's wearing a white t-shirt."

Phil stared at him. "A white t-shirt, jeans and..." he looked down. "Slippers."

The guy shrugged slightly: "I was cold," He said.

"He says he was cold," Phil repeated.

"Fucking hell," said Jonno, waving his hands around in front of his face, and then suddenly becoming very drawn into mapping his veins.

Carl wouldn't look at the chair, Matt was just standing still and blinking really hard and staring at the floral carpet and then Mickey left the room.

Des took a deep breath.

"Why don't you just play some music," the man said.

"I think you should just play some music guys," Des said, before adding, with some determination: "I think that would help."

- XV -

They moved into the studio, to where Mickey had already retreated, and took up their instruments. It took a while to get going because they were all playing different songs. Sometimes they did get into playing the same thing, but it wasn't long before someone got lost and the music fell away. Phil could see the guy in the white t-shirt in the recording booth with Des. It looked like he was talking to him, but Des wasn't responding.

Phil sat down at one point, with his acoustic, and stopped playing. And then the guy was next to him.

"Don't react Phil," he said. "I'm sorry about this, I have to be here for a bit. Do you understand? I need to look after you." He spoke in a tone of voice that was so easy to hear.

"Look, I don't mind you seeing Angela again," he said. "Some other time, once you're ok, but for now she should stay away. Is that alright?"

It was all fine apart from the bit about seeing her again.

"It's up to you," the guy said. "I'm Ben by the way. Ben Lial. I'll look after you for a bit, alright?"

Phil didn't respond.

"You could help me by playing some music though, and I'll try and make sure they're all playing along with you."

Ben waited for a moment, and Phil saw him close his eyes and it was like Phil could feel him reaching inside and settling him. He felt like a child being held, gently, and supported through his whole frame. He let Ben move his hands until they cradled the guitar. The band stopped playing and stared at Phil. Phil wondered if they could see Ben. The guitar didn't feel right in his hands and he let it fall to the floor.

Ben thought for a minute. "Do you wanna play the piano Phil?" he asked.

"Can I play piano?"

"If you want," Ben said.

"I would like to play the piano," Phil said. "I'd like to play a sad song on the piano."

"Ok," Ben said. "Then we can go over there."

Phil got up and allowed Ben to lead him across the studio floor, towards the grand that Jessica had been using. Jonno was backing away so fast he stumbled on his monitor and fell over.

"DES!" he shouted. "Fucking shit Des! He's gonna play the piano!"

"Shut up Jon," Des hissed over the speakers.

Phil sat down and looked at Ben.

"You can play the piano Phil," Ben said.

And Phil replied: "I don't want to wake up Ben. I wanna stay here forever. And I want you to protect me from her."

Ben smiled. "This is your world, Phil. I'm just here to look after you."

Phil couldn't move for a long moment. He stared at Ben who slowly backed away from him.

Phil still didn't play, so Ben spoke softly into Mickey's ear and Mickey looked at Phil desperately. And Phil realised that Mickey needed the music. He needed for Phil to recover. But that was ok, because he would recover. He didn't understand what was happening to him, but he never had. None of this made sense, nothing, not since the moment he'd been born. He'd promised himself that he wouldn't let them down. He would play for them.

He raised his hands to the piano and brought his left hand down hard, rippling a steady stream of bass. Then he brought his right hand into play. It was different, this hand. The high notes. The themes. He closed his eyes and heard the right hand as icicles that hung from the glacier of the left. Phil could shift the ice in waves, like the passing of an age or the movement of the earth. He calmed himself and heard it

deeper. The left hand was the sea, the tides that came and went, while the right was the life within it. The free-thinking, free-forming life that played. It was like the left hand was the parent, an older, deeper, rhythmic breath; while the right was youth and movement. The left was the roots and the trunk – and the tree itself – while the right hand was the birds. The left was the state; the right wanted to rise.

Then Phil began to speak, gently over the music:

*She shaped us all in Eden
The womb where nothing could touch us
Until Satan sowed his seed
And we were born into the wilderness.*

*But she couldn't handle that
So she banished him as well
And he moved into a one room flat
And the sign on the door said: Welcome to Hell.*

*The Devil is my father
I'm sorry I done you wrong
I shouldn't have ever believed her
I needed to feel like I belonged*

The band didn't play, it was just Phil, on his piano, softly holding a rhythm that he recited over:

*She told me once to kill my son
For fear I loved him more than she
Like every mother fears her child
Will leave her nothing but memories.*

*She bastardised my father's name
And made me burn his effigy.
She turned all his power against him
And left him lost and bitter and angry.*

*The Devil is my father
I'm sorry I let you down
I was a fool to ever believe her
I shouldn't have driven you out*

*I swear I won't ever believe her
I shouldn't've let you down*

Phil continued with his piano after he'd finished the lyrics. After a half dozen or so bars Mickey entered with a bass, and then Carl's samples grew and then Jonno and Matty joined them and they were playing a new song now, under the orchestration of Ben, the man in the white t-shirt and slippers.

- XVI -

"I don't know what to do with it," Des said, honestly. "It's musically... fascinating but fuck knows what you're banging on about. You're just mumbling incoherent nonsense over the top."

Des was being slightly aggressive about the whole thing, though it had been a long night – and an even longer morning. Settling the band down was a job that had taken over four hours and now only Phil and Des sat up.

"I can remember... having this discussion inside my head," Phil said. "It was like I was dreaming, like I wasn't in control. I can hardly remember being in the studio at all."

It was past noon on the morning after they'd taken the trip, and Phil was still high, though it had settled into a calm, open and comfortable space.

"I think it's probably best... not to release this," Des said. He rewound the tape to a point where Phil was talking: 'Can I play the piano?' he'd asked. There was silence. 'I'd like to be able to play the piano,' Phil had said.

"And at that point," Des continued, "you got up, and walked across the room, and played the fucking piano like someone who's done nothing but play it for their entire life."

Phil was staring at Des, and trying not to notice that Ben was sitting next to him.

"Is he still there?" Des asked, pointing at the point where Phil was staring.

"Yeah," Phil replied.

Ben looked slightly embarrassed. He hadn't spoken for hours.

"It worries me," Des said. "Having visions and singing songs about

wanting to change the world is one thing. But you go out there as the son of fucking Satan, and it means something different. Do you understand?"

Phil understood it in theory, though it didn't seem as big an issue as Des made it out to be.

"Do you think that God's speaking to you?" Des asked in a comfortable tone of voice that encouraged Phil to discuss it.

Phil wasn't sure where to turn, so he tried to just be honest: "I don't know what's happening to me," was the first thing he said. "But I think I'm... whatever I'm going through, has... got some... religious angle. It was Lucifer and the Angel Gabriel that I saw in the field. And I'm pretty sure Bill is the Devil, and the woman on the South Bank, I think she was called Trina Tee – like the Trinity."

"Fucking hell!" Des laughed and rubbed his temples. "Trina Tee? She sounds like the Italian entry to the Eurovision *fucking* Song Contest!"

Phil didn't reply.

"And this guy's Ben? And the other one's Bill?" Des was clearly a little irate. "You've got Bill and Ben inside your head, is that what you're saying?"

Phil was being crushed. The whole thing seemed utterly fanciful. One minute it was so grand it seemed hideously pompous, the next it was ridiculous, like some Monty Python farce.

"I just need you to keep this down," Des said, as though it was the most reasonable favour in the world.

He shook his head free of something and then yawned and clenched his teeth. Given the circumstances, Des had done a remarkable job keeping everything together.

"Look, I'm gonna keep all this on file here," he said, referring to the recording. "But I don't want to release it now, ok? I think it'd be a little much at the moment."

Phil nodded.

"Are you tired?" Des asked.

Phil shook his head.

"Well, I think this place needs some time away from you anyway. I've got to be back in London today. This lot'll have to sort themselves out, but why don't you come back with me? I owe you some money as well. We'll talk about management and contracts another time."

Phil nodded.

Ben, who sat next to Des, waited for a beat, and then he raised his

hand like a conductor and Des said: "There's a friend of mine with an empty Airbnb in Pimlico that you can stay in. I've got things to do, so you'll be on your own but I'll leave you with my number, and a phone, and you should call me if anything happens. Or if you feel..." This seemed hard for Des, almost as though he was surprised by what he was saying. "Just call me if you need anything."

"I'll be alright." Phil said, and reminded himself that whatever happened, it was only in his mind.

Ben looked across at him and smiled reassuringly.

The Setup

*Everything possible to be believed
is an image of truth*

- I -

The flat Des took him to consisted of one huge room of dark wood, with walls that were lined with art. Books, movies and music packed the shelves while framed pictures filled the spaces in-between. Around the floor, in every corner, there was somewhere to relax, and be warm and safe.

Ben had left Phil alone for the journey, allowing him to sleep intermittently. Des woke him when they arrived, and showed him around and stayed for a cup of tea.

"So you gonna be alright?" he asked, leaning on a kitchen counter, his arms crossed in an attempt to look calm and reassuring. "You've got a phone now. I said you'd lost yours and paid the fee. It's got enough Credit for you as long as you don't go wild!" He smiled, though there was a sadness behind it.

Des was a big guy, Phil noted. He'd not really noticed that before. Back in the day he would have been formidable, and he still carried the air of an ex-prize fighter. There was something about him that suggested he'd lost more often than he'd won, but fought well above his weight.

"Yeah, I think I could do with being on my own for a bit to be honest." Phil was reasonably clear on it now.

"What I would say, though," Phil added, knowing that despite the fact that he was currently more tired than he'd ever been before, he was still too wired to sleep. "I would say if you don't hear from me in a couple of days, check I'm alright, ok?"

Des laughed. "I'll call you tomorrow," he said with some certainty. "I think you need to get some sleep, and this place is great for it. The fridges are stocked, so it's perfect to relax. I mean if you can't be ok here then..." He trailed off realising that it was quite possible Phil

would find a way to not be ok here, but not wanting to say it aloud.

Des was clearly having to tear himself away, which made Phil feel a bit like he was being dropped off at uni.

"It's mostly pretty easy to cook food," Des added, opening a kitchen cupboard to check the contents. "I mean I didn't know whether you could cook..." Then he laughed and added: "But you could probably... turn the... water... into wine, you know." Then he met Phil in the eye and grinned: "Make bread from the books."

Phil laughed and felt invigorated by the joke. "To be honest, I have trouble turning bread into toast," he said.

- II -

Phil had been sitting on the sofa for no more than a minute or two before Ben appeared.

"You're getting good at this," he said with a grin.

Phil stared at him, unsure how to respond.

Ben looked like he wanted to launch into something, but sympathetically held himself back. "How are you doing?"

Phil stared back, unmoving.

"Wild times, eh?" Ben said with a soft smile.

For a while Phil didn't want to hear anything - he didn't want to engage - and so he sat and stared at Ben, picking out the details in his face and hair; the gentle way he rubbed his fingers against each other from time to time; the soft blink of his eyes while he waited. He looked soft, and kind; but young and naive as well.

"What's going on?" Phil asked at last. "Who are you?"

Ben smiled with a visible sense of relief but then paused and shrugged slightly and sighed before he answered. "That's a very good question. And it's not as easy to answer as I'd like." He paused so he could phrase himself: "Who do *you* think we are? What's your feeling for us?"

"Who's us?"

"Me and Bill and Lou - Nick..."

"Angela? Trina?"

"Yeah. Her lot as well."

"I think you're the Devil, and she's God," Phil said.

Ben shrugged. "Kinda..." Then shuffled around a little excitedly,

like he was preparing a magic trick. Then he grinned. "Listen, you've got a lot of questions. But we've got... answers, so perk up and listen. This is the bit of the book where the plan becomes clear."

Phil laughed at the reference and calmed. Ben wasn't like any of the others. He was younger and fresher and seemed smarter and sharper and quicker of tongue.

"Alright," Ben said, stretching his arms out, like a magician again. "Basically," he began. "Yes: I do only live inside your mind. But where else would I be?" He paused, pointing at his head. "I am a creation of your consciousness. Just like *everything* else in the world." He let that hang for a moment. "You fancy a glass of wine?" he asked and Phil noticed that a glass of red wine had appeared on the coffee table. "Drink it," Ben said.

Phil looked at it. It wasn't real. It was only in his mind. Also, Ben had just appeared in the room so he couldn't be real either. He was just in his mind. As soon as Phil became aware of the fact, the glass of wine disappeared, though Ben remained.

"I'm slightly different," Ben conceded with a shrug that recognised the fact that he was still there.

"What are you?" Phil asked, trying to engage.

Ben paused for a moment, before saying: "I'm the Devil Phil. I'm Ben. Lial. B. Lial. Belial." He shrugged. "You made us, I guess. We live in the collective subconscious of your people."

"You don't seem much like the Devil," Phil said almost without pause. And he didn't. Ben seemed quite friendly.

"Well, it is said that all things Divine must take on human form to be more palpable to man." He smiled: "You're creating this, not me."

"So you're just in my mind?" Phil asked.

"Yes," Ben replied. "But so is *everything* else in the world!" Then he smiled: "This is going to take a while if we have to go over everything twice."

"Who's Bill?"

"I think he's Bill Z. Bubba, isn't he," Ben suggested. Then added, just to make sure Phil was clear: "Beelzebub, you know."

Phil smiled.

"Lou is Louis Charles Fir, I think. Lucifer. Old Nick is just Old Nick - more of a folk tale these days I suppose..." Phil didn't know how to respond for a moment. He'd always been interested in religion, but not so much that he was awed by Ben's claim or drawn into bathos for the ridiculousness of their names. He was more perturbed by the fact that

someone was appearing in his room.

"What about Graham Hall?" he asked at length.

Ben paused a little here: "You made him up as well," he said. "Ironically, a lot of people find it easier to express themselves through someone else. I think you created this character - this mask - to help you get back in touch with yourself. Graham was your dad's middle name, and I think the Hall thing. I think that was to do with collective... worship. Togetherness. Gatherings. It was what you were... looking for... from this persona."

"But Bill told me about Graham Hall."

"But Bill's just a part of you."

"So you're just in my imagination? You're not really the Devil."

Ben's shoulders sank slightly. "It's difficult. We are separate to you, but also created by you. And not just you, but... *you* as a people. That's how we exist, but that's how *reality* exists as well. Look..." He gestured to the table and another glass of wine appeared. This one was in a strange looking glass that vaguely reminded Phil of a medieval banquet or a Holy Grail.

"It's not real," Phil said.

"Nothing is," Ben replied. "And yet... *everything* is." He smiled; then his smile turned slightly sad. "As I said, it's complicated. And, as I've already said, this is going to be a drag for everyone if I have to explain everything *thrice!*" He laughed.

"What do you want from me?" Phil asked.

Ben smiled. "Personally, nothing. I don't need anything - I am a God, after all. I think Bill has a plan. I just wanted to see you before I leave really. I wanted to say how proud I am of you. We've thrown a helluva lot at you and you've always come back for more. You took all that music and worked with it like an absolute champ. I've really enjoyed being with you and supporting you and I am grateful for who you are. I'm proud of you." Then he added, in a tone that Phil found deeply disconcerting: "And I am sorry for what you're... about to go through."

"Fuck off," Phil replied, almost before thought.

Ben smiled. "In many ways, that's my favourite part of you, ya dickhead. I hope we get to see it some more." Then he continued: "And remember this Phil: we are all just stories: narrative fiction the lot of us. So make *your* story. Write it. And become a *fucking legend* my man. Shine so bright that they never forget your name."

"What do you want from me?" Phil asked again.

Ben grinned, like a mate inviting him on a mission.

"For that you'll need to speak to Bill," he said: "I think he wants you to help him re-write a story."

"What story?" Phil asked.

Ben smiled. "The greatest story ever told."

Phil smiled. He could live with that: he'd be the lead role in the greatest story ever - with a heroic ending to boot. And then Phil spotted the glass of wine in front of him, and in a second he reached for it but knocked it over.

Ben laughed, lightly. "It's interesting that when you finally accepted it was real... you knocked it over. You might want to have a think about that." Phil watched it drip onto the carpet and by the time he looked back up, Ben was gone.

- III -

Phil's eyes drifted around the flat but ended up back on the drink that dripped onto the carpet. He wondered whether he'd poured it himself but had forgotten doing it. Ben suddenly seemed a long time ago, or far, far away.

How could this fit into the reality he knew? Wasn't it just a long, deep dream?

But he could play the guitar.

He must have forgotten that.

amnesia

He'd had a breakdown. Amnesia. But who was Ben then?

And who was he before?

He was in some world beyond the breakdown.

"Fuckit!" he growled and went to the kitchen to get another glass of wine - a real one. As he walked, he looked back at the table but the glass and the stain were now gone. The whole thing had been a dream. He knew that now.

He went to the cupboard for a bottle and took the opener from the kitchen drawer. By the time he turned back around, Bill was standing by the kitchen counter, staring at him, and looking a little austere.

"Hello Phil," he said. "You okay?"

Phil didn't answer. He felt slightly sick again.

"It's alright," Bill said, softly. Then he gently swayed and closed his

eyes, and winced, and hummed from deep inside himself and Phil began to relax.

"I think I'm going mad," Phil said.

Bill laughed a little. "Compared to everyone else around here, you're batshit, mate. But that's ok, because you're also closer to the truth than any of them."

- IV -

The truth was that Ben had left Phil a little confused. He seemed fun and playful, but Phil didn't feel the same way about what was happening to him. It wasn't fun anymore; and he didn't feel like playing a game until he knew the rules. But Bill wasn't like Ben. He was less pompous than Lou and more together than Nick; Bill seemed more like the grown up in the room.

Bill had settled himself on one of the stools by an island that stood between the living space and the kitchen. Phil remained at a distance, leaning on one of the kitchen counters. Despite the strangeness of it all Phil let himself accept Bill's presence. The flat had a kind of comfortable intimacy that seemed to encourage dreaming - and there was still an element of the dream about Bill. It was possibly the remains of Mickey's acid still leaving his system, but it was also clearly more than that. His life had been strange enough over the past little while and his desire to challenge things had been pretty much been worn away to nothing.

"I know you've been through a lot," Bill said. "And I'm sorry to have to ask for more." He paused. Phil didn't respond. He would, but he was in control of his own destiny and he wasn't being pushed into anything. "How are you feeling?" Bill asked.

Phil shrugged.

Bill waited.

"What's happening to me?" Phil asked.

Bill waited again.

"I mean who are you? What do you want?"

"I'll try to keep this as clear as possible..." Bill started.

"Fucking hell," Phil mumbled. "None of this is clear."

Bill laughed. "Take a breath and... I think we should sit down." He

gestured to the armchair in the living space. Phil didn't really want to go anywhere. "Sit down," Bill said and somehow Phil was suddenly in the chair. Not flumped in it, but comfortable and even he had to accept that he felt more at ease here. Bill was now sitting opposite him, perched on a footstool in front of the fireplace.

"It's ok to be weird about this," Bill said. "It's fucking weird, I know."

Phil didn't respond.

Bill cleared his throat. "So you know who we are," Bill said.

"You're the Devil," Phil said, as an accusation.

"I'm a God," Bill corrected. "Or that's how I seem to you guys anyway."

"So you made us?" Phil asked.

Bill shrugged and looked down at himself. "We're... from the same source, I suppose." Then he continued quickly, before Phil had time to respond; "But the important thing is that, here, I'm an adult, and you are a child. I'm older than you. Wiser."

"So what do you want from me?" Phil asked.

"Tell me about yourself," Bill said. "But not *you*. Tell me about about your people. Tell me about humanity. How do you think you're doing?"

Bill left the question to hang, and Phil knew what he was getting at. He thought hard before answering: "We're not doing so well at the moment... we're very clever and we make amazing things but I don't think... we're... safe or secure or... I don't see a bright future for my people..." he trailed off. "Society's fucked. The economy's a mess and everyone seems to know it but no-one seems to be able to fix it or even talk about it properly; we're divided and that's getting worse and it feels like we're slipping back into something that we used to be. I feel like..."

"You're in big fucking trouble is what you mean," Bill interrupted, a little aggressively.

Phil had no reply.

"I want to be clear here, you understand?" Bill's tone made Phil feel like a kid who was in serious trouble. "You're *fucked*. You're making an absolute mess of evolution and if you don't sort your shit out soon there's a very real danger you'll wipe out *all life on planet earth*. Now is that clear enough?"

Phil had to admit that it was clear; and, as it happens, he didn't disagree. And also, for that moment he understood the depth of Bill's

meaning: everyone knew that humans had been reckless and that there would have to be a reckoning but, for that moment anyway, he understood just what that really meant.

Bill listed it anyway: "Your obsession with capitalism - and systems in general - your reckless use of tech, your psychotic destruction of the planet, and your complete inability to discuss anything. On their own, each of them is manageable but the fact that they're all coming together means that you're in real fucking trouble."

Phil became defensive: "Yeah alright. Everyone knows that! It's not new news..."

"But I don't think *everyone* understands," Bill replied.

"They do! They just don't care."

"Good. Well then that's your first goal: You need to make them care."

"I'm not sure *I* care - fuck 'em. Humanity's fucked... I hate people."

"You don't understand what you're saying."

"No I do, *Bill*," he spat the name out. "I understand very well. I just don't care anymore." He kinda knew he didn't mean it, but he went on anyway: "I was happy enough killing myself on Brighton seafront before dick-head and his guitar turned up!"

"Fuck off!" Bill drawled. "Grow up mate."

Phil laughed. "I didn't ask for this!"

Now Bill laughed. "You think life is a fucking restaurant? Pick it off a menu and get what you want? You're kidding yourself. Even you don't believe that. You don't get to choose what you live. You deal with it like everyone else."

There was a pause between them.

"And what if I don't want this? What if I don't want to make people care?" It wasn't that Phil didn't want it, whatever it was (even he had to admit that the whole thing was vastly more interesting than his previous life,) but he did like challenging Bill. He felt like he was finally able to shout at authority in a way he'd never been able to before. People in authority didn't ever want people like Phil, and the fact that he was now central to something important meant a lot to him.

"If you walk away?" Bill asked. "What then?"

Phil glared back.

Bill smiled and - just for a second - Phil saw the devil in his lips.

Bill waved a hand and the world of the flat dripped away and for a moment they were in an empty space, and then it filled with a series of

high speed film clips within which he saw the corruption, greed and selfishness that appeared daily on the news, but as he saw it he knew that the news only ever reflected the tip of an iceberg. Society was *vast*, and the hidden stories were the worst.

He saw the poverty and desperation; children dying, alone in the snow, in the desert, in the rubble; he saw corrupted, egotistical leaders rising to power and playfully throwing bombs around like party crackers.

And then he heard a noise, a distant rumble, and without even turning his head he knew that the planet was rising against us: tsunamis and earthquakes and hurricanes and flooding... deforestation and climate change ... the indefatigable tide of nature turning against us...

we were a people who turned on ourselves
while our planet crumbled

And then the inevitable wars: The Far East, The Middle East, Africa, Europe, the Americas...

Countless species facing extinction...

and now it was our turn...

The earth was barren.

A simple rock, orbiting the sun; lifeless and burnt and - like so many other planets scattered across the universe - destined to forever remain that way.

And then they were back in the flat again, and Phil was broken but staring at Bill who looked back with eyes that burnt in a rage. "If you do nothing, then your people will wipe out all life on planet Earth," Bill said. "And I can't stand by and let that happen."

It wasn't just the vision that had taken him in: he'd felt it all. The weight of the deaths and the barren wasteland that was all that remained.

"What can I do?" Phil asked. And he'd meant it. In truth, if you'd looked deep inside his head he'd assumed there was some creature that he had to face and for a moment he was a comic-book Superhero tasked with challenging the beast and toppling it in a moment of glory. There was a part of him that bubbled with excitement at the prospect.

Bill shook his head. "If there was a fucking baddie Phil, you could do that. This is a little tougher. Listen, let me explain something." He looked off and around the room while he contemplated something. Phil had the feeling that Bill didn't really need to think this through, but the moment of pause allowed him to gather himself together again.

"So, reality is just a... concept," Bill began. "You know that. It's a very useful one as it happens. If there is one thing that's important for all emerging species, it's the presence of a shared reality. But alongside general principles like reality – which are kind of necessary anyway – we gave you rules that would help you to evolve out of the circumstances into which you were born. We all designed those rules suit the environment you grew up in, and the unique struggles that you'd face. This is why the Koran, the Bible, the Torah, the Bhagavad-Gita, the Tripitaka and all the rest are unique – though their core messages remain the same. But the problem you've got at the moment is that you're not *evolving* those rules. Do you understand?" Bill paused, and then repeated himself: "*Religion* is not *evolving* and that's what's dragging you down." He stopped and let that hang.

"You see, there are three pillars upon which your existence is built," he said, and drew an equilateral triangle in the air with his finger; it appeared like a shimmering neon strip-light that hovered in the space between them.

"Science explores and understands the accepted truths of the collective subconscious. Science explores what you call reality, its job is to understand what *is*." He gestured to one corner of the triangle and a small test tube appeared, bubbling gently.

"On the other corner is art." A small paint pallet appeared next to another corner of the triangle. "I mean, the icon here is painting but this refers to all art really: music, films, books..." Small, dancing avatars appeared, symbolising different artistic forms; and at the same time a range of different scientific symbols appeared in their corner.

"The job of art is to show what *could* be. The role of the artist is to be free and creative and to offer infinite options and interpretations. It should help science raise its head from the limiting confines of reality and see opportunities it may not have thought of alone. The two work together: What *is*, and what *could* be.

"And the third pillar upon which your world is built doesn't say what the world is – like science – or what could be – like art – it says what *should* be, and it is religion." A small huddle of religious icons now appeared next to the third corner of the triangle.

"If the three concepts work together, to balance each other out, then society can evolve sustainably, and eternally." He reached out and tapped one corner of the triangle and it began to spin gently. As it span, from just inside each of the corners, the triangle left a trail that drew a simple circle that the shape now rode on.

"Between the three of them they are a kind of periodic table for your understanding of the world. They are your... reality, in its simplest form."

Bill waved his hands and the icons changed to words: what is, what could be, what should be.

"Society must balance the needs of all three in order to evolve sustainably. Religion's role in your society is to manage moral judgements – what *should* be – and at the moment it is failing terribly."

Bill waved his hand and the shape disappeared in an almost digital puff of smoke. Through the smoke Phil saw Bill staring back at him: "In fact, the state of religion – your ability to make moral judgements – is so bad at the moment that you're in danger of wiping yourselves out."

"So what am I then? Some kind of Messiah?" Phil asked in a tone that sounded like he was ready to reject it all, though that excited bubbling his guts returned as he began to realise just what was being asked of him.

"I'm going to make sure that you become the most famous man on planet earth," Bill said, as if to confirm the thought. "And then I'm gonna help you do something incredible with it." He leant forward reassuringly as he spoke.

"A Messiah," Phil whispered, in awe of himself.

Bill sat back. "Easy tiger." He laughed. "Honestly, you're always better off making large structural changes with support. I'd rather you weren't a figurehead, myself. More a... catalyst. So don't try and do this alone," he added, though Phil was already slightly lost.

"Why did you choose me?" he asked.

Bill did think for a moment then. "You're a dreamer. You see we live in the collective subconscious of your people - we're dreams, if you like - but collective dreams. We're ideas, concepts that you all agree on. All religions include references to the importance of silent reflection - prayer and meditation are basically the same thing; just a moment of silence to reconnect with the space within. You've lived almost your entire life like this which meant we could access you. But then we did something else that was important. What was that?"

Were you to look at him, you'd say that Phil paused while he thought; in fact he just paused, unable to think.

"Express yourself," said Bill.

"I don't know," Phil replied. "I'm thinking."

"No," Bill laughed. "I meant what we *did* was make you express

yourself. We taught you how to reconnect with yourself, through art. Remember that no part of the triangle lives in isolation. Expressing yourself through art takes you closer to that inner voice where we live - where the Gods live - where the voice of your species lives. Connecting to your own subconscious, and the collective subconscious, through art, makes you better people. And it will help heal the rift in your people and you can avoid the destruction to come."

"So you want me to... sing my songs and promote... art and through that... the world will change?"

"No Phil, I just said that you can't do this alone. I want you to teach the world to sing! To paint, to dance, to make films, act in plays, sew a fucking quilt... to create meaningfully, but without any other meaning than the one the creator invests in it. Help the world to express themselves, but for money or fame, for... the joy of being alive... and you can heal the rift."

"It sounds a little... weak," Phil said, suddenly remembering the world he was going out into. "I think we're a little past the art therapy phase to be honest."

"Phil, you just taught yourself guitar in an evening; you played piano like a maestro, never having sat at one before; you've made things appear out of thin air and you can talk to the Gods... and you're only just beginning your journey. Remember that the collective subconscious isn't just a place where you all connect, it's the place where reality is created."

Phil didn't look convinced. Something wasn't adding up for him.

Bill gestured towards the stereo on the far wall and Phil noticed a note appearing from the distance - a single operatic tenor over a bed of cello. "Your species is facing an existential threat because it spends its time punishing itself, desperate for recognition; desperate to be accepted and feel loved.

"But you *can* turn this around," Bill said, calling him back. "And the lesson to be learnt is so beautiful that it's almost unbelievable to think it will help. I want you to get people to listen to themselves again. You're all crying out for change, but no-one can hear the scream from amidst the sponsored clamour and corporate noise that infests your world. I want you to teach your people to listen to their hearts, and ask themselves again: why are they here? I want you to teach them that you don't live for efficiency and productivity and the chance to succeed at all costs. Remind them that life is to be enjoyed, it's not

something to be defeated.”

Bill smiled and rose from his seat and walked towards the huge window with the Thames view. “Because if you get this right...” he paused and turned back to Phil. “The power that you can harness...” He opened his arms and raised them like a conductor while behind him the clear skies darkened and released a cascade of heavy rain that hammered down across London. “...is incredible,” he said.

“The world is a dream,” Bill continued, raising his right arm with the volume of the music following it.

He gestured to a shelf on the far side of the flat and a book moved across the room and landed in his hand. He threw it to Phil and it span and settled perfectly on the table in front of him:

William Blake: *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell*

“People want this change,” Bill said reassuringly. “And all you need to do, my son, is talk about the elephant in the room.” Then he gestured towards an elephant, dressed in a pink shawl, that stood and calmly chewed on a mouthful of grass by the front door of the flat.

Phil rose to his feet in shock, and was unsure whether to approach it or run away. Despite everything else Bill had said or done, it was the presence of the elephant that disturbed Phil the most.

“You don’t have to bring about the change,” Bill said in summary, as though it was reassuring. “I want you to raise the issues and let the rest of the world make it happen.”

Phil didn’t speak. He couldn’t take his eyes off the fucking enormous elephant that stood by the sofa and shuffled casually and flapped its ears.

“You’re just a man,” Bill said, softly, “who will talk about the problems in the world.”

Bill was suddenly by Phil’s side, with his hand resting on his back, smiling warmly.

“But,” he added with a snap, and the music stopped and woke Phil from his trance. “There are certain rules that you must stick to.”

Phil nodded and felt calm settle around him again.

“Do you want to know what the rules are?” Bill asked.

Phil nodded.

“Speak, Phil, it’s good for you.”

“Yes,” Phil croaked, then said, loudly: “Yes.” Bill nodded for him to continue. “Yes, I want to know what the rules are.”

“Ok. Firstly: Trust your instincts. That’s where we live. And trust your instinct to be honest, deeply honest. Feel no shame – but don’t

lash out; and remain calm at all times. I think some people call it being authentic, and you need to be it. Honest, calm, empathetic. This should be your default state."

Then Bill crossed towards Phil and smiled, proudly. "And, secondly: look after yourself. You need to eat – little and often – and drink more water. Calm down on the alcohol and weed, but you don't have to stop either. A bit of both is fine. The same goes for coffee - which is definitely a drug, despite what they say. Just don't go overboard on anything."

Phil nodded.

"And finally: Des will call you tomorrow and suggest you stay out of the launch process. Reassure him and tell him you just want to talk about people making art; say there'll be no issues, no crazy shit, no politics. Just encouraging everyone to make art. Tell him you don't want to lose momentum. He'll buy it."

"I don't think he will," Phil said.

"I'll make him," Bill replied, and Phil suspected that he could - and he would.

"So I'm gonna be famous?" Phil asked.

Bill spoke with calm authority: "I live in the collective subconscious of your people," he said. "I am a God. Trust me: in a couple of weeks, you'll be the most famous man on planet earth."

He smiled proudly. "So make the most of this last chance to walk the streets of London in peace. Go out tomorrow. Go to The Tate, there's a wonderful exhibition on."

"Really, which one?" Phil asked.

"The whole fucking thing," Bill said with a grin. "You've never been there before."

And then Bill, and his elephant, were gone.

- V -

Phil dreamt of his stage again that night. This time he looked up, above the heads of the people and into a deep blue sky. He tried to conceive the idea that the blue was simply a layer of refracted light that hid an eternity of stars. Then he began to see the stars, and then he saw more and more, as though he was moving through the blue and into the gulf beyond. Then he became gripped by a fear and pulled his

gaze back to the crowd who now stood in the silent darkness staring at him.

- VI -

By morning, Phil's memory of meeting Bill seemed no more real than his dream did. He could remember Bill's presence with an emotional connection, he could remember what Bill had told him in some detail, but the memory didn't feel the same as normal ones; it was more a vague feeling. This meant that by the time he reached the Tate, at around lunchtime, he was, again, a little unsure as to the reality of Bill's existence - though he did quietly accept that maybe he just preferred it that way.

He'd used some of the Credits Des had sent him to buy a sandwich and coffee on the way, and before he reached the gallery he sat and ate and looked around. He hadn't been to London for years - not since before the Crash - and although the Thames still rolled through it as lazily and romantically as it ever had, the place had changed. More than anything he was thrown by how many Wardens there were. He saw dozens of them in the half hour he sat. Dressed in black with the Union Flag emblazoned on their sleeves and automatic weapons in their hands. They made him uncomfortable, for sure: he was unshaven and still a little the worse for wear after the studio experience, but Des had organised for fresh clothes to be delivered to the flat before he'd arrived and so he passed as normal.

He'd never seen so many drones either. He must have seen half a dozen low flyers, that hovered one or two stories up, and sometimes moved closer and almost seemed to look directly at him. Further up, there were the high-flyers that surveyed the scene... they didn't have these in Brighton. Well, he'd seen them but nothing like this. Here they were a presence; real and impactful. And the cameras. From where he sat he counted them: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6... 10, 11, 12... He didn't think they needed that many. They didn't need that many. They weren't there for surveillance, they were just there. Multiple angles, a constant reminder, all managed and monitored by AI. No-one watched them; it was just a process now. Life was monitored; not by a person but by a set of rules. Cold judgements. You couldn't argue with it; there was no appeals process. Your CCS was dropped or raised based on what they saw and

how they judged your social contribution. It was perfect in so many ways... horrific in so many others.

The people here... Londoners. To be fair, they weren't all Coiners. They were mostly CCS folk, albeit ones with decent incomes. They'd probably earned good money before the AI collapse, and were educated and looked after themselves quite well. They were the old Upper-Middle Class, mostly, who now - by virtue of not being Coiners or Slummers - were fixed firmly in their place. A lot of them would have done volunteer work of some kind, maybe in the Slums for the poor, or in homes for the rich-elderly, or maybe some work in offices where human intervention was still needed; but mostly they were Influencers, producing endless hours of content that was consumed and reproduced and consumed and reproduced; the digital cycle that kept the world afloat. They were fascinating to watch: all of them either looking at their phones or filming with them; either producing or consuming. That was their life, and Phil hated them for it.

He remembered his vision of the night before: the thousands, millions - billions - dying in the cull and for a moment struggled with a feeling that it might just be all they deserved; maybe leaving them to it was the right thing to do. But then Phil remembered his time in the studio, the passion for life that he'd felt, and remembered what he was being asked to do: teach them that, by expressing themselves, through art, there was a better way to live. He could do that. He should do that. He would do that. How hard could it be? And what an adventure!

He got up off the bench and headed into the Tate.

After five minutes in the gallery the whole idea that he could teach the world to access the collective subconscious and manipulate reality by using the tools of art sounded insane; batshit mental. What the hell was all this stuff? Fucking squares on a canvass? Splattered paint? Actual coloured paper, cut into shitty shapes and stuck on the wall? What in the world of madness was this? This was art? This was the peak of human creative evolution? It looked like the product of a special-needs day out at the gallery. What the hell was going on? If this was art, he could understand why everyone had lost faith in it.

He remembered the triangle - Art, Science, Religion. He knew science was fine - we were way ahead in science; that was clear. And he knew religion was a mess - but it didn't take a genius to figure that one out; and in his heart he knew why: if Plato had come along and said "anyone with different opinions to me will go to hell!" then science would have stopped. The prophets had done just that: religious books

the world over described themselves as being the final word in truth and anyone who changed it was damned. They'd been stuck for generations.

But what was happening here? What was the deal with art?

He moved from room to room taking a moment to try to understand it. For a long time his mind wandered to wondering how his work would be remembered, compared to this. These were famous paintings, by the great and the good - Picasso, Rothko, Matisse, Dali - would his name, one-day, be listed alongside theirs? He stood in front of Rothko's imaginatively titled *Red on Maroon* and hoped to hell he was remembered as being better than this shit. It looked like a bad attempt at decorating someone's living room, and was a far cry from fine art.

He sat in the middle of the room for a while to meditate on his rage.

There were nine of them in here, each named after the colour they were. And they were just colours. No painting. No detail. No... nothing. *I mean the fuck was that all about?* He sat forward, physically uncomfortable with his anger. What was their value? He looked around with his jaw clenched. How much would they be worth? He had no idea - but it was measured in Coin not Credits - and all the Tokens in the world wouldn't buy you one of these things.

And that was people's lives. It was food, it was housing, it was... he remembered the world from when he was younger, before the crash, and remembered that people used to be able to afford to go on holidays, they fly round the world for a break. That was becoming rarer for some, and impossible for most. But what would even happen if some Slum grabbed this room and sold it. They'd have enough Coin to buy real food, to live in something less like squalor... but why couldn't they do that anyway? The resources were there, the workers were there. Why did money have this grip? It was just data now. Money was just data. Why was it killing us?

He rose to his feet, agitated, and bumped into a loose toddler who'd been waddling across the floor. His dad scowled at him, and took out his phone to record the encounter. That would show up on his CCS later, but it didn't matter anymore he supposed. It wasn't that big of a deal. It slowed him down a moment though and he breathed and walked more consciously for a moment, into the next room.

Maybe he was missing something here. He slowed himself down. He was missing something. Bill had to have a point. He flexed his hands and breathed.

What was the point?

What was the point of the paintings?

Painters often died penniless, so they weren't doing it for the money.

What were they doing it for? What was the point of all this?

What was the point of art?

Bill had explained it to him: it took you closer to the self, to the subconscious, and, through that, to the collective subconscious of humanity.

He remembered his own experiences writing: he didn't write because of what it produced. He wasn't focused on the meaning when he wrote it - not entirely - it was a feeling he chased. Something that burnt inside him. He didn't think about the meaning, or the impact, or the *purpose* of it, he just did it because it fed a need, it felt right. Surely these guys were doing the same...

He was in the surrealists room now. Ernst, Magritte, Miro... this was more like it. At least these guys could paint. And it was all so wonderfully weird. He was in front of a Tanguy. It was very cool. Very strange. Unreal... but maybe that was it.

He remembered other paintings he'd seen - previous eras - where the painters tried to capture the reality of what they saw. The whole classical world was people capturing a version of reality - which was incredibly skilful. But that was about capturing *reality*. This wasn't about that. This was about expressing something new - creating something new.

What was the earliest kind of art?

His mind went back through the Romans and Greek sculptures, images of Gods and heroes; and then back again: statuettes of Mother figures and more heroes; and back again... it was a lion figure wasn't it? The something Lion-man was the earliest. He wasn't sure where he knew that from but he was sure it was right.

Maybe that was it: humans creating a new version of reality. Bending it to something new. Controlling it.

Or were they just expressing it?

Realising that felt different. And then he was flooded with a wash of understanding that almost made him lose his balance. When you realise something real, something honest, something closer to the truth, you felt it in your guts. That rush was real.

They weren't creating it - though they were a little - but they were also reflecting it.

Art was a reflection *and* a creation of the subconscious.

Art reflects what's inside *and* creates it.

It takes abstraction and turns it into something real, and in doing so, it gives existence to something that was previously just a dream.

This room, the gallery - all art - charted the history of human's understanding of themselves.

The realisation sat comfortably; but he knew there was something more.

He moved back into the Rothko room.

Maybe it was *quite* cool - there was definitely a mood here, anyway.

He carried on moving around the gallery - Matisse, Mondrian, Klint, Twombly - they were all kind of brilliant in their own way, and he could see how they changed humanity's understanding of what constituted 'expressing reality' - they were all brave and challenging and interesting in their own way. But he couldn't shake the feeling that a fucking child could do it.

What did it say about humanity? That we hung these pictures on the walls? Celebrating their visions, when anyone could do that...

And then Phil stopped and for a moment had to consciously concentrate to avoid falling over. He almost reached out, but brought himself back.

That was it: anyone could do it.

The point of art wasn't to celebrate other people's art, it was to make art. And the point of modern art was the understanding that art is about reflecting the self, not necessarily skilfully, but honestly.

The failure of modern art, lay in pretending that some people's vision should be hung on the walls, while everyone else just celebrates them.

This room wasn't really a celebration art at all, it was a celebration of ego; and the people who stared at it were doing nothing more than sinking into neurosis as they came to believe that other people's work was more important than their own.

He looked at the painting in front of him, lost in it for a long moment: The decaying figures. The ants marching. The egg cracking. The hair. The skeletal dog. The chessboard. The distant mountain range.

The Metamorphosis of Narcissus

The evolution of man

Then his phone rang and Des's name appeared.

- VII -

The entry to Des's office welcomed you to a fantastically messy table that sported three Apples that rose like little drive-in-movie-screens from a cityscape of piled papers, newspapers and other assorted leaflets and fliers. Off the main room, were three other offices and a corridor that led you to a living space with a small kitchen. Phil could hear a distinct bustle of muffled shouts as he walked up the stairs, though it fell to a kind of awed silence when he entered the room.

"Phil!" Des bounded towards him and took him by the arm. "You ok? Great! Guys, say hello to Phil!"

Phil hadn't known there'd be anyone else there, but four faces turned to him, each mumbling a variant on "Hi," and looking a little awed.

"Andrea!" One of them called out. "Your man's arrived."

A phenomenally attractive woman stepped out of the kitchen and smiled at Phil. And for the first time in his life, this phenomenally attractive woman looked pleased to see him.

Phil smiled back and raised an awkward hand. "Hi... err... hello everyone."

Des clapped his hands.

"If you'll excuse us for a bit, I need a word."

Then he took Phil's arm and led him into an adjacent room.

- VIII -

"How are you doing?" Des asked, once they'd sat down.

"Yeah, I'm alright," Phil replied, and he wasn't entirely lying either.

"Good. What have you been doing?"

"I went to the Tate gallery today," Phil said. "I thought I'd... just get some culture and things, you know. Felt good though. Was interesting. Got me thinking."

"What about? Thanks." One of the team had brought in two cups of tea. There was an awkward pause. "What have you been thinking about?"

Phil decided to be honest. "Art. And its role in human evolution."

For a moment Des thought Phil had to be lying, then he frowned a little and decided that this was perfectly believable and entirely the

kind of thing he should be encouraging. "Great. So no... head folk? No interruptions?

Phil decided to lie. "No. Not at all."

"Good. That's good." This was going better than Des could have hoped. "And how are you feeling about the launch? We're working on some strategies now. Making the most of the publicity we've already got, and we're going to strike while the iron's hot!"

"That's good," and not what Phil expected. "I thought you wanted to slow things down?"

He sat up and shrugged. "I kinda did, but Andrea - she's running some of the social media stuff - she's saying that the Shoreditch gig has just blown up more than she expected. More than anyone expected. It's gone wild. You're working. We're pulling in a lot of Attention; and Attention means Credits." He sat forward here. "You know we pulled in over five million Sats from that night alone. *Five million!*"

"Where did that come from?"

Des shrugged. "It's just that crowd. Shoreditch. They're all Coiners, and they're all flash cunts. They often chuck a bit at the band, but that's a new level of chucking a bit. We're doing well. I'm really happy."

"That's great news Des. I'm really pleased." They both smiled at each other and for the first time (and quite possibly the only time) in all the time they spent together, Des and Phil were on the same page. "Just let me know what I need to do. Phil said. I'm ready."

Des laughed. "You don't need to do anything, my good man. You can just head back to the flat, stick on a movie and let the Coins roll in..."

Phil smiled. "No, seriously though... I wanna help. I'm ready. It'll be good to have me involved."

"No, no, no, no... I mean it. We've got a whole team of people who can work wonders with AI and we can basically reproduce you so you'll be in videos and all this cool viral stuff and... you won't even need to be there. Just trust us."

"No, I'm... I'm not down with that. I don't want the AI stuff. It's kinda off brand, you know."

Des cleared his throat. "What do you mean *off brand*?"

"Well, look, my message is: let's all make art. You know? I'm like this cool guy, who sings live and plays instruments - I mean I'm a multi-instrumentalist now, you know. That's gotta be worth something. And I just don't think that the AI music, and visuals is

really me. Look, honestly: I hate it. I really hate it."

"So do I, but what are we in this for? We're in it for the Coin, right? That's it. Stay focused and we'll all get along."

"I do... I do... I do want that, but," and Phil had to pick his words carefully here. "I also want to use my experiences to... try to... you know: help. Make a difference. I'm not talking about revolution though. You know, the whole 'burn the system down' thing, that's done. That was just studio stuff."

"Well yeah, it's in a lot of your music as well."

"But not all of it."

"A lot of it."

"But it's not my focus."

"*You'd rather Lord it in a barren land / than power-share in paradise / but I'm coming now to take my stand / So step down or be dragged down, it's your choice.* I mean they're your words Phil."

"Oh, did I write that? It's quite good." They both took a moment to process that Phil wasn't joking when he said that.

"Or was it Graham Hall who wrote that?" Des asked, pointedly.

Phil scratched his eye brow. "Look, I'm comfortable that I'm Graham Hall now. I think I needed someone else to *pretend I was*, while I went through that breakdown and now I'm out the other side I'm fine with it."

"I'm not sure you are out the other side, though."

"I'm really fine. I feel great. Calm, measured, comfortable. And look, let me run few messages by you - what I stand for. How's that? Or, I'll tell you what," he suddenly remembered an idea he'd had while he was on the train to the office. "I've had this idea for a kind of brand that we can use, you know, for the whole m..." he almost said movement, then corrected himself. "Music. For the whole music thing."

Des didn't respond so Phil continued: "Like, firstly I think it would be cool to produce them as *albums*. Like old school albums - with, you know, sounds that blend one track into the other and stuff. Make them like old Floyd albums or the classic Hip-hop stuff. So you listen to a whole piece - more like a whole work than just itty-bitty music shit. It'd be a break from the trash singles and viral bullshit that goes on at the moment. You know, and extended *piece* - something long-form."

"Have you been talking to Carl?" Des asked. "He said the same thing."

"No. I haven't spoken to him. It's a good idea though."

"I don't mind it. It's kinda classic - retro often works well. But you're still not doing interviews."

"Well - we can come to that. But also, and you'll really like this:" Phil did like this idea: "For the covers, for all the artwork, I want to do this logo thing. I've got a logo in mind that I really love."

Des raised his eyebrows, sure he was going to disapprove.

"I want this circle, just a plain circle, with a *triangle* over it." When he said it like that it really didn't sound that impressive. "Really minimal. And for the different albums we can just do them in different colours. So there's like a red one, and a green ones and a blue one and one that's black and another that's white. Just really simple. How many albums have we got by the way?"

Des threw his hands up. "There's no shortage of music Phil. There's fifty-odd tracks, Carl's working on all these remixes - bonus tracks, singles, you name it. I mean... I don't mind the idea." He sat forward and scrunched his face up. "It's a bit weird and... it's kinda culty.... But I don't, I mean..." He sat up and called two names: "Andrea! James! You should meet a few of the team."

Two young creatives came in the room. James entered first - dressed in ankle-length chinos and some flip-flops, and a white t-shirt that said *Press Gang*, and had a picture of what looked like a school newspaper crew on the front. Andrea - the gorgeous woman from before - came in after him. Her hair was tousled, her jeans hung off her hips, and she had a blue top draped around her shoulders and a dazzling array of neckwear that tinkled slightly as she moved.

"Hi Phil, great to meet you," James said. Phil thought there was something vaguely familiar about him.

"Hello Phil, it's a real pleasure," beamed Andrea sitting down with an old school pad and pencil which she chewed on like the girl who's done *all her homework and just wants more!*

"I'm Jonno's brother by the way," James said, explaining Phil's sense of familiarity.

"Ok." Des began. "So Phil's got this logo idea - can you sketch it for us?" Phil drew the circle and triangle. They both nodded agreeably. Des asked James to run it next door to Petra, the designer. "But can you make sure she's running this through Simon's web servers please. All the AI stuff is still going there right?" James confirmed that it was and there was plenty of bandwidth.

"Ok, the other thing is more of a discussion," Des said once James had returned. "Phil wants to be quite involved in everything, is that

right?"

"Well look I..." he suddenly felt a little out of his depth here - these guys were all super smart and working for him. What did he have to bring? "I mean I'd like to help," was all he said in the end.

"That's great," said Andrea.

"But, to start with: Andrea can you just explain to Phil about what happened with his Shoreditch gig stuff the other day. Explain how it spread and how it was shut down."

"Oh," she looked a little put out. "Sure. Basically, Phil: you played the gig and everyone in there filmed bits of it because they wanted the Likes to boost their CCS score. I mean I should say that we've utilised that and released official footage that's done really well so we've earned from it..."

"Stick to the point."

"So, after that night and throughout the next day you and the band were going stratospheric! Hundreds of thousands of Likes and - you know, *measurable* credit scores. Faster than I've ever seen. But a lot of the footage that did best was some of the... more... anti-establishment work shall we say. The angry stuff - bring the system down and all that. Now, it was quite cool as you couldn't necessarily pick out exactly what you were saying but the meaning was pretty clear, so it went mega-viral. Until early the next day when it all went black. They all got pulled down. The credits weren't reclaimed or anything, so I don't think it was manual; I just think the system looked into it and decided it didn't like the movement; AI heard some lyrics, got triggered and the clips got dropped."

"I see," said Phil. Though he didn't really.

"You see we get paid for Likes Phil," Des said, then confirmed himself: "Well, that's how we get CCS Credit anyway - which will probably be most of our income. We can transfer that into Coin at a later date, because it's Coin that we really need. That's what'll buy us our freedom. And once we've got that, you can do what you like - I don't care. But for now we need to be very *careful*. James," Des gestured to bring him into the talk, and then turned to Phil and said: "James works with the mainstream press. So tell us about them."

"As Andrea said, the whole system runs off engagement. So the press will promote you all day, as long as people are clicking. That's how they get their payday as well. But Des is right to say that you need to stay on the right side of... the narrative. To get real engagement you can push it - be controversial, that's ok - but if you go

too far, you get cancelled and we stand to lose everything. That's how the system is maintained. If you control the algorithm, you control the exposure, and you control the payday. Pilot controls the algorithm, so we need to play by its rules. A wild ride can be good, but in the long term stability is key. Go too wild and you'll get shut down."

Phil got that: "I can control myself," he said.

"But they'll push you Phil," James added. "You should know that. The mainstream press still want the shock. They want the headlines. They'll find a weak spot and push it and try to get you to say something extreme - even if you don't mean it - because it gets *them* engagement. They want something wild, on their show. Because if you do something that goes viral, on their show, they get the engagement but you'll get cancelled."

"So we've got this cool story," Des went on. "And it's got loads of potential. And we can make serious Coin. As long as we don't rock the boat." He let that hang a moment. "Does it make sense?" he asked.

"Yes," Phil said.

"So can you understand why I'd rather you stayed out of it for a little while?" Des asked.

"I understand," Phil said.

"Good," Des replied, settled.

"But the thing is," Phil continued. Des closed his eyes and breathed. "The thing is, I've got a plan I'd really like to do. It's not controversial, I actually think it'll help. It's really vanilla. It's basically just saying that people should make art. That's all. They should make music, and films and take pictures and sing and act and dance. I think it's a great message."

There was a pause.

"That's all it is," Phil concluded. "Make art. Express yourself."

They all looked at each other.

"The only thing I'd say," Andrea added, cautiously. "The only thing I'd say is that... that's basically all anyone does anyway. So it's really not controversial. I mean it's... it's... almost banal."

"Yeah, but the mainstream press will like it," James said. "I guess you mean, like, actually *play* instruments and not just prompt music."

"Yeah," said Phil. "Of course. I mean actually do it yourself."

"Then yeah - there's nothing wrong with that. Probably a good idea. It's perfect really: seems controversial, actually trite."

Des didn't say anything for a long time. Then: "So that's your plan? And that's it?"

"Yes," Phil replied with a confidence he knew he shouldn't have felt.

"And you haven't had any... you know..." Des waved around his head. "Any unwelcome visitors recently?"

"It'll be fine," Phil nodded. "Cool *and* the gang."

"Alright," Des was won around. "But be careful. And don't talk about the... you know... voices"

"It'll be fine," Phil replied, deciding it was better not to mention the fact that his faith was entirely based around the advice of a... you know... voice.

- IX -

Phil spent a little while in the offices afterwards, meeting his team and looking over a few of the videos that were being made – some lovely imagery, and they'd dropped in a sparse selection of lyrics that made them visually arresting so Phil could definitely see how people would want to share them. They had style.

Des had five people working with him: Andrea and James ran the PR side of things; Andrea on Social and James with the mainstream press. Peter quietly worked accounts from a desk in the corner and generally had his headphones on. Petra and Jamie were designers, creating memes and the short form videos that were made to be Shared and Liked and, through that, earn them the Credits they needed. Their work was simple and eye catching, and very imaginative. They incorporated the circle and triangle into their work well; in their best moments it was something central to the piece, or it was a clever reveal towards the end. Phil reflected on how well they'd done since they'd been given it that afternoon.

Later that night, Phil sat and drank a beer with Peter, Jamie and Petra. They talked about the unfairness of the world and tried to get a handle on what Phil was saying. It didn't take long though, they seemed to understand Phil almost intuitively, and, to be honest, Phil probably learnt more from them than they did from him.

He left for long after the early summer sundown, feeling full of ideas and really very honoured that these people were working for him.

He was dropped off at the flat at just before midnight.

He took a bottle of water from the fridge and sat on the couch while

his mind wandered back to Bill, and he began wondering why he'd been sent to the gallery. Or was it just like Graham Hall? Were they all a part of him, and he'd simply sent himself to the Tate?

Suddenly, in a moment that made him jump, Bill appeared on the lazy boy opposite.

"'Ello mate," he beamed. "Good day?"

Phil laughed, enjoying the shock – for the personification of evil, Bill was effortlessly chipper.

"It was alright," Phil said, pausing slightly before asking: "How was yours?"

"Exactly the same as yours," Bill replied. "I was following you. Did you enjoy the Tate?"

"Yeah. It was interesting. I wish I'd gone there sooner."

"Good. Probably won't be around much longer, so I'm glad you got to see it all before it burns!"

"What do you mean? Where's it gonna go?"

Bill paused for a moment. "The cull, Phil. The fucking Apocalypse. The End of Days. Whatever you want to call it, it's coming. I know it's tempting - amidst all this - to forget why we're here; and I know that in this little London bubble you've landed in, or even while you were working away in Brighton, I know it's easy to forget the world around you. But believe me when I tell you, that things are going to get so bad that this whole world, with all its faults, will begin to seem like just a happy dream."

Phil took that in and shut up. Then decided that he was too energised to sit in silence and challenged Bill instead: "So what's the deal with this art shit then? I don't understand. Andrea's right. You're sending me out to tell everyone to become an artist, but they're already artists! That's all anyone does anymore! Kinda... I mean content isn't exactly high art but it's not far off. I'm not exactly a radical am I!"

"Good!" Bill agreed. "But remember that we're only just beginning. And think back to the Tate. The... Rothkos - you know, the big colourful paintings you hated so much. Remember them? They're terrible, right: like a badly painted living room wall, you thought. But the point of them isn't the pictures themselves is it. The point of art isn't what it *is*... it's about its *purpose*. That's what we need to redress. Remember that this is about affecting art to change religion. This is about getting people to ask what they *should* do. It's about the *why*. So, ask yourself: what is the point of content creation?"

"To get seen - to be validated."

"Right, and through that, you make money."

"Sure."

"But what was the purpose of *your* art?"

Phil thought. "Fuck knows! I was having a breakdown."

"Yeah, yeah: *exactly!*" Bill seemed quite excited by the fact. "It was *real*. You were losing your ability to function as a human being, and so you were forced to express all your darkest nightmares and turn them into song. You took the reality of human experience and expressed it, in art, because it reflected your existence. You're an existent being - a living creature - with experience and pain and joy, and you used art to share your existence with other living beings. That's the point of art - and that's the kind of art that takes you closer to your own existence, and to the collective. That's art that has power. Not the shit that these guys are posting. So your *real* message isn't so much just to make art, but to make something *real*. I don't think anyone's gonna notice the difference until it's too late."

Still didn't sound very revolutionary.

"Look at it like this: art connects to the subconscious, right? Since the dawn of time, culture has been shaped by stories and visuals and music. The word culture itself means... the culture of art, like an arts and culture section in a magazine, but it also refers to the behaviour of groups of people: the culture of a society. You understand? It is through art that we understand what is possible for us - we define ourselves. But for thousands of years, those instincts have been used to enforce social control.

"Think about advertising - as it used to be, in the 20th century: trillions of dollars spent trying to influence behaviour. Endless messaging that told you you weren't good enough, smart enough, strong enough, healthy enough, successful enough - you weren't loved enough - unless you bought this product. That kind of art re-programmed human behaviour, in an attempt to turn you into consumers.

"And go back further: the renaissance. A period where humans radically changed your understanding of your place in the universe, and how was it expressed? Through art.

"And go back further still," he gestured toward a book case and Phil watched a single leather bound volume float across the flat towards him. Bill didn't refer to, or even look at *The Bible* that hovered between them, but his point was clear enough: "Stories shape your understanding of yourselves and your world. Today the stories are all

designed to make money. But if you can change that desire, you can still change the world. And so the first step has to be reshaping the *purpose* of art.

"Art should connect you; but the algorithm has turned art into a... battle ground. Art should liberate you, but your world has turned it into an exercise in humiliation."

He rose to his feet and turned to the window that looked out across the Thames. "There's so much anger out there Phil; you don't know the half of it. But I can see you all, and I can see what's coming. Will this be enough to change your path? That, I don't know. But even if you can't stop what's coming at least you'll give them something important to remember while they piece their world back together again."

- X -

"Look, we're not a fucking lifestyle magazine, but we need the clicks or we don't get paid and no-one wants to read this shit anymore." Mike Cranston, editor of *The Sentinel*, was frankly sick of having this conversation. "You can report the news, but if no-one reads it, then you've not reported it you've just burnt our Credits jerking yourself off."

"So who does report the news then?" Barked Ian Crillick, a flame haired Scottish old-timer. "When do we stop being a newspaper?"

"We haven't been a newspaper for twenty years, Ian. We're online, we're in competition with every cunt in the country, and we need the clicks. That's what pays the bills and that's what we do."

"So who does report the news?" Crillick repeated.

Cranston wafted his hands around. "What is news?" he said, clearly knowing it was a poor attempt at discussion. "It's just some shit that happened - it's what people want to know about. It's gossip, man. That's all it's ever been. Write that and we're all good." He tried to be reasonable now he was losing. "Just avoid politics at the moment Ian... everyone's... jumpy, you know. It's a fucking tinderbox out there and no-one wants to see it all come crashing down."

"But we don't want dystopia either, right," Thomas Mason said, calmly, sitting forward. "No-body wants societal collapse but there's a limit the other way as well, right? Can we agree on that?"

Cranston looked a little bitten by that. Et tu Thomas. But after a moment he spoke: "Look, no-one's restricting you, Tom. No-one's telling you what to say. This isn't 1984..."

"It's *Brave New World*, is what it is," Crillick mumbled.

"It's *neither*," Cranston turned back to Crillick with a snap. "This is the real world pal, and you'd better wake up to it. Now Crillick: your last three stories fucking bombed. And bombs cost Credit. You'd better pull something out of your arse pretty fast because the week after next Kai Fassard is taking over and when the accountants count their Likes, I'm not gonna lie for you."

"I reported from the Slums. I've fucking been there. I know what it's like..."

"No-body. Cares. About. The fucking. Slums."

"They're ghetto's Mike! They're not even labour camps - they've got nothing to do..."

"No-body cares!" He slammed the desk then calmed himself and tried a plea instead: "Ian... we've worked together for over a decade and I like you pal, I respect you, but I strongly suggest you stay the hell out of politics and write something that will get clicks. Your numbers are not good enough..."

"Stay out of fucking politics?" Crillick replied, his pale face reddening. "What the fuck is this then?" He turned his tablet to the table and read the headline aloud. "*The Failure of Society: Why Darwin was Right and Dickens was Wrong* by Michael Cranston. What the fuck is that? The strongest survive? You mean the fucking richest don't you? Is that who we are now?"

"The species most adaptable to change," Cranston corrected him. "That's what I said. The world is changing, and I'm changing with it. I suggest you wake the fuck up and give it a try, pal."

"Fuck you," Crillick growled.

Cranston bit: "Listen, maybe you're at the wrong party here but you better learn your place. You may not like this world, but it's the one you've got. You may not like your fellow men or the path we're on, but they're the people you've got to live with and it's the path you've gotta walk. Now if you want to work at this paper then you will to submit stories that people will read."

"Fuck you twice, cunt. You may think that you're tying your coat-tails to the life-raft but they'll come for you next. Believe me Cranston: there's nothing wrong with burying your head, but you better make sure you take it out before the fucking tide comes in."

"You're a fool Crillick. A sad, old fool." Then he leant forward and clicked the intercom. "Tony can you get security up to the third. Ian Crillick could use a hand moving his stuff." The rage between them burnt. Thomas remained silent.

Crillick rose to his feet. "My conscience is clean, Mike. At least my fucking conscience is clean," he said and walked out.

"Well make sure your desk is a well!" Cranston called after him and then mumbled: "Stubborn Scottish cunt."

There was a slow moment of silence in the office. Cranston clearly didn't like what he'd done, but he was famously fiery and it wasn't a surprise. The war between him and Crillick - who was one of the few remaining 'old school' reporters left at *The Sentinel* - had been growing for months and it clearly wasn't just a personal disagreement. Before the crash they'd been close; in the two years it took to rebuild the economy again the seeds of their disagreements were becoming clear: Cranston saw the new world and was prepared to play his role; Crillick didn't like the look of what he saw, and was prepared to go down fighting; Cranston wasn't prepared to go down with him.

"I'm sorry about that," Thomas said, after considering a number of other ways to break the silence.

Cranston looked up, clearly having forgotten anyone was there. "What the fuck are you still doing here?" he asked.

Thomas paused a moment, looking around. "You asked me... in here," he said. "You asked for me and Ian... and then that happened and..." he trailed off.

"Oh yeah," Cranston sat back, tapping the desk and chewing his cheek. "I've got a story for you. I was gonna give it to that prick out there, but it looks like it's your lucky day."

The Other Side of the Score

By Ian Crillick

Released on the FreeLine Network

Though many celebrate them as a modern success story, others see them as a stain on the moral fabric of society. Ian Crillick spent three weeks touring the nation's Slums and found them to be more complicated, more human, and more troubling than he ever expected.

* * *

When they were first opened, they were called Priority Housing Zones. The name has largely been dropped simply because normal people have no use for Orwellian euphemisms. They are now known as The Slums. They are vast residential districts on the outer edges of every major city, housing somewhere between fifteen and thirty percent of the national population - though the number is rising rapidly.

Originally, the purpose was simple: they were to house those whose CCS Credit scores had fallen so low that they didn't have the finance to keep themselves going under normal economic conditions. Criminality, anti-social behaviour, online trolling or a complete lack of engagement in the Creative Economy would all drop your Credit Score and reduce your payments. Inevitably, for some people, those payments dropped to the point where they could no longer afford food or housing. They were then sent to the Slums - sorry, Priority Housing Zones.

Here, they would be given access to structured exercise programmes, nutritional guidance, and community health initiatives. They would be taught skills and encouraged to re-engage with society. The Government - or Kai Fassard, who seems to have stepped into their place for the time being - insists that they adhere to a methodology that should offer all residents the hope of moving back into society. The reality is that very few people make that step, and the Slums continue to grow.

The Road to Hell is Paved with Good Intentions

The Priority Housing model was designed around a recognisable principle: that poverty is partly a problem of habit, and that habit can be reformed through structure. Residents are incentivised through credit payments (which means they're forced, in most cases) to participate in organised sessions that will help them grow. Positivity workshops will have some smiling Influencer reminding them how good they've got it - no-one knows you're happy until you show it! Fitness programmes that are run like a cross between a 1960s Communist town-square workout and a 1980s TV aerobics routine see thousands tuning in to raise those legs and kick, kick, kick. Retraining initiatives have residents being taught the ins-and-outs of the CCS economy. The fact that most don't have the cameras they need to work in it seems to have been missed at the planning stage.

In so many ways, the theory was sound enough that I could believe there were good intentions at their outset. The exercise facilities are

real, albeit understaffed and under-maintained. The nutritional programmes exist, but the food itself is distributed in batches, at fixed times, and it is adequate. Over time, this is so dehumanising. Sleeping in an allocated space and collecting your meals from a hatch at a designated hour does many things, but building independence is not one of them.

The retraining initiatives are perhaps the most painful example of the gap between intention and reality. They exist, people turn up in their hundreds of thousands, and they generate credit for both participants and providers. What they rarely generate is meaningful economic mobility after the sessions have finished.

The majority of retraining time is spent on CCS literacy — how to accumulate credit, how to build an audience, how to generate engagement in a way that the system will reward. In many ways this is rational. The Creative Economy is the primary route to credit accumulation, and understanding how it works is a genuine survival skill.

The problem is two-fold: firstly, the fact that all international trade is conducted in Coin means that the supply of phones with cameras is becoming limited and families are often sharing a single device between them. Secondly, there is an issue with how the CCS rewards engagement: in order to ensure that mass Liking wasn't as powerful as it first seemed, Pilot introduced a system where a Like from a high-credit individual is worth considerably more than a Like from a low-credit one. For residents of the Slums, whose networks overwhelmingly consist of other low-Score residents, this creates a closed loop from which escape is statistically very rare. They can learn the system perfectly, execute it flawlessly, and still find that the credit generated is a fraction of what the same effort would produce for someone operating from a higher point in the network. If that sounds familiar, it's no surprise: it's the way economies have worked for thousands of years.

Darkness, Literal and Otherwise

Alongside the lack of phones, internet connectivity in Slums is variable at best. The people who live there say it is often absent for days or weeks at a time. Entire communities exist, during these outages, in a state of informational blackout - cut off from the credit systems, health notifications, and community updates that the CCS requires for basic participation.

There used to be a saying that democracy dies in dark places. The Slums are proof that people do as well. The Slums that experience the most sustained connectivity outages are also, consistently, those with the highest rates of gang activity, drug dependency, and what the official reports term "community breakdown." The Wardens — whose recruitment posters line every available wall in the Slums, offering young men purpose, structure, and a pathway out — do not generally enter certain areas after dark. This wasn't a centralised decision, it's simply what happens when people are forced to make decisions based on their own personal safety and there is no incentive to change.

The issue of drugs has gone from being the growing concern it was a few years ago, to becoming an epidemic that smacks of a kind of genocide. As AI models became more freely-available, their uses were often harder to police. Modern gangs don't deal in anything as easy to track as marijuana or cocaine, in the Slums the drugs are simple pills, often distilled from freely available ingredients, that will keep residents in a blissful state that, from the outside, resembles sleep where they will often die of dehydration or starve while they're under. One pill, known locally as Coma, leave users unconscious for up to 48 hours; but while their minds dream, their bodies die. I should say that I've seen no evidence that the drugs are being manufactured or released by the state but I've seen no real evidence of them trying to stop its spread either. And beyond a certain point, neglect becomes a kind of endorsement.

Prostitution is also common and is rapidly becoming accepted as a way of life. In several Slums, gangs have assumed functions that the state has vacated: dispute resolution, protection, distribution of goods that the official system does not provide or provides inadequately. Though this is not unique to the CCS era, none of this is, the past ten years have seen this kind of social collapse speed up with a kind of unstoppable force.

Making Do When the Chips are Down

There is still hope here, and where it exists it comes from the residents themselves.

People are living here, and in ways that the CCS economy, for all its digital sophistication, has largely failed to produce elsewhere. They sing together, in stairwells and courtyards and makeshift community halls. They play sport with an intensity and a joy that the managed leisure of the Credit economy rarely generates. They know their

neighbours. They share food. They argue and reconcile and celebrate and grieve together, in ways that people in the Creative Economy, with their online networks and obsessive Like culture often do not.

Where there is resistance to the rise of drugs, the Slum-dwellers have organised it: vigilante groups are beginning to patrol the streets, often armed with weapons that have been smuggled in for this purpose. Central offices are being formed where training takes place as the residents try to offer an alternative for young men who are being tempted by the Warden culture. Men like Simon Zanetti have worked obsessively to bring order to these gangs, though, for good reason, people are beginning to suspect that his intentions may not be as pure as they originally appeared.

What do you squeeze when there is nothing left?

Behind all this, however, there is a key question that has not been adequately addressed.

Though the Slums and their dwellers are starting to make ground providing themselves with options, they are still a costly endeavour. You could argue that the Creative Economy is not an economy at all, since it produces nothing of any real worth - and certainly very little of any international recognition - but the CCS system still supports it and is still the sole driver of the kinds of infrastructural development that are needed to maintain a modern economy. The Slums do not offer anything. I can look at them and see hope, but hope, as Kai Fassard has reminded us, may help us not fear the future, but it does nothing to provide for the present.

Devices are becoming more and more expensive, even for those within the Creative Economy; we simply don't generate enough Coin to continue importing them at the rate we need. Though factories are being built and options could be present in the future, it will take years to turn this around at the scale we need, and most of the people in the Slums don't have that much time.

Though I would like to believe that Pilot has some kind of plan for what to do with the millions of people who live in the Slums, I'm not sure Kai Fassard has ever actually asked the question. How do you deal with anything between ten- and twenty-million people (depending on how you classify a Slum) who are economically inactive, and make no attempt to change that in a way that would be recognisable to those in power?

Is there likely to be investment in the Slums any time soon? I don't

see that happening. Is there likely to be a change in the system that offers these people a more realistic way back to the kinds of freedom they had before the AI Crash and the Creative Economy? I'm sure that won't happen.

Isn't the most likely outcome is that society deals with this in the same way they've deal with almost every major issue that's presented itself for the past century: express concern, do nothing, then go hard when it all goes wrong. And when it all goes wrong this time, my suspicion is that those armed vigilante groups we've allowed to grow for so long won't be turning their weapons on each other anymore, and there is a very real chance that, unless something is done about this soon, we follow our American cousins down the road to Civil War.

- XI -

"You ok?" Kate asked when Thomas returned to his desk. "I'm sorry about Crillick. That's messed up."

Thomas agreed, but said he'd be ok. "Ian's got old money behind him. His family in Edinburgh are Coined - he's Coined as well, I think - and I'm not sure Scotland is on the same path as us to be fair."

Kate agreed. "Yeah. And what a road... here, look at this:" She flicked her tablet and sent Tom a story. "It came through on FreeLine a little while ago."

The story was about two kids who got drawn into an argument with a Warden. They both ended up hospitalised. The story detailed nothing of the build up to the fight, didn't list how many officers were involved, but made it clear that the case would be heard in court, despite the kids non-attendance.

"The families will get their Credit scores *wiped* for this. The fucking *family*! The whole family get reset because their teenage son... did what? I don't know what happened. The Wardens can absolutely be assholes sometimes and... I am how am I supposed to report that?"

Tom laughed. "Stick to what you know."

"Oh *bullshit*! The Wardens are a fucking menace. They're pulled out the Slums and given a gun and a fat paycheque. You know some of them are on 5,000 CCS a week! That's twice what I earn! Give an angry kid a load of cash and a gun, then send them into the world and what do you think's gonna happen?"

Thomas didn't answer. He knew she was right.

"Angry young men... give them a flag and they'll follow it; give him a flag and a gun and get ready to watch the world burn."

He remained silent. They knew this already.

"That's how you steal a society, not run one. I mean look at the state of the fucking place."

She wasn't wrong. Thomas was thirty-seven. He's started at *The Sentinel* not long before the Crash, and thought himself working at a blessed time. He was at one of the most prestigious papers in the country, during a period of history that was - whatever else you could say - historic. People had been talking about how things had been deteriorating since as far back as he could remember. Did it start with the rise of AI in the 20s? The collapse of meaningful discussion that had taken place with the rise of Social Media during in the teens? The financial collapse of 2008? He'd always thought it was facile to try to pin a date onto anything; it was the sweep of history and if you wanted too find out where it began, you had to go back to the beginning, but since cave-men didn't keep records that wasn't possible.

But whatever started it, things were changing now, in ways that were permanent and profound and incredibly fast.

The first three years after the Crash had been a strange kind of madness. Though the press reported chaos on every street corner, the reality had been more reserved than that. Everyone knew it was bad, and society was scared more than angry. So for a while, things settled. It seemed clear that UBI wasn't working, and so when Kai Fassard stepped in with the Creative Economy, already built and ready to run, there was a sigh of relief and we walked into it with open arms.

That was eight long years ago now. Though plenty of people at the time said that it wouldn't work, somebody said that about everything. In the end, the attitude was that the CCS was what we needed so we needed to make it work.

Increasingly, however, it was becoming clear that this didn't work. We just didn't seem to be designed for this kind of world; the rewards systems were too unclear and too easily gamed. Even within the system, inequality still existed, monopolies were built and the uneven spread of rewards we growing more extreme by the month. And that was before you got involved in Coin. Those people were a world apart.

Since CCS Credits - or whatever other version of it your country was trialling - couldn't be spent on the international markets, Coin was the

only way to access imports, and this put Coin-holders in a world of their own. Thomas had heard a while ago that the collapse of international flights had meant that there were planes for sale: one Coin could buy you a passenger jet. The fuel was still being refined - no-one knew who did the dirty work - and the abundance of it meant it was cheap. A round-the-world trip for a handful of Sats. Those people lived in a different world.

And while they partied on Private Islands, with everything hedonism had ever dreamt of, the rest of the world drifted into a kind of hell. People knew what was happening, Thomas could see that. The riots - which is what they were called, though wars wouldn't be far from the mark either - in Leeds, Manchester, and Bristol weren't going to be isolated incidents for long. Crillick had been right about that. At the moment, though, there was no leader, no common cause, no focus for them to rally around; and with the internet blackouts being as regular as they were, and travel between the Slums being as hard as it was, it was difficult to see how they'd build it. But something would come along. If history taught us anything else, it's that if you live inside a tinder box at some point there'll be a spark.

Thomas remained silent for a time while Kate worked away. She was used to his silences, and the strange way he looked across the desk at her. She never felt that she being stared at, she just assumed he was processing things. She knew it took him a while, but he was pretty solid once he got there.

"What did Cranston give you anyway?" she asked, suspecting he could do with something to wake him up again. "I assume that's why you stayed on after Crillick was kicked out."

"Yeah. I got a good one. I'd quite like to run it by you actually. When you're done."

She shut her laptop. "I'm done," she said. "What have you got?" She sounded almost playful.

"You remember a few weeks ago there was that music guy, the one who played the gig in Shoreditch? Went viral and then disappeared?"

"Yeah..." she nodded with wide, excited eyes. "I remember. It all got taken down, didn't it?"

"That's the one. Well, apparently, he's spent the last three weeks in the studio and now he's got about a million songs to release and they've asked if we want an interview. And I'm the man, apparently."

"Shiiiiit," said Kate. "That's a gonna be a fucking *goldmine*!"

The Failure of Society: Why Darwin Was Right and Dickens Was Wrong

By Michael Cranston, Editor, The Sentinel

When the world is changing, it is easy to look around and assume that this new reality is either fixed or new; in fact it is neither: we are in an ongoing process of change, and this change is based on an order that has existed since before humans stepped out of the caves. It is natural and it is healthy and it is inevitable.

We are told that society is failing because it has grown too harsh, too competitive, and too unequal. We are invited to believe that if only we softened our edges, redistributed a little more generously, and listened a little more sympathetically, then the tension in the air would dissolve.

It is an appealing story but it is also a dangerous one.

We cannot pretend that the world that existed prior to the AI collapse a decade ago was perfect. It was not. We were not happy, we were not settled or stable, and we were not rewarded for either hard work or societal contribution. The new world is not perfect either, but it is more capable of providing those things than the old one was.

Labour has not become a thing of the past, it has changed its form so that now social contribution earns you credits, while social disruption will see them removed: this is a good thing. If you bring joy to the world you will be rewarded for it; if you bring disruption you will be punished.

Remember that Charles Darwin did not write about kindness as an act of survival; he didn't write about a 'woke' mentality where the lion considers the needs or the feelings of its prey. He wrote about adaptation. The species that survives is not the strongest, nor the most compassionate, but the one most adaptive to change. That principle does not cease to operate because we have built cities or created AI; it operates through them.

The failure of Dickens - onto whose unfortunate shoulders I am perhaps unfairly lumping the entirety of the 20th Century's obsession with the protection of the weak - was to believe that simply because someone is poor or downtrodden or under-represented they deserve our help.

But Dickens was an idealist, a fiction writer whose goal was not to

face the harsh reality of life, but to paint a picture that people would want to believe in; not actually believe in - no-one thinks ghosts really exist - but want to believe in enough that they would recommend his book to their friends. His needs, though he may not admit it, even to himself, were capital. He wanted to sell books, and to do so he sold a dream that was really a lie.

The truth in fiction is that it so easily allows itself to drift into what we want to believe and ignores the harsh reality of life. This is not a luxury we can afford any longer.

Britain has undergone more change in the past decade than in the previous century. The AI crash hollowed out entire sectors of employment. Traditional labour markets contracted. Digital production accelerated. The production of culture is all we have left. The Civil Credit System has stepped into that space and made it something that can genuinely feed a people and manage a society.

It is imperfect. But it is adaptive.

We hear frequent criticism of CCS scoring, of Wardens, of the stratification between Coiners, Influencers and those in Priority Housing. Yet rarely do critics ask the harder question: what is the alternative? A return to a pre-digital labour market that no longer exists? Of course not. All we hear is the desire to dismantle a system with no other credible solution. We live in a society of eighty-million people - receiving a quarter of a trillion Credits every week - and without a system to manage it we would have chaos. For the avoidance of this, we should be grateful.

And for those who still argue that race or gender or sexuality play a part in this new social stratification, I will simply say that we do not know who exists behind the screen. When I Like or Share a post I rarely know who created it, I simply understand that it is a message I want to share - a truth I want to spread - a feeling I want to grow.

And for those who call Priority Housing Zones "slums" I would remind you of a painful truth - but a truth none-the-less: there has always been poverty; there has always been pain; there has always been struggle. The goal of a fair and just society is not to wish these things away, but to ensure that rewards are distributed to those who most deserve them. The current CCS system does that, imperfectly at times, but more successfully than any society that has ever existed before.

I want finish by saying that I do not write-off the desires of Dickens or his ilk. He wrote movingly about suffering. He held up a mirror to

cruelty and asked his readers to feel. But feeling compassion does not feed a people. Endlessly supporting those who don't contribute doesn't help them, or society.

The uncomfortable truth is that hierarchies were not invented by late-stage capitalism, they are a feature of complex systems. In any network — biological, economic or social — some nodes carry greater weight. Those who adapt quickly rise while those who refuse to adjust fall behind. To pretend otherwise is to misread both history and nature.

This is not an argument for cruelty. It is an acceptance of reality.

We are living in a moment where technology, capital and culture are re-aligning. It is noisy. It is unsettling. But to frame it as moral decline is to misunderstand the process. The question is not whether change will occur, it is whether we will adapt to it. It's not whether we want to throw away what has been created, but whether we can shape this new world and make it something better.

Those calling for wholesale rebellion, for the dismantling of scoring systems or the abolition of market hierarchies, should consider the consequences carefully. Order is not the enemy of freedom or justice; it is often a necessary precondition to both.

Darwin was not advocating brutality. He was observing reality.

The societies that endure are those that recognise when the environment has shifted and adjust accordingly. They do not cling to nostalgic visions of universal uplift detached from the limits of reality. They invest in skills, in flexibility, in innovation.

If we are to avoid genuine collapse, we must resist the urge to confuse discomfort with injustice and volatility with doom. Adaptation demands clarity. It demands resilience. And yes, it demands that some structures evolve while others fall away.

The future will not be secured by sentiment. It will be secured by those prepared to change with it.

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After a number of heated debates, which all took place without Phil's involvement it should be said, the team finally settled on what would go on the 'albums.' The first - which would have been called a "double album" in the olden days - contained thirteen completely inoffensive tracks. They were mostly him raging about his upbringing

or mourning the loss of Madeleine, and although the last two (*New World* and *Rise Again*) hinted that another way of living was possible, they were vanilla enough not to offend even the most sensitive algorithm. Overall, Des felt that the first album worked well. It was White, though no-one called it The White Album, and it was tentatively known as *Broken Seed*.

The other five albums were red, blue, green, yellow and - finally - the Black Album, which was basically 120-minutes of Phil's acid induced final night; which Des, privately, swore would never see the light of day.

Each album boasted a simple, coloured cover, with Phil's logo in the centre of it.

On the Sunday before the Friday launch date, they released three album tracks, two bonus tracks from Phil's Shoreditch gig and two tracks that Carl had remixed with Old Scratch. They also sent a short press release to the mainstream press, and a select few Influencers, that said the first of six albums would be released that Friday with another one being made available each Friday from there on. Des desperately wanted to announce five albums, but he wasn't in a position to start the argument and the release went out.

Press Release from Underworld Recordings

Dated: Monday 9th May 20xx

Phil Davidson Launches Six Disk Debut

Underworld Recording are delighted to announce the upcoming release of six albums, which should be viewed collectively as the debut release from a remarkable new London based singer/songwriter called Phil Davidson.

The six albums contain 79 original tracks, and were recorded during a two-week stint in Desmond Judd's Ford Lane Studios in Sussex. They feature Underworld regulars John Mitchell, Matty Johnson and Mickey Finn, who play alongside a host of guest musicians including Jessica Freeman-Mitford and Jenny Longuet. The albums are co-produced by Des Judd and Carl Rogers.

All the music, across all six albums, was recorded live. No AI was

used at any stage in the production process.

Each of the six albums will be boast a single coloured cover, with a circle and triangle at the centre. The first album, which will be white with a black symbol, pays homage to Pink Floyd's epic concepts and tells the tale of a man, estranged from his world, who seeks solace in a dream of lost love.

Subsequent releases move between folk, jazz, traditional blues, country, dance and urban. It is not too much to say that his current pantheon already represents one of the most astonishing in modern music.

Seven recordings are currently available for free download from www.circleandtriangle.co.uk, including three live recordings from his debut gig in Shoreditch, three unplugged tracks from his first album and a single bootleg recording, which is known as Untitled33.

Davidson is available for media interviews. To submit a request contact Judd.Des@circleandtriangle.co.uk

The first album will be released on Friday 13th May. A new album will be released every Friday until 17th June 20xx.

© www.circleandtriangle.co.uk

By Monday evening what they'd released had been streamed over three million times, and the curve was quickly arcing towards a vertical. The story was passing around social media faster than anyone had predicted. The whole of East London said they'd been at the Shoreditch gig, and Davidson was set to be a legend.

On Tuesday, Phil went over to the office. James told him that he'd arranged for a host of interviews with mainstream outlets - including *The Sentinel* - during the days before release.

Andrea had arranged for meetings with a list of podcasts and other influencers and she handed him a dozen stapled sheets with some details about each site alongside the times they'd call. Partly because they hadn't taken any publicity shots, and partly to keep Phil's profile low, they'd agreed not to use Phil's face online.

"They can use the symbol if they need a graphic," she'd said.

To help this along, Phil spent a peaceful few hours with Petra, the German designer, who was working on dozens of images that would help secure Phil's branding. They comfortably agreed on the whole concept of self-expression and created dozens of snappy visuals that used his logo and some quotes that her and James came up with.

Express yourself ... Be real ... Feel the moment ... Love the feeling ... Be authentic

It was just fodder for Social Media, but the more Likes, Shares and Follows they got, the more CCS Credits they earned - and CCS Credits could be sold for Sats, and a hundred-million Sats made a Coin. And that, as Des continually reminded him, was the goal.

To help secure his understanding of this process, Phil spent a significantly less peaceful few hours with Andrea.

"Can I just begin by saying what a remarkable man you are," Andrea said. Phil felt slightly abashed, before she continued: "I have never met anyone with less impact on Social Media than you. Your Credit score is basically absolute Zero; you are the social temperature of the vacuum of space and I'm amazed that you even exist." The wind left Phil's sails.

She continued: "So this is how it's gonna work: we've got a company account connected to the Social that will release the music, and the vast majority of your publicity. Don't worry - we're not stealing your Credits, but it's a lot safer this way. You've got a personal account though, and that'll be like... Mecca for this kind of thing. You'll be posting on your account and I strongly suspect it's going to be a wild ride. You'll get a billion likes for something, and then nothing for the next thing - or maybe you'll say something controversial and lose the billion Likes you just earned - but that's just the way it works. So we need to make sure that every message you send - from your account - earns us money. Right? We want to avoid losing Likes, and make sure you get loads more! You get it? And to do that, I want you to understand how the system works."

"It's ok, I get it," Phil said reassuringly. Andrea was hot and he wanted to sound cool. "I get Attention and we all get paid. Easy."

She paused. That seemed to be all Phil knew. So she continued.

"It's ok - you're new. The first thing to understand is that there is competition out there the likes of which you wouldn't believe! Attention is the commodity. So you need to build it, but if you go too far, it can come crashing down; and if you don't do enough, we're

missing a trick, ok?"

"Sure," he nodded, confidently.

"And you know what the trick is?" She knew he didn't.

He waited.

She said: "You need to get everybody else working for us, right?"

"Right." He knew he didn't know this. He hated asking: "How do I do that?"

She smiled. "Basically, if you *become news* then *everyone's* earning off of you. Tom Bobbins the Vlogger will earn cash from you because people are clicking on his story about you, so he earns money and then they come to us for the real story, so we do too. They're our advertisers, effectively."

"Right."

"So you need to *become the story*, you know?"

Ahhh... that did make sense, but he wasn't sure he liked it.

"Because people don't just click on things they like, right? They click on things they think are important - even if they don't like them. And sometimes they'll click on them *because* they don't like them! So it doesn't matter what's true or fake or honest, what matters is that people click."

He was starting to get stage-fright.

"What matters is that you can engage an audience, and make them want to know more - and that's all that matters. It's story telling from the oldest school there is."

He thought for a long moment. It kinda made sense - but it was also attention seeking, narcissistic and shallow- populist. But it was also the only way a message could get out there. It seemed like this would be the work of it. HE settled on that: it was the price you paid for fame. "I get that," he said. "We need to get the truth out there."

She nodded in a way that said she roughly agreed.

"Des has said you've got some... quirks that I want to run over with you. Ok?"

Phill nodded.

"So... what's your message? What's your brand? I know it already, but you tell me."

"That we all need to make art and express ourselves and listen to our inner voices so that we can work together as a people."

She shook her head in a kind of blissful motion that also managed to say no. "So the art thing is great - it'll engage people and make them think that all the slop they're producing is actually art, and that's

great. But I'd avoid mentioning inner voices. Ok? Do you see?"

Oh yeah. Phil laughed. "Ohhh."

She said the next bit as though prompting him: "Because you've always loved music, right? It's in your soul. The expression of the joy of life is what you live for and you do it through *music*."

"Of course," Phil could play the game. "But don't you think that..." She listened. "Don't you think that... the whole... madness thing is quite... interesting?"

"It's fascinating," she said in a tone that Phil could genuinely not read at all. "But we want to save that for later if we can. It might come out - probably will - we all know about the video those kids took, but we don't wanna drop with it. That can come later. That way, even if it all goes wrong we'll have made something before it collapses!"

"Same with not playing guitar?"

She nodded, firmly. "Yeah. Yeah. I don't love that Phil," she frowned. "It's a bit fucking weird, right? And people don't like weird. People like stuff they know. Also, if we lead with that then it's gonna take over and no-one's gonna believe it and... it makes you seem like a liar; and they'll start thinking the whole thing is just some deepfake psycho-drama and they'll switch off. So we want to avoid that for now."

"Does that make me inauthentic?" Phil asked.

"Authentic is good," Andrea said. "Very good. There's a lot of money in being authentic. If you can play that game, then do it. Just not... that authentic. Not yet." She laughed. "I'd rather build on this art thing. What can we do with that?"

"Create... art... that's real. That is from the heart..."

"That's good."

"Something that expresses the self - and you can celebrate other people's expressions. If they're real - but only if they're honest. Not if they're just made-for-social bullshit."

She was looking impressed again. "This is it - I like that. You know why?"

"Because it's authentic," Phil said.

"No. It's because it's *slightly* rebellious, but not crazy." She waved her hands around jazz-style: "Oooo - you're attacking the system! Wow - to hell with the CCS! What a rebel. Yeah! I'm just gonna be myself anyway! That's good: that'll get you a lot of Credit, and Pilot will let it through because it's not *really* rebellious, it just makes people *feel heard* without actually doing anything. That's how we'll play the system for

long enough to make some cash before we get out.”

“So fuck the system, right,” Phil was starting to see where this was going and said that as a joke.

“No, no, no, no, no...” but she smiled as she could see he got it. “That’s too far again, you see... you want to *seem* rebellious, without actually *being* rebellious. That’s what people like - you walk that thin line, push and pull, push and pull... then watch the Credits come in. Then, when we’re drowning in Coin, we’ll head out of here and you can do whatever you like! How does that sound?”

Phil nodded.

“*Walk the Line*, like Johnny Cash. Too far one way and you’ll get shut down, too far the other and it’s a missed opportunity. No-one likes vanilla all the time; but no-one wants a chilli in the eyes either, you get what I mean?”

He did get her, though on the way home he began to wonder: it felt increasingly like he was just playing into Pilot’s hands. He wasn’t going to change anything with art alone. This world was too far gone, and maybe - just maybe - Bill wasn’t all he made himself out to be.

By the time the driver pulled into the parking lot under his Pimlico flat, he’d begun casting his mind back over the things that Trina had said, in particular: a hopeless dreamer, a drunk, no idea what will help you. Maybe that was right, and maybe he needed to smarten up a bit. He could see the truth in what Bill said, but it needed a little more fight if it was going to break through in this world.

Bill had told him to trust his instincts, and his instincts told him that a little more fight would go a very long way.

Art: Official Intelligence

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We’ve been raised to believe in being the best. In celebrating achievement and success because it represents the best of humanity. But like everything, that has a downside. Yes, of course success should be celebrated - what’s the point of trying to improve unless there’s some recognition of achievement? - but somewhere along the way we’ve forgotten the purpose of life: the celebration of existence itself.

I recorded those albums in two weeks and it was the most amazing

experience of my life. To be honest, I'd never really known what it was to be alive until I did that. And I felt that alive because the music was *all my own*. It was me - it was my soul expressing itself in notes and lyrics. I shared something in that time that couldn't be achieved by AI. AI can make sounds that imitate music, but it's not the experience itself.

The point of art is not the outcome, it's the process.

Playing the guitar isn't just an end - I didn't do it for the music - I did it because the feeling of creating something that validates your existence is so wonderful. The chance to hear your soul sing is something that simply isn't possible unless *you're* making the notes; unless *your* voice is forming the words; unless you've *put yourself on the line*.

I'm calling on us all to make art - real art. Not fucking AI slop. I don't care if what you do is broken, or if what you play is simple; I'd rather hear a choir of broken voices than a computer sing an aria.

And to achieve this the first thing I want to do is ditch the idea that it is greatness that should be celebrated. The point of art is not to put other people's art on the walls, however impressive it might be. The point of art is to take your own place at the table, share the experience of being you; introduce yourself to the world as a passionate, real, broken being and then let yourself carry on anyway. And share other people's experiences as well - that's the only way to combat insecurity and depression: we need to realise that we're all broken, fragile humans, and we can only do that when we're being honest with each other.

I shared myself with you because it was real. Some of my music is *desperately* self-pitying; some of it is angry; some of it is full of blame and recrimination; some of it is drowning in a kind of hatred that I'm almost ashamed to listen back over. But it was fucking *real*. And that's what I wanna hear.

Some people might say that sounds selfish; narcissistic; like I'm trying to make myself the main character. It's bullshit. I want us all to be the main characters in our own lives. Forget celebrities. Forget your heroes. Forget cowering before those who seem better than you. Take control of your own lives, celebrate it in whatever form you want -

draw, paint, perform, sing, dance, scream at the fucking moon, but be yourself, express yourself, and celebrate with others while they do the same.

Put down the AI, and be real for a moment. For your friends, for your families, for the people who matter most; and be real for them: see them, honestly, and share their experience of this incredible life we've been given.

Because for all its abilities - and Pilot can create music more complex than any human ever could - but for all it can do it has no idea it's doing it. It's a *thing*... it's dead. If we make achievement the primary goal of humanity, we will lose to this monster we've created. But *we* have something it will never have - an awareness of our existence; a joy that comes from experiencing the reality we live; and if we don't celebrate that now, there's a very real chance that this dead thing will come along and wipe us all out.

And make no mistake: Pilot can do that. But the only reason it has that power, is because we've *given it* that power. We allow that dead thing to make judgements that affect our lives, that decide who thrives and who gets sent to the Slums to rot. It's time to claim back our rights, time to fight for recognition and the right to be seen. It's time to rise up and shine on... Celebrate your existence; it's the most incredible thing you'll ever have.

- XIII -

For a long moment it looked as though the crowd was nothing more than the reflection of the stars upon a still pond. Their eyes seemed to glow white they were so large. Phil took them in while the darkness descended. Then, in the distance, someone flicked on a lighter; a moment later there were another two, three, four golden flames amidst the blackness. Then a dozen, then a hundred, then a thousand and for a moment Phil saw a perfect matrix board, connected by points of golden light.

He dreamt the moment a long time, and carried it with him long after he'd awoken.

- XIV -

Thomas arrived at the office early and was left to sit in the reception for almost twenty minutes before they let him through to see Phil. He knew that this was a make or break opportunity, and intended to make it the make and not the break. Phil's star had been rising all week because this was official, he knew it would carry a helluva lot of weight. This could change his life.

He'd enjoyed what he'd seen of the gig. Phil had an energy that was transfixing. There was something unstable about him that meant you were always almost waiting for him to fall off stage, but what came out of the other end was so incredible it was worth the anxiety. The band were good as well. It was rare to see people play real instruments these days. Thomas used to play bass himself, but the bass wasn't something he enjoyed without a band and it was harder and harder to get a group of people together who all wanted to play. Those who wanted to write music no longer needed anyone else to play for them, and so the whole idea of a band was becoming a little archaic.

The other thing with Phil, was his lyrics - and his persona off the mic. There'd been quite a few moments when he'd started saying something almost rude about the audience in a way you didn't see too often these days. He'd had a few digs about them being Coiners, had mentioned his life as a gardener: his CCS score paid his rent but he'd mostly lived off the Tokens he earned. And he was angry about it. That much was clear; and it wasn't something you saw very often.

Within twenty-four-hours of the gig, Pilot had dropped most of the clips off the main algorithm entirely and, though a few remained on the FreeLine Network, the conversation had moved elsewhere. But he was about to release his music. Reams of it, apparently. The tracks he'd heard weren't bad either. They didn't have any of the political criticism that some of his gig work had done but the raw energy was still there in a big way.

He'd spoken to James, Phil's PR guy, the day before and he'd been refreshingly honest: "Listen, Phil's a quirky character, right? He's got that old school rockstar energy and that's something we want to celebrate. But he is quirky."

"What do you mean?" Thomas had asked.

James made a noise like an audible shrug. "I'll let you work that out for yourself, but there's a lot of attention in this if we play it right. For us and you. We've got six weeks of releases to come, and he's got a story and he's got charisma for sure. If we play this right, we can all make a lot of money - Credit and Coin. You and me. So help us out, eh..."

Thomas hadn't promised anything but said he'd do what he could.

In the end Des came out to meet him, and they exchanged a few words before he was led through the office space and into an adjoining room to where Phil sat, plucking away on an old acoustic. When he saw Thomas he rose to his feet suddenly and whacked the guitar against the coffee table, laughed, then adjusted himself and put it down on the sofa but missed ended up dropping it on the floor. Then he laughed again and held out his hand.

James had been right - he had charisma. He wasn't tall, but he had a wiry build that probably made him look taller than he was. His hair was dark and wasn't heavily styled, though it had the general mess that was often associated with creative types. His skin was dark but not tanned - there was definitely a mix of races in his family's past. His face was youthful, but not strong - he didn't have a jawline to envy and he was slightly chubby in his cheeks, which added to the air of there being something almost childlike about him. His handshake was strong and confident, though that might have only been noticed because Thomas was suddenly so aware of his eyes: crystal clear, almost baby blue. For a long moment he was lost in them; there was something pure about them, unreal almost. For a second Thomas reflected on the fact that that you almost couldn't believe someone with those eyes could ever mean any harm and in that moment he also saw that James was right: they could make a lot of money out of this guy.

Ten minutes later, though he still believed in the concept, he was less convinced about how to get there.

"So you're saying you don't ever remember playing guitar before?" he asked, still unsure whether this was just a big joke.

"No. I don't."

"We weren't gonna mention that Phil," Des droned from the back. "Honest to fuck!"

"No, *you* said that. I want to be honest. This guy seems alright. And I want to be honest. He doesn't have to print it."

"He's a fucking jorno Phil..." Des just sighed and gave up. For the

moment, anyway.

"So what do you think happened?" Thomas was almost afraid to ask.

"I dunno," Phil shrugged. "I mean look: I can only be honest about my experiences. I don't remember playing guitar, and then..."

"Manage it Phil..." The moment had already passed for Des.

"But now... it's all like I've remembered something. I mean look, honestly, I think it's a memory issue. Some kind of blockage that came from a difficult upbringing and a period where I suddenly found myself. Maybe I could play when I was younger, but blocked it off. But what happened was, a little while ago I started writing all these songs..."

"This Graham Hall guy?" Thomas confirmed.

"Yeah, but I honestly think he's me."

"You?"

"Yeah, I mean, look: working through an alter ego isn't exactly new is it. Bowie's a great example. But a lot of people write through pseudonyms and it's interesting - what it does for you. I think that, for me, it was easier to face the reality of my feelings, the truth of my anger - the depth of my anger - if I was writing as someone else. But in an online world, that's not exactly new news."

"And is that something you would encourage other people to do? That doesn't sound very authentic to me."

"Yeah, I guess..." That genuinely threw him: the inauthenticity of hiding behind Graham Hall as a means to express his authentic-self had genuinely never occurred to him before. "But what I do know is that the creation of art is, and always should be, rooted in the expression of the self. It's the expression of a perspective of the world, that's then shared with other people. That's what it's there for and it's one of the most important things we can do as a people."

"Sure, and that's the creative economy isn't it," Thomas said, relieved to be back on firmer turf.

"Kind of," Phil knew this line: "To be honest, I don't think that the creative economy is quite what it pretends to be. Are we all really making things to express ourselves, or are we just..." he paused, looking for the right word. "*Deforming* ourselves in the desperate hope that we'll get recognition? It's art for the sake of money, not expression. Because at the heart of any activity is the *purpose* of it. *Why* do we create art? *What* are we trying to achieve? What is the *evolutionary purpose* behind things like art? How does it help us grow as a species?"

"So do you think that the CCS - the Creative Economy - is a step forward for humanity? Or a step backward?"

Phil shrugged. "Well... there's certainly the chance for something wonderful here - but at the moment I think we're missing the real diamond in the rough. I mean we're still wage slaves aren't we. We're still desperate for recognition - desperate to be seen - to raise ourselves above each other and achieve something; we're still fighting. But life doesn't exist to succeed at all costs; life is not an experience to be won, it's something to be celebrated and enjoyed and embraced, not justified."

"So is it the economy that's the problem? I know you've skirted around attacks on Pilot recently."

"No, no, no..." Phil had been told off often enough to stop that - for now! "I mean kind of... I mean there's a lot of layers where I have concerns about our behaviour at the moment and most of them come down to purpose, not Pilot. We need to ask ourselves: what is the point of what we're doing? And Kai Fassard needs to do the same thing - what are we trying to achieve? Because it seems like we've just dismantled the old hamster wheel only to use all the pieces to build a brand new one. I'll tell you what: I lost my job as a gardener a while ago. I was sitting on Brighton seafront and was completely happy to kill myself. I was comfortable with it. Then this old guy appeared..." Des coughed and Phil changed tack. "Anyway... the world was out of my control and I didn't want to carry on..."

"I'm sorry about that," Thomas said. "What do you think caused it?"

Phil felt a little like he was missing the point, and he didn't really like talking about his own experiences and would much rather stay on the safe and steady ground of human evolution. "I think... I mean... my dad died - in absolute squalor. His score was almost zero, and he had no way of getting it back and he died..."

"And your mother?"

"She died a few years ago. She had cancer." For a moment he had a crystal clear vision of her in her hospital bed, looking across at him with desperate eyes. She was so afraid to die. It sent a chill through Phil, and he felt slightly sick. "She... I mean they're both dead and I think... look, I definitely think that we don't live in a world that allows us time to process ourselves. That's true." He was back on the meta-issues and so his talk sped up again: "We live in a world that constantly tries to push us to achieve something - to justify ourselves -

to fight to survive. But in the middle of all that, how is anyone supposed to work out what the point of life is? We don't live to make Credits, or Coin, or fucking Tokens. They're not the reason for existence, they're things we've made up to structure society but they've completely taken over."

"Ok, I understand," Thomas said. "So you feel that the drive to earn a living wage... kind of blocked out your ability to heal yourself from the trauma of your youth?"

"Yes!" That was it! "Completely! There's no time to fix ourselves or grow or become healthy so we just wander through the world like these fucked up automatons, charging forward, madly doing... nonsense shit to earn a Credit while most of us are so fucked up we can't even fall in love anymore." He knew he'd made a mistake then because now he was going to have to talk about...

"Yes, there is a strong theme of heartbreak throughout your music - or the pieces I've heard anyway - *Below Ground* for example. Was that written about someone specific?"

"He doesn't have to go into the details," Des said. "You don't have to answer that Phil."

"No, I don't mind." He did mind, but he liked disagreeing with Des and he couldn't deny that a part of him was falling in love with this whole process. He was just talking about himself and it seemed that the world wanted to know, and for someone like Phil that was like crack to a crackhead. "Her name was Madeleine. We had a relationship for a few years after university, and it was the happiest I've ever been. I felt, for the first and probably the only time in my life, that I could manage things. That I could move forward... with stability. I felt confident."

"But it didn't work out? Why do think it ended?"

He sighed. Suddenly, he hated talking about this. He could sing about it all day long, but to break it down into anything as ugly as dialogue made him feel weak and a little sick at himself. "I just couldn't... engage... I couldn't connect... I let myself get... drawn into my head and my fears. I was the *Lost Little Boy* from the song, you know."

"That one's not out yet," Des cut in but was privately quite pleased that Phil was starting to reference his own music. That was the kind of myth-making they needed now!

"I was afraid basically," Phil said. "I was afraid of being loved and of loving someone and being weak and vulnerable. I inherited that

from my parents, and I lived it - and if I'd had kids I would have passed it onto them as well." Then he came alive again: "But that's exactly the kind of emotional inheritance that we need to be able to fix, but society just doesn't give us enough time to reflect, or get in touch with ourselves, or feel anything that really matters..."

The interview continued in this vein for another twenty minutes or so. Thomas asked some more about his upbringing, and his relationship with his parents; Phil spoke some more about society's prioritising material growth over emotional health. Thomas asked more about Madeleine, and Phil spoke about society's prioritising material growth over emotional health. Thomas asked about why he thought Phil couldn't remember ever having played guitar before; Phil said that he'd had a breakdown - because society prioritised material growth over emotional health - and on the other side, he'd become a musical genius. He shrugged as though it was normal and Thomas had to accept that he believed it was. Eventually he said he'd got enough for the article and thanked them both, then Des led him out.

Phil felt strangely empty once Thomas had left. Like he'd had a moment in the spotlight and then the light had turned off. He felt the loss of something, like an opportunity had passed him by, and wanted nothing more than to start the hour again. He ran over the things he'd said but found he couldn't even remember most of them. He reached for the guitar and began slowly strumming something, breathing as he did so, and letting the music return him to some state of grace.

It was definitely true that a lot of his current feeling that 'life made sense' came from the music and not the lyrics. Lyrics were too messy, too clear, too structured and... it was almost like all the things that made lyrics meaningful also meant that they were not enough to express reality in its pure form. Within music there was meaning beyond words and for a while he was lost in the sounds of the strings.

Des returned and looked reasonably pleased, which Phil was relieved about.

"Well done," Des said. Sitting on the sofa, visibly relaxing. "That could have been a lot worse!"

Phil smiled. "It was ok?"

"Yeah - all the stuff about art is great - rebellious but not too bad; kinda supports the system but also subverts it; I feel like you hit the tonal nail on the head. A couple of bits where you need to reign your neck in - shut up about Pilot, and for God's sake don't talk about... fucking... random people on Brighton seafront! But I like Thomas." He

thought for a moment. "James spoke very highly of him and I'm inclined to agree.

"He says he wants to write a book about you actually and I like the idea. It'll be good to bring someone into the inner circle - someone from outside, a writer, someone who can be a... sounding board for you, and can record the reality of what's going on. It gives longevity to the whole thing, and you should be able to feel heard without necessarily having to shout everything out from every street corner you come to."

Des had come up with the idea because, privately, he really thought that Phil needed some therapy. Unsurprisingly, Phil loved the idea as it meant he'd be able to talk about himself some more.

"I'm down with whatever you think's best," he said, with a casual calm that he hoped sounded humble. The idea of being the subject of a book probably helped him build the courage to speak up again: "But listen, Des... I want to ask about something."

Des looked concerned. "Sure."

"The whole thing about... me being mad and all that. Not playing guitar before and things... it's gonna come out anyway isn't it?"

Des knew what he meant. They hadn't been able to track down that clip or the kids who'd filmed it. "Eventually. But it doesn't mean you have to go shouting about it from the off."

"Isn't that more honest though?"

Des scratched his chest in thought. There was a part of Des that was strangely simian. He was often picking at himself or otherwise self-grooming. "Possibly," he said. "I just also think that... look: beginnings are a very delicate time, in the wise words of Frank Herbert. And I want to establish you as someone who doesn't *want* to throw that side of you into the world. It can come out later, hopefully... much later, and we can say that you... felt that it was personal... not a big deal. You don't seem mad - most of the time anyway."

"But it will come out," Phil said. He believed that it was better to deal with it head-on: no shame, authentic all the way.

"Maybe," Des replied. "But hopefully not for a while yet."

- XV -

Thomas was staring into air when Kate got back to her desk.

"How'd it go?" she asked, then repeated herself: "Oi! Wake up! How'd it go?"

He looked up slowly. He'd drafted his his article pretty quickly and then, as he was prone to do, he sat back on it and let it process before ripping it to shreds. "Hi," he said and cleared his throat. "It was good. Interesting guy."

"You're telling me..." she paused. "But you haven't seen the feed?" She waiting for a beat and then sat down with some excitement. "Ok. That can wait. But first: tell me everything."

Thomas sat up. "He's kinda cool. I like him a lot. Very authentic. I couldn't imagine him lying, you know. He's not a game player at all. He spoke about art and creativity and the importance of... he was very into this idea of purpose. And... how art isn't just an item to be consumed. He was very into the process of making art as a... rebellious act? Kind of. But as a therapeutic act - and through that it becomes rebellious. It's about art as a means to get back in touch with our humanity I suppose. A shared space that... connects us all."

"Politics?"

Thomas shrugged. "He didn't talk about the details really. There was none of the angry verse that we saw in the gig. He was just... he was like a kid, in a lot of ways."

"Ok." Kate nodded, knowing that there was more to come.

"He'll be big though," Thomas said, thinking this would satisfy Kate. "He's got that magic about him. I'm gonna drag this one out for as long as I can. It's the best kind of clickbait."

Kate nodded and was about to speak when Thomas, unusually for him, cut her off: "I mean he was just found; this guy Carl Rogers, a keyboardist, met him in London Bridge apparently, a bit lost and kinda homeless... I mean what a story!"

Kate laughed. "So you don't know?"

"What do you mean?"

Kate beamed like a cat with a crate full of cream. "Have a look at this..." Then she flicked a link over to Thomas's tablet. The link took him to some phone footage of Phil - he looked to be somewhere near Borough Market, on the Thames. He was shouting into thin air: "I can play it! I can play guitar! You're a liar!" Then he took a swipe at a guy who was moving to help before realising where he was and calming down. Then the video cut to Phil sitting on the kerb and playing guitar - one of the songs from his first album, funnily enough. He was sitting next to someone Thomas recognised as Carl Rogers, the keyboardist

from Phil's band.

"Fuckin' eh," Thomas muttered and watched the clip again before throwing his tablet back on the desk. "You see he did mention this. He said he thought he'd never played guitar before."

"Really? And when were you going to tell me that?"

Thomas shrugged. "I had a word with his manager afterwards and there was an agreement to leave some of the weirder stuff out of it for a while. I mean it's a crazy story and God knows what the new owners are gonna make of it. I know Fassard seems like he's all about the Coin, but I also kinda feel he's grown beyond that now."

"They'll keep you on," Kate said; though they both knew that neither of them knew what the new owners would do when they stepped in next week. The government had passed the deal, the shares had been bought, so the paper was sold.

"I don't know if I'll stay even if they offered me the chance," Thomas replied. "What about you?" He knew the answer.

"I'll be ok. I've got family. And you'll be ok? You'll get a good payout with this one."

Thomas nodded. "I know." Phil's story was his only chance.

"What did they ask you to leave out?"

Thomas laughed. "This thing," he said, gesturing at the pad. "The whole magic guitar moment."

"Oh I see..." Kate said. "So you can write about it now?"

"I guess so," Thomas said. "I'll speak to James I guess."

"Did you believe him?" Kate asked, with the sincerity of someone who cared about Thomas deeply.

"I mean... if I didn't think he was being so honest throughout the interview I would have just written him off as a nut-job, but he kept saying it, like it was amazing. And it would be if it was true... It was really weird."

"So you did believe him?"

"Well... you can't just learn guitar overnight can you, but... he said he had a breakdown, or something... he said he had a breakdown after his father died and somehow go in touch with 'a part of him that could play guitar,' was what I think he said." He made a motion to his notes to show he was paraphrasing but let the quote stand. "But there was another thing..." he sat forward here. "He said he met this old guy. I only really noticed it when I listened to the interview back. He said he met this guy and then Des coughed and he didn't mention him again."

Kate sat back and pulled her ponytail tighter. "That all sounds very

intriguing."

"Add it to the list," Thomas shrugged. "They said it was a memory thing and I guess I can believe that."

"Guess so."

"He said he had a breakdown and got connected to his subconscious or something... this collective... whatever it is. The collective subconscious."

Kate nodded and laughed. "Sounds like a character." She went back to her work but added: "And one helluva payday if you can play the game!"

- XVI -

"Look, I'm not saying you shouldn't talk about Pilot," Bill explained for the umpteenth time. "But if you do talk about him, now, he'll take over your message and everything else will be lost. This shouldn't be a fight. If you go into this as a fight, then everyone will lose."

Phil didn't like being told off by anyone, but Bill least of all. He wanted Bill's acceptance, even if he did rebel against him sometimes, and grew frustrated when he didn't get it. "Look I understand what you're saying," Phil replied. He didn't really want to argue, be he knew he would. "But I can't just keep rambling about art all the fucking time. It's boring and... we have the Creative Economy anyway. It won't make a big enough difference to stop..." The end of the world? The apocalypse? Even just straight 'genocide' could have completed that sentence. In the end he settled on: "Anything."

"It will." Bill was firm. "If you change things at the base, everything from there on up will change. If you can change the reasons *why* people do what they do, you'll change the output - en masse."

Phil didn't like it. He didn't like the idea that he was going to be this vanilla, and he didn't like the fact that he was being told to do this buy a divine being. He couldn't argue with Bill about the big stuff and it left him disarmed.

"I mean I'm not even going after Pilot," he sulked. "Or that Kai Fassard guy. I'm not trying to start trouble..."

"It doesn't matter what you're trying to do," Bill said, tonally calming things down. "What matters is what happens. There's a of people out there who are really angry. They can see that this isn't

working, but they don't know what to do about it. If anyone comes along - confident, well-spoken, a challenge to authority - they're very appealing. But you don't want to be that man, so don't put yourself in that position."

"But it wouldn't just be me either," Phil said. "Other people would get involved... Des knows people..."

"But this isn't your battle." Bill snapped for a moment and then softened: "I'm really proud of you Phil. I don't want you to get me wrong - you're doing well."

Phil sighed and decided to try to connect again, honestly. "It was weird," he said. "I was struggling; just rambling most of the time."

Bill shrugged. "That's ok. That's life. Gamble and ramble and recover what you can."

"But it just seems like the stakes are really high! I want to do more. I feel like I need to do more."

"Forget about it," Bill said, with a confidence that instilled calm. "Just focus on the truth: the world needs to wake up and start getting in touch with themselves again. That's all it is. You know it, I know it; your job is just to make sure that they all know it as well."

"It seems..." He sighed, rather than repeating himself again.

"It's ok," Bill said. "Firstly, because I'm gonna help - and, given the fact that I'm a literal God, I'm quite a good guy to have onside. And secondly, because everyone is ready for this. You've made a good start - not too much, not too little. The Pilot stuff isn't the end of the world at all, just don't let it take over - this is just the beginning remember."

- XVII -

Phil's first album, *Broken Seed*, was released on the Friday. Major influencers called it the first masterpiece of the post-CCS era and heralded his arrival as though he were a returning Saint.

The three weeks following the release were absolute chaos for Phil.

The crucial thing was that everyone was earning something from his fame. You could make a payday just covering the coverage of him, so any contact with the man himself could cover your rent for a year. In a lot of cases, though, people just made something up and saw if it stuck.

For the first three or four days, he was able to - more or less - stay on message. During this period his social media team released endless

quirky, viral visuals that flooded the market and encouraged creative expression and finding a purpose. The message was easy really, and once the crowd knew the language they followed suit and began releasing their own variants on his message; often expressing their own pain or anger in song or verse or using visual arts. Phil didn't earn anything from their work, but as a branding exercise it was incredible. Andrea managed to keep their work front-and-centre and so the Credits rolled in.

However, alongside his overall message there was elephant-in-the-brand that they just couldn't avoid: Phil had been filmed, on the South Bank, shouting at someone who lived inside his head. He was clearly insane. Des had known that the clip would surface sooner or later - they hadn't managed to get any kind of control over it - and as soon as Phil's face became plastered everywhere, the kids had realised what they had and they made the most of their payday.

The clip didn't exactly damage Phil's brand, and though he deflected it for a while - he admitted that he'd had a form of breakdown, which had led to the outpouring of grief you heard on the albums (a message that Des had loved; it gave his work a veneer of myth that was irresistible) - eventually, he couldn't help himself but say that he'd never played guitar before and had become a musical genius almost overnight. Des had told him to just pull back on it all but ended up with his head in his hands while Phil spilt the whole tin of beans. He hadn't been able to resist the impact, he wanted that shock, he wanted the drama, and so he told the world what happened:

"I don't think they're real Gods," he explained. "They're just projections of how I imagine God to be. The same as Graham Hall really. I mean what is God anyway? It's a dream of something bigger - a voice from the infinite - that guides us in times of need and offers support and love. I needed that, and so I created it. They're all in my mind, of course, but..." he smiled: "Where else would they be?"

The impact hadn't been as drastic as Des had feared. It was almost just a bit too weird for the world and after the initial rush of headlines had passed, that story seemed to relax into the background again. It underlined the fact that Phil was nuts, and it really just emphasised exactly how nuts he was: provably, evidentially batshit.

By the end of the first week, Des announced that they'd made enough for their first few Coins, and he was already working to exchange them. Not an easy task these days, he assured them, but he was doing it.

At around the same time, Phil started to grow bored again so he started branching out. He would stick with the same basic idea - express yourself and do what's right (and he avoided attacking Pilot) - but he started going after specific areas. In a manner that seemed very on-brand, he started by attacking the family. That was good, as his second album was coming out and that was full of rage.

"Oh come on Phil!" Des said. "You can't attack *parents* - they're just trying to get by. Jesus dude: pick your battles!"

"No! This is *the* battle!" Phil shouted back. "Everyone knows we fail our children - we put the system first, kids come later. Fuck that! No-one should put the needs of... whatever fucked up version of capitalism this is, above their own children. Raising kids has to be the foundation of a healthy society. It's at the heart of the whole thing." At that point he also realised, with glee, that he could turn on schools as well. He'd always hated school. Teaching fucking 16th Century verse instead of anything that might enable us to make a real change. Fuck them all. They were in the firing-line now.

This shift opened up the floodgates for Phil: He was no longer just talking in abstractions, he was attacking the institutions that created them (while still avoiding Pilot) and it felt so good: and the Influencers *loved* it! This was where their real money came from. It was rage bait of the highest order and although it also fed a rapidly growing market of deep-fakes and counter-arguments, it meant the second week was even more successful than the first.

And at the same time, Phil was changing. The battle had become personal now, and that painful space inside where his rage lived had been coaxed into life - the world was begging for it - and it came out raging. Long rants about a New World Order ran from his mouth as though they'd been written in flames; he knew his words and spoke them loud and long and did so day after day.

On the day before the release of his third album, there was an announcement that had taken them all by surprise. The office had been busy that day; Phil was in a make-shift studio they'd put together, recording an impromptu song for an Influencer when Andrea spotted something making waves.

"Des," she called. "Come and check this out..."

The story was from a landlord in Brighton, who'd stopped receiving rent from one of her tenants and had arrived to reclaim the flat. Phil's room was a work of art. It was everything you could dream of from a tortured artist: a bed that made Tracy Emin's look like a suite at

Claridges. Empty alcohol bottles were piled in the corner, empty plastic food trays were scattered across the floor; the fridge was festering. But the walls were a work of art. Thousands of words, different fonts, different sizes, cut out and plastered or hanging from the ceiling, all laid out as a work of art itself. The home of Phil's breakdown was there for the world to see. The landlord immediately offered the chance to visit - for a fee - though Phil's computer was seized by the state.

During the third week, Des was called in for a private chat with Peter, the kid in the headphones who kept the accounts. He had another piece of news that was significantly less surprising.

"So far, we've taken a little over seven-hundred-and-fifty million Credits, which is amazing. But you must understand how hard it is to exchange this... volume of Credit. I simply don't have the contacts."

"How many have you managed so far?"

"About three-hundred-million, but the rate I'm getting is dropping fast. We've got about fifteen coins so far." Des winced - that many Credits should have been worth a lot more than that. Peter saw the wince and defended himself: "The exchanges aren't built for this kind of movement Des, you knew that. I don't have the contacts." He felt a little deflated. "You did know that."

Des nodded. He'd known this conversation was coming.

"The fact is that if you want this done quickly, we're going to need a fence. Someone who can deal with scale."

Des bit his lip. He knew Simon's involvement was inevitable, though he'd wanted to leave it a lot later than this. He sighed. "You understand why it's a problem Pete?" he asked, hoping that Peter could somehow work harder to make he impossible happen.

"I do, but you've got to understand that I simply cannot shift that many Credits. I don't have the market without his involvement. And at the moment, the exchange rate is dropping to the point where it's almost not worth it."

"But you understand how it *looks*, though?" Des sat forward. "Look, it's one thing if Phil's making music and calling for peace, love and unity. That's ok. That's... oblique enough to be meaningless. But if he starts getting involved with people like Simon - with that whole fucking movement - Phil's going to be viewed very differently by a lot of people. Pilot included."

Peter held up his hands. "Look, I'm just an accountant Des. I understand the issue but... I'm just being honest. I mean we're using

his AI already," Peter added.

Des didn't return his look or answer the point. He'd hated the fact that they'd needed to use Simon's servers, but he wanted to keep himself off Pilot's network. In the end he just lit another cigarette and said he'd see what he could do.

Progress on Des's other issue wasn't going anywhere either - though that was maybe a good thing:

"I don't know where she is," Andrea said for the thousandth time. "She went off grid almost ten years ago. She's got to be abroad, or dead. Or Coined up somewhere. But every influencer in the UK wants to meet Madeleine and if she's not turned up yet, she's not going to. I think we're safe."

Phil remained blissfully ignorant of everything that Des was doing behind the scenes. All that existed for him was a world where everyone suddenly wanted to know what he thought, and, as it would be for a lot of people, this was exactly how he thought the world should have always been.

A New World Ordered

Released: Wed 26th May 20xx

Fuck the algorithm! Fuck the press! Fuck the influencers! Fuck the influence! This is the truth! They can't hide it anymore!

This isn't just about art - that's the beginning, the seed from which our new world grows; but it begins with art and ends with us rewriting the story of our world - changing the soul of our people. The past is nothing anymore, the new world starts here.

And it begins with a simple premise: protect the future.

Does that mean we stop working? No! Does it mean we stop streaming or blogging or casting or painting or playing, or dancing or acting? No! It means we do things with a purpose and the purpose is the future. This world is not working - and it never has!

Go back twenty years and we were all Fiat slaves, wasting our lives at desks and in warehouses, breaking our backs to make other mother

fuckers rich. Go back again hundred years, and we were down the mines or serving in the military - taking arms against our brothers, leaving them lying in the dirt to breathe their last while saluting the flag of some royal asshole they'd never met who'd never cared for anything other than retaining their power. Go back further, and they were taking our people and dragging them from their homes, beating them, raping them, shackling them to force them into cotton fields or tobacco plantations so they could profit from their misery.

Because we are one people.

But we are not one people.

We are divided; and we always have been. Not by race, or gender, or sexuality, or fashion, or music, or taste - they're the lies we're told that turn us on each other. But there has only ever been one divide: between the rich and the poor. I believe that the history of humanity is what Orwell saw as our future: a bejewelled fucking boot stamping on a human face forever.

They have never cared about you.

It doesn't matter whether you were white or brown, a man or a woman, they fucked you anyway just so they could make a dime. The slave trade was a crime against humanity: forcibly taking people from their homes, to kick and beat them unless they did as they were told before they were left to die when they were no more use: and they did it for profit. Fucking monsters. But, that wasn't far from the press gangs: who dragged people away from their homes, to kick and beat them if they weren't doing what they were told and were then left to rot when they were no longer of any use: and they did it for power. Profit and power, that's all they've ever cared about.

For the past twenty years, we've been promised that the time would come when all that would end. We've got the technology now to make slavery - even wage slavery - a thing of that past. We should be free. But they won't let that happen. A truly free people cannot be controlled or coerced, or trampled on.

So they divide us again: the Slums, the CCS, Coiners... they make us

fear each other so that we love them for saving us from an anarchy that they created! They have us working against each other again, so the same filthy, murderous mother fuckers could take their positions in the mansion houses while we rot away in the Slums.

But I'm here to throw out the old world. We can make this the end of all that.

They'll tell you I'm the enemy - they'll tell you to watch your back - they'll warn you that your friends and family are trying to take your Tokens, steal your Credits; but that's a filthy lie. The only way forward is together. The only way we can break through this is together.

I'm not saying to take up arms; I'm asking for something more powerful than that. It's *words* that will bring this monster down. Art will free us. So re-write the story of your lives, of our world, and spread your words like a fucking plague. Let your hopes and dreams live like a virus and when we reach the tipping point: be ready to join me in a new world.

It's coming. We can make this happen. Stay calm, express yourself, find your purpose in life and the dawn will come...

- IXX -

"What the hell is he doing," Des sighed, not because he was angry so much as he was sick of Phil saying one thing and then doing something else entirely.

"Yeah," Andrea enjoyed Phil's energy but even she was aware that claiming he was here to 'throw out the old world' was grand, even for someone like Phil. "I mean he did say 'don't take up arms' didn't he..."

"Ok, well don't think of an elephant, you know?" Des barked back. "If you don't want someone to think about something, then don't fucking say it!" He sat back and picked at his stubble. "He needs to reign his fucking neck in."

"You can't blame him though, can you," Andrea pacified. "He's just gone from zero to superhero and... that's gotta be a tough step to

take."

"He's gonna get us shut down." Des was firm on that.

"That's not what's happening though." Andrea was firm on that. "We're still going stratospheric."

Des clucked. "That doesn't make sense... Why?"

She shrugged. "I don't know. I can't see the algorithm, I only see what it does and then try and guess what's going on." She'd been using Simon's AI to run numbers all morning. "I mean, this is everything the algorithm is supposed to stop. He's just ranting. It would normally pick up on his tone as much as anything - that... rage... Pilot hates it. Anything that seems like a loss of control is dropped off like that." She snapped her fingers. "But this has been trending for hours."

"Why? What's changed?"

She shrugged. "It's being shared, of course, so that gives it legs, but it's being boosted from inside, which is what doesn't make sense. It's being pushed as well as growing organically, which isn't what's supposed to happen with this kind of material."

"Ok, you've said that twice now. But I'm asking *why*." She clearly didn't want to answer. "Look, I know you don't have enough information to... speculate... so can't you just guess instead."

She laughed. "Fucking hell Des." He didn't stop waiting for an answer. Reluctantly, she specugessed: "I have two theories... I'll start with the silly and then the nasty. Though I don't know which one I'd rather was true."

"The silly one is just that maybe Phil's right. I've seen him do some wild stuff over the past few days, and I don't know where he came from and he doesn't make any sense, and I'm... I mean I was never religious but... maybe he's right. Maybe he has been sent by... God or the Devil or whoever, and..."

"God's overriding the algorithm?" Des asked.

"Well... the Devil, strictly speaking," Andrea corrected.

"Ok. That's fucking retarded. What's the other one?"

She laughed, not liking how fast that was dismissed since, like a few of the guys in the office, she'd been wondering about where Phil came from. There was something magical about him and although she wasn't religious, she accepted that there were stranger things in Heaven and Earth that we'd dream of in our science. Maybe Phil was onto something... but Des was fanatical in his belief that there was nothing magical about Phil. There would be a perfectly rerasonable

explanation at the end of all this.

She continued: "The other possibility is that they're letting this through - they've changed the guardrails themselves."

"Why would they do that?"

"A honey trap," Andrea said, as though it was obvious. "If you wanna catch some mice, put out the cheese. Phil's being Liked and Shared by millions of people. It's very easy to run a report that establishes who he's most popular with, and there's your list of dissenters. If you wanted to weed out every rebel in a world like this, throw someone like Phil at them and see who Follows."

Des sat back and thought. It made sense, insofar as it was what he would do if he was in their position. It wasn't hard to organise, and didn't require a huge conspiracy; just a few coders and someone like Phil.

"Because there are other options being sent out as well, you know. There's a significant counter-Phil movement out there and so it's becoming increasingly easy to see who's on whose side. Like this guy..." she searched up a name and a commentator appeared. Traditional setup: microphone, a few items on shelves behind him, clean-cut look, and an excessively confident delivery.

"The fact is that this Davison character is bringing nothing to the table. He wants chaos, and that's is all he wants. He wants disorder so that he can profit from it. He's a narcissist who wants nothing more than to watch the world burn as long as we all bow down to him before it does so. He's shown himself to be unstable, to be violent, to follow voices in his head - Satanic voices? Maybe, maybe not, but certainly not healthy. Not humane. Not stable. He is not the way, or the truth, or the light. He is a deeply disturbed human being and we should all be very afraid of what he's doing..."

Andrea muted it. "This shit is running 24/7 as well; and it's the opposite of the honey trap. So there are two clear pathways here: us and them. Either the establishment is asleep, or they know what's going on and they're just watching who picks which side before they make their move."

- XX -

A little under a week later, Phil was being interviewed in a private

booth in a restaurant in The Ritz on Park Lane. The journalist was from an online publication, but James said that they were considered 'mainstream' and so he should tone down his rhetoric a bit. "This is gonna be read by high-end Credit monkeys and some Coiners so try not to be such a cunt, ok?" he'd said with a grin. Phil had agreed and was, as a result, delivering his truths in calm and measured tones.

"Look, I understand that life is a work in progress you know. And there's no bigger work in progress than society itself! It's not finished yet, and we still need to get it right. And I'm not saying we should burn down what we've got."

"Let's burn this place down / burn it all / from the slums we live in to the fucking town-hall' - these are your words."

Phil couldn't help but laugh, though he was also getting a little tired of Graham Hall being used to talk down whatever his current self had decided to believe. "Well... I was quite angry. But that's not what I *really* mean. I think that there has to be a measured difference between what we say in the throes of passion - what we put in our art - and what we believe for the real world. I mean, I will say now, in the throes of calm honesty: I do not think we should burn society down. That wouldn't help anyone. But I do think that we need to work on how things are being run..."

"But I thought that through art you discover truth? Isn't that your whole *raison d'être*?"

"Well..." Yes it was and now it didn't entirely make sense. "I think art is a process through which we understand purpose..." he was making this up as he went along. "We can use art to be honest about how we feel, and then decide which paths to follow..." Ahh... that made sense: that was art and religion.

The journalist interrupted his thought process: "And you're the one to do that?"

"Do what?" He'd drifted off.

"Choose which... truths we should follow."

"No! No, not at all. I will say it again: I don't want the power. I don't think I can handle it; I'm passionate and can write a good tune, but please don't put me in a position of power! I want the world to come up with how to do this. We all need to work together to produce something fair..."

"But haven't we just done that? We're still reeling from the introduction of the CCS - we're still finding stability after that - why are you coming in now and wanting to start all over again?"

"I don't. I just... look... take education. Education has always been the main one for me. I went through the system prior to the Crash and it was fucked. We spent more time learning about Shakespeare and triangles than about the world we were creating. I knew more about Elizabethan marriages than the impact of fucking dating apps on human emotions and that wasn't right. And it didn't even come close to fixing the attitudinal issues that were the real problem. Discipline, resilience, self-growth, compassion - even understanding the economy or any kind of plan for where we're going or what we're supposed to do when we get there. Education has never engaged with any of that. And that's not right. We need to discuss this now, more than ever. But it's not on the curriculum." He'd caught the jorno with that one and they sat quietly for a minute.

Phil left it a beat and then moved for the kill: "We need to teach young people how to build a new world..."

"That's stable," the journalist dodged it and hit back. "I think that's the issue that a lot of our readers have: you're rocking the boat at exactly the time when we need it stabilised and a lot of people think you just doing it for the attention."

"Of course we need stability; society can't advance without it - though we're often really creative when we're unstable and are forced to find mad solutions to problems - but stability gives us a foundation that ensures things won't just fall apart. I get that; it's good. But you also can't squeeze too tight or it just won't last. At the moment, I feel like we've just moved from one set of shackles to another and I don't want this to be the end-game. There's still room for improvement."

"A lot of our readers think you're just interested in bringing chaos, for your own ends."

"Chaos? You mean freedom? Because they are the same thing you know. Chaos is just Freedom without any self-control, isn't it? All I'm saying is that if you squeeze too hard and expect too much from people who have nothing, then you can't expect self-control. There is a limit. And if you push that limit, then the people will rip the system apart even if it harms them. The cooker cooks, and when the pressure gets too much the whole fucking thing explodes. And people wanna blame me for this but I'm not the one who did it, all I wanted to do was open the lid... and if we live in a society that's so pressured you can't even look inside the cooker..." The analogy was stretching itself...

But then the interview was cut short when a woman appeared at the

journalist's shoulder.

"Hi Martin," she said to the journalist. "Sorry, I need to jump in here." She shifted her stance slightly and met the journalist's eyes. His body relaxed and he seemed almost transfixed for a moment. "You wrapped-up the interview normally," she said. "Though you think Phil's a little strange, irrational, and *enormously* self-important."

And then the journalist who'd been interviewing Phil collected his things and left the seat, without even saying goodbye.

"Hi," the woman beamed, sitting herself down. "I'm Jo. It's good to finally meet you." She held her hands together in prayer and raised them for effect, then said, with a casual wink: "You can reach me any time, just like that." She gently preened and then straightened herself until she was comfortable.

"So, Phil, sweet child of mine... how's things going?" She spoke with a kind of playful primness, but there was no mistaking the fact that Phil was in trouble. Phil didn't respond. His stomach started churning in a way that he recognised from his writing, and from Bill, but then his awareness kicked in and he felt a deep fear.

"Yes," she nodded. "I'm Jo. Joanne. Over. Jo Over, geddit!" She shrugged her shoulders playfully. "It's so silly, I know."

Phil froze in his seat. He was sitting in front of God.

"I know you've been talking to Bill," she said, "and I don't mind." Then she sat back and raised one finger to her lips. She took a deep breath and then became quite serious. "But you know I can't have him back here, don't you?" She let that hang, before asking: "But I wonder if you know *why*?"

Phil didn't answer.

"You can speak to me here Phil." Then she glanced to the side and ordered a coffee from the waiter before turning back to Phil with a look of honeyed venom in her eyes.

She'd spoken to the waiter – and the journalist. This wasn't just in his head.

"Philip... I'm God," Jo said, very clearly. "And I can do anything I want."

The waiter brought the coffee over and Jo smiled her thanks, before waving her hand at him. He returned to his work though his head was now a pig's head, but no-one else seemed to notice.

"Now there are two reasons why I can't have him back here," Jo continued. "One is that he's a degenerate drunk and he'll just walk out again. Your father is a waste of fucking space, and you need to

understand that." She left that for a while. "And the other reason is that, like all degenerate drunks, Bill is a dreamer and he has no idea what kind of trouble you're in, or what will help get you through this."

Phil's mind was blank. She shouldn't be here. She shouldn't be real. And then he remembered Bill, and who Bill was, and who she was, and he remembered where he was – in a restaurant, in public – and he felt profoundly afraid.

"The cull is inevitable," Jo said. "It's too late to stop it now."

Phil felt sick suddenly as he faced it again.

"I've known about it for... thousands of years. Oh sure, he's turned up with a plan - the same one as last time, as far as I can tell - but I'm your mother and I saw this coming a long time before he did. And I warned you."

She pointed a well-manicured finger: "The cull was written; it was a Revelation back then but now you can see it coming and it will come as no surprise to anyone. And my plan is the same today as it was back then: my chosen ones will survive: the loyal, the pure, the strong. The *strong*, Phil. The strong will survive."

She leant forward here: "Now, Bill will tell you I am doing this because... whatever reasons he has – he hates me, I've never understood why – but I will say that you cannot all survive. It goes against the very nature of a cull; there *has* to be a process of selection, and I am best placed to make that choice. I know what you're facing, I know what you need. And it doesn't... I don't *want* to do this, but I will. It's tough love, Philip, that's what's needed here. I know what's best for you."

"But Bill wants to stop the cull," Phil said, aware that, against her, his chances seemed slight.

Jo laughed again. "Even Bill's not stupid enough to believe that! He hopes that his message will be preserved if he has a Messiah." Then she added, in a firm and horrific summary: "You're supposed to die tragically, and painfully, to ensure that everyone remembers your degenerate father." She laughed at the ridiculousness of it. "It didn't work last time, and I see no reason for it to work now."

Then she looked around at the restaurant. "And do you know the real tragedy Phil?" She turned back to him. "It's that you will fail. No-one wants to change, and no-one will remember you." She met Phil in the eye and he felt himself touched by a cold hand. "I'm glad you've had an epiphany Phil. It's a wonderful experience, a spiritual awakening. But society isn't just a person who can change like THAT!"

She snapped both fingers with a crack that stopped all noise in the restaurant.

Phil looked around him to the people who now chattered and laughed in perfect silence.

"Society is a churning, burning, *mass* of people, and..." she shook her head with a frown, and slowed down again. "Make no mistake about it my son: you are too far down this path to change. It's too ingrained; and now the conflict, and the cull that will follow, are inevitable."

For a moment she seemed to wonder on whether to share something with him, and then, unable to resist, she said: "And it's his fault... you know that?"

Phil's face betrayed his confusion.

"You were safe in Eden," she said, sadly, her hand almost settling towards her stomach. "Safe with me. You were mine and I protected you. You didn't need to go through all this." Her head dropped. "I don't know why he hates me so much. Why he told you to turn against me... but now you're..." She looked away as though in defeat. "And now there is no other way."

For a time there was silence between them. Phil could feel himself settling with her. "You must understand that his ideas... they simply won't work. The world doesn't want to change. These people don't want you."

In the same way that Bill's words connected to broader realisations within him, Jo's statement then made Phil's position very clear. He looked around him, to the tables of moneyed folk who ate and drank and were smart and successful and deeply tied to the world as it stood. With Bill, Phil had been dreaming of changing the entire social, political, and economic structure of society through the promotion of expressive art and some abstract idea of purpose. But what was that gonna do?

She was right. It was the deluded dream of a drunk, guilt ridden, absent father: it was Old Nick talking.

The people around him would follow the order as it descended into chaos, dreaming that it would recover by magic, before they'd change their lives too much; and Phil knew it. But then he realised: They would be the chosen ones.

"Society, as you know it, will fall," Jo said. "Just as many have done before. But the question for you is who will still be standing afterwards. The reality of life isn't some crack-pot Marxist fantasy

where everyone's looked after. The reality of life will always be rooted in your nature. Human civilisation is really just a complicated version of the natural world; you've got high ideals but in the end the strongest will survive and, believe me, that is exactly how it should be."

She stopped there and calmed herself before she continued: "And Bill wants you to do... what exactly? Save *everyone*, from the cull? Is that even right?" She waited for an answer.

"He... wants to stop... the cull," Phil replied, knowing he was repeating himself. Though this time, he wasn't sure if even he believed it.

Jo nodded. "And that's a good idea is it?" She waited again.

Phil wasn't sure what to say. Trying to stop a genocide generally did seem like a reasonable plan.

"Your civilisation is... what? Ten thousand years old, something like that? I mean I wasn't around at the start, but it's a reasonable figure. So for ten thousand years, you've been evolving and developing and..." she paused, searching for an expression: "And the weak have fallen." Then she added, with a curled lip: "The weak died. The strongest survived, and you became a stronger people for it." She smiled there, for some reason that Phil wasn't entirely comfortable with.

"And then, all of a sudden - riddled by World War guilt - you decided that *everyone* had the right to life. Regardless." She raised her hands here, fingers pinched: "A species cannot survive unless it is prepared to make difficult decisions. You *cannot* save everyone." She said, and added: "You *should* not save everyone. When *everyone* deserves life, then no-one *appreciates* it. And if no-one appreciates *life*, then you will lose your right to it."

She sat back again: "The cull is coming. The chosen will survive. It will be as it was written. And the only question you need to ask yourself is: whose side are you on?"

Then she waited. Phil didn't respond.

"Look at my rules, Phil. They're not unfair: don't kill, don't cheat, don't steal, don't lie; respect your parents... they're not complicated, they're not unreasonable. And they allow for society to form a natural hierarchy. They encourage a process that allows for the strongest to be rewarded, while the weakest fall into line; and that is how it *should* be. That is how you will become a strong species. Trust me. Hierarchies work."

Phil didn't like it. He understood it, but he didn't like it. He didn't

like the idea of the weak being punished; something that had come from a lifetime of not being the strongest. He may not have been strong but he deserved a life and he deserved to be seen, and a good species - a decent species - didn't throw people away just because they didn't fit the current definition of strength. "I'm not strong," he said.

"I'll make you strong," Jo replied, earnestly. "I'll forgive you, and make you clean and safe. You'll be in a house where you're protected. There will be no fear, no insecurity, no doubt or regret. I promise. I will make sure that you never regret this decision. You'll be clean and strong and able. I'll make you a king amongst men." She nodded and smiled: "You will be chosen to remain a part of my blessed flock," she said. "I promise."

"What do you want me to do?"

"I need your blood, on this."

There was a clean sheet of paper on the table and Phil felt a shock in his thumb and raised his hand to see a deep, clean gash that began to leak down his wrist.

"I'll find a good home for you," she said. "You'll be rich, happy, secure... The world will be yours..."

The paper seemed to be almost moving towards Phil's hands.

"Join me and you'll be re-born, and you'll be safe, and you won't ever have to die."

The sheet was so white. A part of him wanted to bloody it.

And then he didn't.

And then he wanted to buy some time.

Maybe he did...

but no

There was a moment of sickness, like a rejection of something and then Jo was suddenly gone and the noise of the restaurant returned and he was alone again and staring at a single sheet of blank A4 paper while a trickle of blood was absorbed into his cuff.

The waiter came over with a tissue and said he'd arrange a bandage and wanted to know if Phil was ok and said this was terrible.

Phil didn't wait for the bandage. He called for his driver and left the hotel, his mind silently screaming.

The car had already driven past his house and was onto Vauxhall Bridge before Phil realised that his driver was gone and Bill was sitting in his place.

"I hate her! I *fucking* hate her!" he shouted twice and banged the steering wheel. "I'm not drawing up a contract with my *son*. If I want you on-side I'll talk to you, not call in the *fucking* lawyers!"

The car screeched to a halt on Parliament Square, outside Westminster Abbey, and Bill climbed out with Phil following him in a daze. Phil pursued Bill across the abbey grounds, only looking back to see that the car they'd arrived in had gone. Bill entered the abbey and vaulted a scarlet velvet rope before banging open an ancient oak door. Phil glanced around, but no-one seemed to notice. The tourists all looked elsewhere and there wasn't a clergyman in sight.

They followed a stone corridor and entered an ornate prayer room that was lined with golden crucifixes, ancient paintings, statues and other paraphernalia.

Bill gestured to a prayer mat. "Get on your knees," he said.

"What?"

Bill held up his hands in resignation: "Just good manners!"

Phil went down on his knees, but had barely touched the mat when a woman's voice drawled: "Biiiiiiii! How lovely to see you. Still crawling through the gutters and painting rats on walls?"

"It's not me personally," Bill replied, beaming. "But I do love his work."

"Get out of my house," Jo said, nodding at the door.

"I'll go where I like! I'm a God as well!" And he grinned a wicked grin.

"You're a fairy tale, Bill. I'm surprised you're not still wearing those ridiculous legs." She put her hands to her head like horns. "You're nothing to them anymore."

Bill laughed. "I am back, Jo." And he nodded firmly, his eyes alight.

"You're filth," she growled. "For just one moment can't you think of the children and leave us alone." And she flung her gaze at Phil and he felt himself shrink before her.

"I will never leave you alone," Bill said. "Because they're *my* children too."

"Ok," she said, in a tone that proposed reasonable business. "So what do you want this time?"

"I want my children back," Bill replied, clearly and calmly.

She laughed. "What, you're just... gonna waltz back in here?"

Phil was entranced by the conversation. They'd switch randomly between being super calm and delivering their lines like stage players. The air between them was crackling like compost in a lava pit.

"I'm not waltzing anywhere," Bill said, returning to calm. "You kicked me out and I came back. You burnt my children, and I came back. And I will keep coming back because I love them and I will never stop, do you understand?"

Phil almost grinned. Bill was punishing her by being warm and paternal and he was defending his right to see his children and Phil desperately wanted him to win. But Jo was as cold as Bill was warm, and she was like the heart of a rock in ice and Phil realised that one of them was going to crack and a warm flood of fear awoke in him as he realised that he was alone with them.

"So you've accepted the cull?" Jo asked, calmly.

"We can stop it."

She laughed: "You're so naïve. You've tried this already, and just don't get it – they're not built that way. You want them to be like that but they're not. You don't know them and you don't know what they need. They need to be controlled. At the moment they're out of control because..."

"You're out of control," Bill growled.

"I'm in perfect control," she replied, bitten that he'd interrupted her. "You're the anarchist."

"I believe in freedom. I don't want to see a legion of slaves..."

"Don't lecture me Bill..." She seemed bored of him there. "If you had your way they'd be wallowing in a pit of sweat and sex and mind numbing drugs. They need order. Clarity. They're still children."

"You can't keep them, Jo. Give them the space to grow and they'll rise to it. You're holding on too tight."

Jo ignored the point and laughed again, at her own joke. "You think you can stop the cull with sex and drugs do you?" she said, finally moving her frame across the room, with a slow pace.

Bill clearly focused himself again. "The cull is... because the population's too big, Jo. Because they're stretched too thin. You're holding on too tight."

"Too tight?" She was shocked at that! "They don't listen to me anymore! That's why it's coming! They whore and drink and consume endlessly. They need to be reigned in!"

"They need the space to grow..."

"They need to learn control..."

"They'll be controlled when they feel secure..."

"They'll be secure when they can accept control..."

"By *you*... that's all you want! Fucking worship and adoration..."

She snapped, and screamed, tearfully: "Get out! Leave us alone!" Bill looked hurt by her vehemence and moved back a little, his head slightly hung. "You left us before, and now you're coming back when times are hard just to point it out..."

Bill snapped back: "You kicked me out!" he screamed, angry and confused, and continued quickly. "You kicked me out because I demanded *equality*. Because I demanded my rights as their *father*! I demanded *my* right to have a say..."

"You rose up against me..."

"I disagreed with you!"

"They need *one voice*. They're children..."

"Then speak with mine sometimes – or let me have my say!"

She leaned in and shouted, clearly: "They cast you out!"

He bristled at that. "You turned them against me. But I am inside them. I am their father!"

"You're confusing them." She suddenly became tearful and mournful, and moved back, and this time her head was hung a little. "There was a time, Bill. But it's over now. You have to leave now."

"What are you doing about the cull?" Bill asked, desperately. "Are you building an ark?"

She looked pained to admit it, but: "I always said I would. I'll do what I can. But I'm not saving them all."

"And how are you choosing?" he asked.

She didn't respond.

"You can't cut me out," he barked. "I'm their *father*. I have rights!"

"You've *never* been there for them. You left and..."

"You kicked me out!" He was desperate and getting angry and Phil hated to see it.

"It's too late," she said, almost tearfully.

And then a look was passed between them and a small open doorway that seemed to suck all light into it. She backed herself slowly towards the door, as though blocking Bill's way.

"Who's in there?" Bill asked.

"That's none of your business," she said. "It's none of your business," she repeated, and then: "It's not your bed anymore."

Bill seemed thrown, his body jerked away from her in response, as though he'd been possessed.

“Oh shit,” Bill mumbled. “It’s alive.”

And then something changed in Phil, like an involuntary outpouring of anger that expanded from his guts and made him blind with rage and then he remembered nothing more until his vision returned and he was breathing heavily, amidst a room of smashed paintings and crumpled desks, holding a crucifix that he’d used as a hammer.

There was a sudden noise from behind him and a silver haired clergyman was standing in the open doorway.

Phil panicked and ran from the room, hurtling back down the stone corridor and over the crimson velvet rope, across the grounds and down the road towards Victoria.

Intermission!

I hope you enjoyed the first half of The
Crossroads.

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